

THE SAEREN CHRONICLES

Also by Post Peleos

THE SAEREN CHRONICLES

Book One: Hazel Academy

Book Two: The Resistance

Book Three: The Weight of the Source

The trilogy is complete.

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Writing adult fantasy romance as

SØREN STROMBERG

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THE SAEREN CHRONICLES

Book Three: The Weight of the Source

Post Peleos

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Post Peleos

*For my family —
it's not always the one you are born into,
but the one who accepts you for who you are,
flaws and all.*

CHAPTER ONE

What the World Became

The almond tree at the bottom of the garden had flowered twice since they came to the valley, and both times Viridia had felt it before she saw it.

That was the new thing, and a year on she was still learning to carry it. She would be at the window with her hands in dishwater, or out on the step shelling beans into a bowl, and somewhere under the ordinary business of her own body a small green pressure would open, faint and certain, the way you know a lamp has been lit in a far room by the change in the dark rather than by the light itself. A thing had begun to live that had not been living a moment before. The first spring it had only been the tree, the buds breaking, and she had stood with her wet hands dripping and not understood for a while what she was feeling or why it should make her want, absurdly, to sit down. The second spring she had known at once, and known too, for half a breath under the green pressure, a cold somewhere very far off at the edge of the feeling, a place the warmth thinned toward and did not reach, that she did not have a name for and did not go looking for. Some things you leave lying where they lie; she left it. She had said nothing to anyone. She had finished shelling the beans.

She was sixteen now. She kept having to remind herself of it, rechecking the number like a sum done right that she

still did not quite believe. The girl who had walked out of the burning school had been fourteen and had felt forty. The year had not given the forty back, but it had given her the number, and she held it the way she held the small true things, somewhere it would not be lost.

The valley was called Wend, or had been, before there was no longer anyone whose business it was to call places things. It sat a day and a half by the slow southern line from anywhere that had ever mattered, a scatter of stone houses along a stream, terraced gardens climbing the slope behind them, an orchard, a mill that still turned. They had not chosen it so much as stopped in it. After the east road, after the long walk with the rescued and the wounded and the ones who had nowhere left to go, there had come a morning when the column simply did not get up, and the valley had let them stay, and slowly the staying had become a life. Now there were perhaps two hundred of them folded into a place that had held forty, and the gardens had been doubled, and a thing that was almost a town had grown up in the gap between what the valley was and what they needed it to be.

It was not hidden. That was the strangest part, still, a year on. There were no wards over Wend, no box of invisible air, no three men spending themselves to keep a forest looking too still. There was no need. The thing they had been hiding from was gone. The thing they had been hiding from had been a world, and the world had changed, and they had changed it, and now there was nothing to do but live inside the change and find out, a day at a time, what it had cost.

* * *

Raizen was in the orchard when she came down with the bean bowl, and he was standing on two legs, and she still could not look at it without something in her chest going tight and glad and afraid all at once.

He had been human for a year and he was not good at it yet. He stood the way a thing stands that has only recently agreed to have a particular number of limbs, very straight, very still, attending to his own balance as a separate task from whatever else he was doing, and what he was doing this morning was looking at an apple. It sat in one hand, and he turned it slowly. The change had given him dark hair and the height of a tall young man, and the eyes that had been lightning when he was a dragon had dimmed down to a dark and ordinary brown, a human brown, so that the only place the prismatic thing he had been still showed was in the attention behind them, and he studied the apple with the whole of that ancient attention as though it might at any moment explain itself.

"It is the same fruit," he said, without turning. He always knew where she was. The bond told him, the way it told her, a warmth that no longer had to stretch over miles. "Last autumn it was on the ground and the wasps had it, a small sweetness gone to rot, and I understood it. This spring it was a flower and I understood that. Now it is this. Between the two. Hard and sour and full of a thing that has not happened yet." He turned it again. "I do not understand the middle. The middle is the part you people live in."

"You could just eat it," Viridia said.

"I could." He did not. He set it back on the branch with great care, balancing it in the fork of two twigs where it had no business staying, and it stayed, because he had asked it to, and a faint prismatic shimmer ran off his fingers and into the wood and was gone. He was always doing that. He could not stop being what he was; he had only changed its shape. "Eating it would end the question. I am in no hurry. I have noticed that this is the chief difference between us. You are all of you in a terrible hurry, and you have so much less time than I do. It seems the wrong way around."

She came and stood beside him under the tree, and for a moment neither of them said anything, and the orchard hummed its low green hum under the floor of her awareness, every tree a small steady presence, alive and unhurried, and she let herself rest in it, because the orchard was one of the few places where the source-sense was only sweetness and held no count.

"You are doing the thing," Raizen said.

"What thing."

"The listening." He had no other word for it and neither did she. He turned the dark new eyes on her, the human ones, and the look that came out of them was the old one, kind and missing nothing, the look that had not needed changing because it had never lived in the color of the eye in the first place. "You go somewhere behind your own face. I felt it the first spring and did not know it. Now I know it. The tree opens and you go to meet it. What is it like, little one, to feel a thing be born?"

She thought about how to say it truly, because he was the one creature she did not bother to say things falsely to.

"It is like a window opening in a house you didn't know had that room," she said. "Just for a second. And then the room is part of the house and you can't find the wall it used to be." She looked at the apple he had asked to stay. "And the other one is the same. Exactly the same, in reverse. A window closing. A room you can't get back to."

"The other one," Raizen said.

"When something dies."

He was quiet. The bond between them lay warm and open and carried, just then, more than either of them said. He knew about the other one. He had been there at the source when she took up the weight, had been the anchor at the far end of it, hand over hand, the only thing that had kept her a person while the whole living weave of the world

poured through her and tried to become her. He knew what she had agreed to without quite being told the price. They had neither of them said the word *forever* about it, but they both lived in the shape the word made.

"How many," he asked. He did not ask it lightly. "In a day. How many of the other one."

"I don't count," she said, which was the first untrue thing she had said to him all morning, and he knew it, and let it stand, because some lies are a kindness a person does themselves and a friend lets them keep.

* * *

The truth, which she did not say in the orchard and did not say anywhere, was that she had tried not to count and had failed, the way you fail not to hear a clock in a quiet house.

It had come back to her slowly, the sense, the way the sight had come back. The rebirth had spent her to the wick. For weeks after the cavern she had been blind in the old way, her mana-sight gone dark, the world flattened to the plain dull surface that ordinary people lived on their whole lives and never grieved because they had never known otherwise. She had grieved it. She had not told anyone that either. To have stood in the source and felt every living core in the world burning at once, the whole vast chord of it, and then to wake the next morning to a body that could not see the warmth in a candle, was a loss she had no name for and no right to, because she had chosen it, and a cost you choose is not a cost you are allowed to mourn out loud.

Then, in the autumn, it had begun to return. A flicker first. A warmth at the edge of the eye that was gone when she turned to it. Then more. Through the winter it had come back in pieces, the sight unfolding itself a layer at a time, and with it, unasked, the other thing, the deeper thing, the source-sense that was not sight at all but something

underneath it. Because she was not only a girl who could see mana again. She was the vessel. She was tied now to the source the way the source was tied to everything, and as the channel between them opened back up, the world began to report itself to her. Quietly. Always. A pressure under the breastbone that rose when a thing was born and eased when a thing died, and never stopped, because somewhere in a world of millions a thing was always being born and a thing was always dying, and she lived now with the surf of it under everything, the long low respiration of all the living cores there were.

Mostly it was bearable because it was distant. A tide has no faces. She did not feel *who*. She felt the great soft arithmetic of it, the sum and not the names, and she had taught herself, across the winter, to let it run under her the way Wend let the stream run under its bridges, present and constant and not looked at. The cold working part of her, the part that had always done the arithmetic so the rest of her could survive the choosing, had taken the source-sense and filed it where it filed the count and the wall and the rest of both your lives, somewhere she could find it and did not have to hold.

But some of them were near. And the near ones had faces.

Old Tem in the third house up the lane, who had been failing all winter, whose core she had felt thin and gutter for a month like a lamp running dry. She had known the night he went before the knock came to the door. She had been the one to wake Alice. She had not said how she knew, and Alice, who knew her, had not asked, had only taken up her bag and gone, and afterward had sat with Viridia on the dark step and held her hand and said nothing, which was the only thing there was to say.

That was the new thing. That was what the world had become, from the inside. Not the politics of it, the leaderless capital and the broadsheets full of argument that came up the slow line a week stale, though that was real and that was coming. From the inside it was this: that a sixteen-year-old girl in a valley felt the whole of the living world breathing under her skin, and learned, a death at a time, the weight of being the place all that breathing ran toward.

* * *

Alice was at the long table behind the mill when Viridia brought the beans, and she was teaching, and Viridia stopped at the edge of the yard to watch her the way she always stopped, because watching Alice be a healer again was a thing she did not let herself take for granted.

The girl who had come out of the capital's hands, a year ago now, freed but changed, had been calm in a way that frightened everyone who had known her before. The warmth had gone out of her, or down, banked so low you could not find it. She had healed with hands that did the work perfectly and felt nothing through it, and she had smiled the smile that did not reach, and Viridia had been afraid, in the early months, that the Alice who used to talk too much and laugh at the wrong moments and have a crooked tooth she showed when she forgot to be careful had been left in a room somewhere and would not be coming back.

But warmth, it turned out, was not killed. It was only banked, and banking was a thing you could come back from, and across the year Alice had come back from it a degree at a time, the way the orchard came back, the way the sight came back, slowly and then all at once in small particular signs. The crooked tooth had reappeared in the winter, the first time she forgot to be careful, laughing at something one

of the children said, and Viridia had seen it and had to leave the room, because some kinds of relief you cannot let people watch land on your face any more than some kinds of grief.

Now Alice had four of them around the table, and they were not children. They were grown men and women of the valley, farmers, the miller's wife, a man who had driven the slow line for twenty years, and in front of each of them sat a small clay bowl of water, and Alice was teaching them to put light into it. Or to keep light out of it. Viridia could not tell, from the yard, which, and that was rather the point.

"Both," Alice was saying. "It is always both now. That is the thing your whole life told you was a lie, and it was the lie that everything was built on, and now you have to unlearn it with your hands while you are also frightened of it, which is the worst possible way to learn anything, and I am sorry, and we are going to do it anyway." She had a bowl of her own. She held her palm flat over it. "You all carry both halves now. Every one of you. The bright and the dark, the giving and the taking, and nobody asked you and nobody trained you and most of you found out you had the dark half when something went wrong. A cup that cracked. A plant that withered when you only meant to touch it. A morning the milk soured under your hand. You have learned to be afraid of half of yourselves. We are going to stop that, because a thing you are afraid of and cannot control is the most dangerous thing there is, and the only one of those two facts you can change is the second."

The miller's wife said, low, "My mother would have called the dark half a sin."

"Your mother was lied to her whole life by people who killed to keep the lie," Alice said, gently, without heat. "So was mine. It isn't a sin. It's a hand. You don't call your left hand a sin because you write with your right." She let that sit. "Now. Watch." And she lowered her palm, and the water

in her bowl went still, stiller than still, a stillness Viridia could feel from across the yard like a held breath, the small clean pull of the dark half drinking the warmth out of a thing, and then Alice turned her hand and gave it back, and the water trembled and was only water again. "Taking and giving," Alice said. "The same gift. You have had it a year. Let's make it yours."

It was the most ordinary miracle in the world, four frightened grown people learning to hold both halves of a thing over a bowl of water in a mill yard, and it was the whole of what the year had been, and Viridia stood at the edge of it with her beans and felt the thing she had felt all spring, the thing that was nearer to grief than to pride and she did not entirely understand why.

She had done this. Not the mill yard, not the patient woman with the crooked tooth. The other thing, the thing under it. Every one of those four had carried only the bright half their whole lives, or thought they did, because six hundred years ago someone had stood where she had stood and cut the world in two. And she had mended it. In a cavern, with a dragon braced at the far end of her, she had run the weave full and given every living core in the world back the half it had been robbed of, all at once, without asking a single one of them, because there had been no way to ask and no time and because she had decided, alone, that wholeness was worth more than consent.

And it was. She still believed it was. She watched the miller's wife hold a stillness over a bowl and not be afraid of it, and she believed it.

But Amber's question came up in her anyway, the way it always did now, the question Amber had asked her once at a cold fire and asked her again, sharper, the first month in the valley, the question that had grown teeth across the year. *You couldn't ask them, so you decided for them. That was the whole*

crime of the people who cut the world, that they decided for everyone. I'm not saying you were wrong. I'm asking how you tell the difference, from the inside, between you and them. Because from where I sit you can't, and that's the thing that should scare you, and I notice it doesn't.

It did scare her. She had never told Amber it scared her. She watched the miller's wife hold a stillness over a bowl and not flinch from it, and let the answer go unmade for one more day, and did not let the mill yard see her leave it unmade.

* * *

Amber found her at midday, because Amber always found her, and dropped onto the wall beside her with the boneless certainty of a creature claiming a sunny spot, and ate three of the beans Viridia had shelled without asking.

"These are raw," Amber said.

"They're for the pot."

"I know. I'm registering an objection on behalf of beans everywhere." She ate a fourth. The year had been good to Amber in the way the year was good to people who had decided, somewhere on the east road, to survive on purpose. The hollowed look was long gone. She had found, in the valley, a kind of fierce ordinary contentment that she defended with jokes the way she had once defended fear, and she had appointed herself, without anyone asking, the keeper of the one thing in Viridia she trusted no one else to keep. "You went away again. This morning, in the orchard. Raizen told me. He worries, in his big slow lizard way. He came and found me and said, *she went behind her face*, like it was a weather report. He's getting better at being a person. He's worse at it than a toddler and better at it than most adults, which is roughly where I'd put him on a good day."

"It was the tree," Viridia said. "It flowered."

"I know it was the tree. It's always the tree, or the goat that kidded last week, or old Tem, or the thing you won't tell me about that I can see you not telling me about." Amber said it lightly, and under the lightness was the flat true thing she always carried under the lightness, the thing that made her, of all of them, the one Viridia could least afford and most needed. "Here is my objection, and it is a real one, and I'm only going to make it once because nobody likes the friend who makes it twice. You feel all of it. The whole world being born and dying, all day, every day, under your skin, and you have decided, because you are you, that the correct thing to do with that is to carry it alone and shell beans and let nobody see it land on you." She looked at Viridia sidelong. "I'm not telling you to weep on me. God, no. I'd faint from the shock and you'd have to heal me and then we'd both be embarrassed. I'm telling you that *I see you carrying it*. That's the whole of what I can do, and I'm doing it, every day, whether you let me or not." She shrugged, as though it cost her nothing, which was the lie she dressed the true things in. "That's all. Objection registered. Where's the rest of the beans."

Viridia handed her the bowl. It was easier, she had found, than inventing a reason not to.

They sat on the warm wall in the noon light, and below them Wend did the thousand small things a place does to stay alive, the mill turning, the smoke going up, the children at the older rounder letters that were no longer dead, the grown people learning their own dark hands over bowls of water. One of the goats had got onto the mill roof again. Nobody seemed troubled by it. Under all of it the orchard hummed and the stream ran and the living world breathed its slow breath under Viridia's skin, born and gone, born and gone, and for a little while in the sun she let it be only

weather, the kind you live inside and do not watch, and was almost at peace, and that was when it happened.

* * *

It came from the north, and it came wrong.

She had felt deaths before, a year of them, near ones and far ones, and they all had a shape, and she knew the shape without having to spell it out, as plainly as a word in her own tongue. A death was a window closing. A core that had been burning, bright or banked, old or new, simply ceasing, the warmth going out of a room and the room becoming part of the dark. It was always sad and it was always, in its way, clean, because it was the thing cores did, the last honest thing, the going-out that made room for the coming-in. The tide breathed out. She had learned to bear it because it breathed back in.

This did not breathe out. This was pulled out.

It hit her under the breastbone and she came off the wall and onto her feet before she knew she had moved, the bowl going over, the beans scattering across the stone, Amber's voice saying her name from very far away. Somewhere north of the valley, a day off, two days, she could not yet judge the distance, a core had not gone out. It had been *drained*. She felt the difference the way you would feel the difference between a candle blown out and a candle whose flame was reached into and pulled, dragged, sucked down a hole that should not have been there, the warmth not ending but going somewhere, draining away into a place that had no business taking it, a place that was not the clean dark of death but an absence with a current in it, a thing that wanted.

It lasted perhaps three seconds. Then the core was gone, all the way gone, emptied, and the wrongness closed over the spot where it had been, and the tide breathed on around

the hole as though nothing had broken it, and Viridia stood on the wall with her heart slamming and her sight, her returning, not-yet-whole sight, blown all the way open by the shock of it, wider than it had been since the cavern.

And because it was open, she saw the thing she could not have seen a year ago.

Far to the north, at the edge of everything, where the world's warmth thinned to nothing and the abstract cold beyond it began, the place she had only ever half-glimpsed at the rebirth and named to no one, there was a flaw. A thread of the weave gone wrong. Not a door. A door was made; a door had edges; she knew what a made door looked like because she had stepped through enough of them. This had no edges. This was a place where the great seamless fabric of the living world had been pulled at until it had begun, very slightly, the smallest fraction, to *part*, and through the parting, faint and cold and certain, something on the far side was leaning in.

Then her sight, spent past what it could hold, guttered, and the far north folded back into ordinary distance, and she was a sixteen-year-old girl standing on a sunlit wall in a valley with scattered beans at her feet and a friend gripping her arm and saying her name.

"Viridia. *Viridia*. Look at me. What. What is it."

She made herself breathe. She made her face come back to the careful surface, the one that had carried her through the gates and the corridor and the cavern, because two hundred people lived in this valley and not one of them needed to see what had just gone across her. But Amber was not two hundred people. Amber was the one who had registered her objection, who saw the carrying and did the carrying of the seeing, and to Amber, this once, in a low voice with the noon sun on the scattered beans, Viridia told a piece of the truth, because the alternative was to carry this

one entirely alone and she found, standing there, that she could not.

"Someone died," she said. "North of here. A day, maybe two." She steadied her voice on the flat hard certainty that was the only thing that ever held when the rest of her would not. "And it wasn't a death, Amber. Something took them. Pulled the life out of them, all the way out, into a place I can't see the bottom of." She looked north, where there was nothing now but the green shoulder of the valley and the bright ordinary sky. "And there's a tear up there. At the edge of the world. In the part nobody can see but me." She heard herself say it and knew it was true and knew, the way the truest things always reached her first, ahead of any understanding of them, that it was the first of more than one. "It's the kind of thing I couldn't have seen a year ago. My sight wasn't back far enough." She was filing it already, without deciding to, setting it beside the count and the wall and the weight, reaching after an arithmetic she did not yet have the numbers for. "I don't know what it means."

That was the lie, the last small one, the one she let herself keep the way Raizen had let her keep the other.

She knew what it meant. She did not yet have the proof of it or the shape of it, but she had already started toward the answer, the way water starts toward the low place, before she chose to, and the answer had a current in it that ran in exactly one direction, and the direction was toward the source, and she was the source, and somewhere north of a sunlit valley a person she would never meet had been pulled out of the world toward the thing she had made of herself.

She did not say that. She picked up the bowl. She began, with steady hands, to gather the scattered beans off the stone, because it was a thing to do with her hands while the rest of her decided how much of this was hers to carry and

how much she was allowed, at last, to set down where another person could see it.

Above the valley the sky stayed bright and the mill went on turning and the four frightened grown people learned their own dark hands over bowls of water, whole now, all of them, whole the way she had made them. And to the north, at the cold edge of everything, a tear she alone could see leaned a fraction wider. Through it, patient, certain, in no hurry at all, something that was not attacking and did not need to be leaned in toward the warmth she had become.

CHAPTER TWO

The First Door That Should Not Be

She did not sleep that night, and in the morning she told them she was going north.

She told them at the long table behind the mill, where Alice had her bowls of water set out for a lesson that would not happen now, because the moment Viridia said the word *north* Alice had gone still in the particular way she went still, the stillness that had frightened everyone the first months and that Viridia had learned to read as the opposite of cold. It was not the absence of feeling. It was feeling held so carefully it made no sound. Alice put the lid back on the box where she kept the dry things, and that was her answer, and it was the only one she gave.

"A day's ride," Viridia said. "Two. I'll know the distance better when I'm closer to it."

"You'll know the distance," Amber said, from the doorway, where she had been leaning with her arms folded since before any of them came down, which meant she had not slept either. "Listen to her. *I'll know the distance better when I'm closer to it.* Like she's reading a timetable for the slow line. Like there's a station at the end of this with a tea cart." She came into the room. "What's at the end of it, Viridia. Say the true thing for once at the start of a day instead of making me dig it out of you at noon."

Viridia said the true thing.

"A tear," she said. "And whatever pulled that man's life out through it. I felt it for three seconds and then I couldn't feel it any more, and I don't know if that's because it stopped or because it finished. Those are not the same. I want to know which one it is before it's a great deal closer to here than a day's ride." She looked at the bowls of still water on the table, the lesson that would not happen. "And I want to read the tear with my own sight, near, before it widens past the place I can do anything about it. My sight only goes so far yet. I have to take it to the thing."

"And the rest of us," said Raizen.

He had come in without anyone hearing him, which he could still do, the old silence of the great body folded somehow into the new one, so that he was simply in the room where a breath ago he had not been. He stood by the cold hearth with his hands open at his sides, and the dark ordinary eyes were on her, and behind them was the attention that missed nothing.

"You said *I*," he told her. "Four times. *I'll know. I want. I have to.* You have made a long habit of the word, little one, and I have let you keep it because it cost me nothing to let you. It costs me something now." He did not raise his voice. He never did. "I will not stand in an orchard turning an apple while the thing that ate a stranger's life decides whether you are a day's ride or a morning's. The bond does not let me. It is not a thing I have decided. It is a thing I am."

"It's dangerous," she said.

"Yes," said Raizen, as though she had told him the apple was a fruit.

So it was the four of them, in the end, and that was the first lesson of the north, learned before they had gone a mile: that the word *I* had stopped being true the day a dragon set its will against the unmaking of her, and that she had simply

gone on saying it out of habit, the way you go on reaching for a railing in a house whose stairs have been moved.

* * *

They went up the slow line as far as it ran, which was not far, two stops and a long wait at the second while a man with a lantern walked the length of the train and told them, with the flat courtesy of a person who has stopped expecting his words to change anything, that the line did not go past Hallow any more, that the bridge past Hallow had been let go in the winter and no one had come to mend it, because mending bridges had been a thing the capital did and there was no longer a capital that did things. He said it without bitterness. He had a core that carried both halves now, like everyone, and Viridia could feel the dark half of it sitting unused and afraid in him the way an untrained thing sits in a person, a tool in a drawer they have decided not to open. She thanked him. He touched his cap and walked back up the train, and his lantern swung, and the train sat in the failing afternoon and did not go on to Hallow, because there was no longer anyone whose business it was to make it.

After Hallow they walked, and then they had horses, two of them, traded from a farm for the better part of what they carried, because a world that had stopped mending its bridges had not stopped wanting things it could hold. Raizen would not ride. He walked beside the horses with the long unhurried stride of a thing that had crossed greater distances on stranger legs, and the horses did not like him, and he was patient with them about it, and somewhere in the second day of walking Viridia understood that the cold she had felt at the edge of the source-sense, the cold she had filed and not gone looking for, was the direction they were walking in. It did not announce itself. It was simply that the warmth thinned as they went, the long low respiration of

living things growing fainter under her skin the further north they came, not because there was less life here but because something was drinking at the edge of it, a steady small subtraction she could feel now that she was near enough to feel anything at all.

She did not tell them that. She told them the road.

They camped the second night in a dry barn with half its roof gone, and Amber made a fire too big for the space and dared anyone to object, and Raizen sat across it from her and asked her, with the grave attention he gave to apples, why human beings made fires larger than the cold required. Amber told him it was for morale. Raizen turned the word over.

"Morale," he said. "The warmth you do not need, kept burning so the warmth you do need feels less alone." He fed a stick into it, carefully, the way he did everything. "I begin to see the use of you people."

"That's the nicest thing you've ever said to me," Amber said. "Don't ruin it." And she did not let him ruin it, and she talked over him when he tried, and Alice, banking her own small warmth across the fire, forgot herself for a moment and laughed, the crooked tooth showing, and Viridia sat back from the light of the fire that was too big and let the relief of it land where no one could see it land. She had learned that you could carry a thing easier in company even when the company did not know it was helping. That was a use of people too. She did not say so. She kept it, the way she kept the small true things, somewhere it would not be lost, and in the morning she did not tell them the warmth had thinned again in the night, and they went on north.

"It's the next valley," she said, on the morning of the third day, and she was off the horse and standing in the road before she had finished saying it, because the wrongness had come up under her breastbone again, not the

three-second shock of the first one but a low continuous pressure, a place where the world was being held open. "It hasn't stopped. It's still going. Whatever it is, it's still there, and it's still pulling."

"Then we hurry," said Amber, who had spent the journey being unbearable about everything and went quiet the instant it counted, which was the whole of who she was. "Or we don't. You're the one who can feel it. You tell us which."

"We hurry," Viridia said.

* * *

The valley had been a place where people lived. That was the first thing, and it was the worst thing, and she made herself look at it because looking at it was the price of being the one who could.

A hamlet, smaller than Wend, a dozen houses along a beck and a chapel with a fallen roof and a green where someone had been keeping geese, and it was empty in the particular way that meant it had been full very recently. There was washing on a line. There was a pot still set over a fire gone to white ash. There was a child's wooden horse in the middle of the lane, on its side, and Viridia looked at it and took it up and filed it and did not let the rest of her stop walking, because the rest of her wanted very badly to stop walking and there was no time for what the rest of her wanted.

The cores were gone. Not dead. She would have felt them die, would have felt the dozen small windows close, and she had felt nothing from this valley until she was nearly in it, which meant they had not closed. They had been emptied, the way the man three days ago had been emptied, the warmth not ending but going, drawn down and out through the place at the top of the green where the air was wrong.

It stood between two houses, where a lane should have been, and it was not a door.

She had stepped through enough made doors to know. A made portal had edges, a frame the working held in place, a clean seam between the place you left and the place you arrived, because someone had meant it, had set the Moravian to it and held the meaning steady. This had no frame and no edges and no clean anything. It was a place where the air had gone thin and then thinner and then given way, a rent perhaps the height of a man, its sides not cut but frayed, the world around it pulled toward it and stretched and worn, so that even ordinary eyes could see the wrongness, a smear in the daylight, a heat-shimmer with no heat in it. And through the smear came the cold she had been feeling for two days, pouring out slow and steady, an absence with a current in it, a thing that wanted.

And standing in the cold, in the lane, with its back to them, drinking, was the Horror.

She had no word for it and would not be given one. The reckoning part of her, which had a word for everything, which had filed the count and the wall and the weight of both their lives, reached for a word and found nothing and that was its own kind of terror, that here at last was a thing it could not file. It had a shape and the shape would not hold still in the eye. It was tall and it was not, it was a man's height of moving absence, a place where the light went in and did not come back, and where it touched the world the world went grey, the grass under it gone to ash in a slow ring, a goose at the edge of the green still half-alive and going out as she watched, its small warmth draining sideways into the thing the way water finds a drain. It made no sound. That was the part she would keep, afterward, filed where she could find it: that a thing could unmake a living world and make no sound at all doing it.

"Don't," Raizen said, very low, and she did not know which of them he was speaking to, and then she did, because Amber had drawn the long knife she carried and Raizen's open hand had closed over Amber's wrist without seeming to move through the space between.

"It eats warmth," Raizen said. "You are warm. Do not give it your warmth in a piece of steel and a piece of you behind the steel. It is not a thing you fight with the body. Look at it. It is the absence of body." The dark eyes went to Viridia and the prismatic attention came up behind them, urgent now, the only urgency she had ever seen in him. "You felt the man die. You felt this open. You are the one of us who is tied to the thing this came looking for. So I will ask you the only question that matters, and I will brace, the way I braced, and you will answer it with the thing you are and not with your hands. *What closes it.*"

And the answer was not in her, which was the terror of it. There was no working she had been taught for this. She had opened seams by meaning them and she had read the lattice and she had stood in the source and run the whole weave full, but no one had ever set down for her, in Moravian or in plain words, what you do with a place in the world that has worn through. She had only the thing she was, which was the vessel, tied to the source the way the source was tied to everything. And a worn place was a place that had been emptied of the source, and she carried, somewhere under her breastbone, more of it than any living person had ever held.

So she would give it. She did not know if it would work. She knew only that the tear was an absence and that she was, of all the things in the world, the one most full of the opposite, and that a hamlet of emptied cores and a child's horse on its side in the lane did not leave her the luxury of being sure first.

* * *

She did not run at it. There was nothing to run at.

She went instead to the tear, to the frayed rent in the daylight between the two houses, because the Horror was the water and the tear was the drain and you do not bail a flooding room while the pipe is still open. She crossed the green at an angle, away from the thing, and it did not turn, because it was busy with the goose and with the slow grey ring spreading out from where it stood, and Amber went wide on the far side drawing its eye that was not an eye, putting herself in danger on purpose with the boneless certainty of a creature that had decided somewhere on the east road to be useful at exactly the cost of herself and no less, and Raizen, Raizen did the thing he was.

He let the human shape go a little. Not all the way. There was no room in a lane between two houses for the whole of what he was, and a year of feet had not taught him how to be it by halves, so what came off him was not the dragon but the light of it, the prismatic thing he could not stop being and had only changed the shape of, rolling off his open hands and into the air in a long banner of color, every element at once and none of them, a warmth so loud and bright and *present* that the thing of absence turned toward it at last, because a thing that hungers for warmth cannot help but turn toward the brightest warmth in the field. It turned from the goose. It turned from Amber. It came toward Raizen, slow and certain and in no hurry, drinking the color as it came, and the color guttered where it touched, and Raizen poured out more, and his face, his new and human face, went grey at the edges the way the grass went grey, because he was feeding it himself to buy her the seconds, and the bond carried what it cost him straight into her chest so that

she felt herself being spent at the far end of him, and she set that down too.

She set her hand against the tear.

It was cold past cold. It was the cold of the place the warmth thinned toward and did not reach, the place she had half-glimpsed at the rebirth and named to no one, and her sight, her returning, not-yet-whole sight, blew open against it the way it had blown open on the wall in Wend, wider than it had any business going, and for one moment she saw the tear from the inside. She saw it was not made. She saw there was no working in it, no Moravian, no meaning held steady, no hand. It was a place where the woven cloth of the world had simply been *leaned on* from the far side until it wore through, the threads of the weave drawn thin and parted, and what leaned on it was not a person and not a will, only a pressure, an absence on the far side that pressed toward the fullness on the near side the way water presses toward a low place, patient, certain, in no hurry at all, finding the worn places and coming through.

And she understood, in the part of her that did the arithmetic so the rest of her could survive the choosing, that water finds a low place because the low place pulls, and that the pull had a direction, and she started toward the rest of that thought and did not let it arrive. There was no time. There was a thing of absence three strides from Raizen and Raizen going grey, and she took the half-finished thought and filed it where she filed the things she was not ready to know, and she opened herself to the tear and began to give.

It was nothing like the easy things. It was the opposite of easy. She found the parted threads of the weave where they had frayed and worn through, and she poured her own source-warmth into the gap of them, the way you would press warm hands to a wound that would not close, and the cold drank it. That was the first thing she learned, in the

doing, because no one had taught her: that the tear would take everything she gave it and not be full, because the far side was vast and cold past any filling, and the only thing she could do was not fill it but *re-knit* it, gather the worn threads with the warmth she fed in and draw them back toward one another, hand over hand, meaning over meaning, holding the warmth in the place long enough for the threads to remember they had once been whole. It hurt in a way she had no name for. It was not the body. It was the part of her that was the source being spent at both ends at once, Raizen draining out the far end of the bond and the tear drinking the near, and she shook with it, and she did not stop, because a thing half-mended was a thing still open, and she gathered and held and gave until the worn threads, slowly, imperfectly, with a seam in them that would never be smooth again, drew back together and held. The current of cold pouring out of it thinned and stopped. The drain was shut. And behind her the Horror, cut off from the far side that fed it, with no tear to be a current toward, with only the near world's warmth and a dragon's bright blood already half-drunk in it, came apart.

She did not watch it come apart. She had learned that much, in a school that burned, at a square where a boy she loved was made an example: that there are things you do not need to have watched to carry, that the carrying does not require the watching and is in fact made worse by it. She kept her hand on the closed place where the tear had been and her eyes on the cold stone of the house in front of her, and behind her the thing that had made no sound made no sound now either, a different silence, and the grey ring stopped spreading, and the goose at the edge of the green did not get up, and Raizen folded back down into a grey-faced young man and put a hand against the wall of a house and breathed like a person, which he was learning to

do, which she had felt him learn from the inside three strides away with his life half spent to buy her the door.

* * *

The hamlet was empty and stayed empty. They looked, the way you look, and there was no one, only the cores gone from it and the white ash under the pot and the washing on the line, and Amber walked the lanes once with her knife still drawn and put it away at last and came and stood by Viridia at the closed place and did not say anything for a while, which from Amber was a kind of speech.

"Did it hurt them," Amber said finally. "Going. Did it hurt them the way it hurt." She did not finish. She did not have to. They had all felt the goose.

"I don't know," Viridia said, and it was true, and she gave Amber the true thing because Amber was the one she gave the true things to. "I felt them gone before we got here. I didn't feel them go. I don't know if that's a mercy or only a distance."

"Tell me it was a mercy," Amber said. "Lie to me. I'll know you're doing it. Do it anyway."

"It was a mercy," Viridia said.

"Thank you," said Amber, and her voice did the thing Viridia's voice was not allowed to do, cracked once on the two small words and got itself back, and she looked at the wooden horse on its side in the lane and then she did not look at it again, and she scrubbed a hand across her face and was furious about it, the way she was furious about beans, dressing the true thing in the small cross thing because the true thing was too big to carry bare. Viridia did not look at her while she did it. It was the only kindness there was, and she had learned, across a year, that the not-looking was a thing you could give a person, the way Alice had not-looked

at her on a dark step, the way Raizen had let her keep her lie about the count.

Alice came up from where she had been at the white-ash fire, kneeling, doing the thing she did, which was to put her hand where the warmth had been as though there were something left in it to read, and there was nothing, and she had known there would be nothing, and she had knelt anyway, because that was who she was again now, a degree at a time. She stood over the closed place and looked at it with the stilled calm that was not cold, and she said the thing none of them had said.

"Look at me," Alice said. "Don't make the face. Look at me." She turned the calm green look on Viridia, and the crooked tooth did not show, because there was nothing here to forget herself laughing at, and she took Viridia's wrist, the healer's grip, the one that was not a comfort but a reading. "You are wrung out to nothing. I can feel it in your pulse from here, you gave yourself to that thing, I watched you go grey doing it, greyer than him, and he's a dragon. I have one thing to say and then I won't say it again." She let go of the wrist. "You stopped this one by pouring yourself into it. Good. It worked. Now do the arithmetic you do, because you're going to do it anyway and I'd rather watch you do it where I can see your face. How many of you are there. How much warmth do you have to give before there's none left to give and you're a girl on the ground in a lane and the next tear stays open." She did not soften it. "You cannot pour yourself into every one of these. There will be more than you have warmth to mend. You stopped this one." She let it sit. "It is not finished."

"No," Viridia said.

"Then let's go home and not pretend it is," said Alice, who taught frightened grown people to hold both halves of a thing over a bowl of water, and knew to the ounce what the

giving had cost the girl in front of her, and had just watched the person she loved most spend herself nearly to the wick to close a single tear in the world, and was frightened, not of the tear, but of the long sum of tears and the one girl who could feel them all and would try to mend each one with her own hands, and said so the only way she had, which was plainly, with the warmth held so carefully it made no sound.

* * *

They did not go far before they stopped for the night, because the horses were tired and Raizen was grey still and would not say so, and they made a small fire under a wall a mile south of the emptied hamlet, and Viridia sat with her back to the stone and let the source-sense come back up under her, the slow breathing of all the living cores there were, the tide that went out and came in, and after the silence of the valley it was almost a comfort, the great soft arithmetic of it, the proof that the world was still mostly full, still mostly warm, that one drain shut in one lane had not unmade the sum.

And then, because her sight had been blown open by the tear and had not yet folded all the way back down, because for a little while longer she could see further than she usually could, she let herself look north again, the way she had looked from the wall in Wend, toward the cold edge of everything where the warmth thinned to nothing.

The tear she had closed was closed. She could feel the absence of it, the clean place where the wrong place had been.

But she could feel the others.

Not near. None of them near, not yet. Faint, the way the first tree had been faint that first spring, a small green pressure opening at the edge of the dark, except that these were not green and they were not being born. They were the

other thing. Three of them, perhaps four, she could not yet tell, scattered along the cold rim at the top of the world where the weave wore thin, places where the world's woven cloth was being leaned on from the far side, worn, drawn out, beginning the smallest fraction to part. One of them, she thought, was further along than the others. One of them, she thought, she could already feel a current beginning in, the first cold breath of a drain not yet open but about to be.

She sat with her back to the wall and her friends asleep or pretending to sleep around the small fire, and she felt the others opening, faint and certain and not yet ours to stop, and she did not wake anyone, because there was nothing yet for anyone to do, and because some cold part of her was already counting them, setting them beside the count and the weight and the half-finished thought she had filed at the tear and not let arrive, and she let it count, and she watched the cold edge of the world, and she did not say, even to herself, the thing the counting was walking toward.

She only let herself know the small true thing, the one she always knew before she understood it.

There would be more doors. And she would be the one who had to close every one.

CHAPTER THREE

A City With No Head

The broadsheets came up the slow line a week stale, and they came in two kinds now, and Viridia had learned to tell them apart before she had read a word.

There were the ones printed on the old presses, in the old grey type, that still called themselves *The Capital Standard* and *The Crown Register* though there was no crown and the capital had stopped being one in the way that matters, which is the way that lets a thing get a bridge mended. Those were thin, and careful, and read like a man going on shaving in a house that is burning, and she did not entirely trust them and could not entirely stop reading them, because the careful man at least still believed there was a face to shave. And then there were the others, the new ones, run off on whatever press a faction had got its hands on, in type that did not match itself line to line, and those did not pretend. Those were arguments. They named names she did not know and accused them of things she could not weigh and called for orders to be restored or torn down or seized, and every one of them was certain, and every one of them was certain of a different thing, and reading a stack of them was like standing in a room where a great many frightened people were all shouting the truth at once.

She read them at the long table behind the mill, in the slack hour after Alice's lesson, while Alice put the dry things

away in their box and the four frightened grown people went back to being a miller's wife and a farmer and a man who had driven a train, and she read them the way she did the arithmetic, taking the names and the dates and the columns of who had done what to whom in a city she had walked through once as a prisoner, filing it, setting it beside the count and the weight and the tears she could feel opening at the cold edge of the world.

"You shouldn't," Amber said, from across the table, with her boots up on the bench and a week-stale *Standard* held at arm's length like a thing she might have to throw. "Read those. They put a year on you every time. I watch it happen. You go in a girl reading a paper and you come out a magistrate."

"Someone should know what's happening up there."

"Should they." Amber turned a page. "Why. What are you going to do about a riot you're reading about a week after it stopped being a riot. By now it's either burned out or burned the street down and either way the paper's wrong. That's the whole trouble with a city with no head, Viridia. The news of it is always already a lie, because the thing it's describing has already become a different thing by the time the ink's dry. There's nobody up there making it stay one thing long enough to be true about." She put the paper down. "And you read it like a list of people you've personally failed."

Viridia did not answer that, because it was close enough to land.

* * *

Here is what she had pieced together, across a winter of stale papers, of the thing the world had become at its head while it learned its own dark hands at its edges.

The capital had not fallen. That was the part the new broadsheets could not seem to forgive it for. A city falls in a

night and you can grieve it; the capital had simply, over a year, *stopped*. The High Chancellor was dead, killed in the last hour of the war by a dragon nobody up there had ever seen and most did not believe in, and the council that had cut the world six hundred years before him was scattered or dead or, in two cases she had read of, in hiding under names that were not theirs, and the great machine of the light-supremacist order, the thing that had sorted every child by the half of the gift it was allowed to admit it had, the thing that had killed Jazen in a square to make a point, had not been overthrown. It had been *unmade from underneath*. Every person it ruled had woken one morning a year ago whole, carrying both halves of the gift, the bright and the dark, the very thing the order had spent six centuries killing to deny, and the lie the whole machine ran on had stopped being a lie that anyone's body could keep believing, and a machine that runs on a lie does not fall when the lie dies. It just keeps turning, slower, sillier, grinding nothing, until one day a man with a lantern tells you the line does not go past Hallow any more because mending bridges had been a thing the capital did and there is no longer a capital that does things.

And into the space where the order had been, all the things the order had held down came up at once.

Some of them were good. She held onto that, on the bad reading days. The schools that had sorted children were closed, and no one had built the thing that should replace them, and that was a disaster, and it was also the first time in six hundred years that a child with a strong dark half was not taken from its mother in the night. The intelligence service that had hunted people like her was gone, and the corridors it had run through stood empty, and that was a kind of freedom even if the freedom mostly took the shape of nobody guarding anything. There were towns, she had read,

that had simply started governing themselves, badly, loudly, in halls that used to be assize courts, and were finding out the hard way what the capital had always told them they were too dangerous to be trusted with, which was that ordinary people, given both halves of a terrible gift and no one to forbid them, mostly want a bridge mended and a school for the children and to be left alone, and will quarrel viciously about exactly how, and will mostly, in the end, mend the bridge.

But some of it was not good, and the not-good part was the part that filled the new broadsheets, and the not-good part had a shape she recognized, because she had grown up inside the old version of it.

People had power now they could not govern. Not the power to seize a city, most of them, but the small ungoverned power of a hand that could sour milk and crack a cup and, in a quarrel, in a market, in a bad month, reach into the warmth of a thing and take. Most never would. But a year is long, and a leaderless city is frightened, and a frightened man with a new and secret violence in his hand is a different animal from a frightened man without one. There had been killings of a new kind, the papers said, deaths with no wound, and the careful grey *Standard* called them tragedies and the loud new sheets called them the work of one faction or another and called for the guilty to be found and dealt with, and nobody up there could find anyone, because everybody now carried the hand that could do it, and you cannot deal with everyone.

And so the factions. The papers were full of them, and they were all, when she did the arithmetic on them, the same faction wearing different coats. There were the ones who wanted the old order back, who had decided that the world had been safer when it was a lie and wanted the lie restored, who were quietly hunting for council members not

to try them but to put them back at the head of the machine and make it grind again. There were the ones who wanted no order at all, who had mistaken the collapse of a wicked thing for proof that all binding was wicked, and who would fight anyone who tried to mend the city as fiercely as they'd fought the order that broke it. And there were the new ones, the worst ones, the ones she filed and came back to and filed again, who had looked at a world full of ungoverned power and frightened people and concluded, with perfect logic, that what was needed was a *stronger hand than the old one*. A hand strong enough to hold both halves of the gift for everyone, since no one could be trusted to hold their own. A hand strong enough to reach into every core in the world and decide which of them got to keep their dark half and which did not.

She had read that argument, printed plainly, in a sheet that did not match its own type, three weeks ago, and she had not slept well after, and she had not told anyone why, because the why was that the argument was correct. Given the bodies, given the soured milk and the killings that left no mark, given a frightened city, it was the correct argument. It was the argument the council had made six hundred years ago, in better words, and it had not been wrong because it was illogical. It had been wrong because it was monstrous, and the thing she had learned, reading that sheet at the long table behind the mill, was that *correct* and *monstrous* were not opposites, and could in fact be the same sentence, and that the whole work of a life might be telling them apart when they wore each other's coat. She had read it at this same table, where the bowls of water still sat in their stack, and she had not slept.

She filed that too. She had not understood yet that it was about to walk into her valley on three pairs of feet.

* * *

They came on the afternoon of the second day after the hamlet, up the slow line as far as it ran and then on foot from Hallow like everyone, three men in city clothes gone shabby on the road, and Wend had a way of knowing a stranger was in it before the stranger reached the mill, so that by the time the three of them came up the lane Viridia was already on the step with Amber a careful pace behind her and Raizen, who had felt her attention sharpen from the orchard, coming down unhurried with an apple still in his hand.

The man in front was perhaps fifty, with the grey careful look of the old *Standard* made flesh, a man who had shaved that morning in a burning house and meant you to notice. He had soft hands and a hard mouth and he looked at Viridia and did the thing she had watched a hundred people do across the year and would never get used to, which was to be unable to hide, for one half-second, that she was smaller than the story.

"You're the girl," he said.

"I'm Viridia."

"I know who you are." He said it gently, and it was a correction, and under it she heard the thing he had come a week's hard road to say, the thing he had rehearsed at every stale stop on the slow line. "Everyone knows who you are. That's rather the point of why we're here. My name is Corwin Vale. I sat on the trade board, before, which is to say I am one of perhaps a dozen men left alive who knows how a city is actually fed, as opposed to argued about." He glanced, just once, at Raizen, and the apple, and the way Raizen stood, and something behind his careful eyes recalibrated and did not show it well. "These are colleagues. We have come a long way to talk to you, and we have come, I'll be honest, because

we have run out of better ideas, and you are the only idea left that everyone is afraid of in the same direction."

"That's a strange thing to want in a person," Amber said, from her careful pace behind.

"It is the only thing that holds a frightened city together," Vale said, without looking at her. "One fear everyone shares. We have not had one of those in a year. We have had a thousand small fears that point a thousand ways and tear the place apart between them." He brought the grey eyes back to Viridia. "May we sit. We've walked from Hallow. I'm too old for the roads they've let go."

She should have said no. She knew, on the step, with the source-sense breathing its slow tide under everything and the tears at the cold edge of the world counting themselves in the part of her she did not look at, that the right thing, the safe thing, was to give these men a meal and a bed and a no and send them back down the slow line in the morning. There was a tear to think about, four of them or three, she still could not count them clean. The capital was not hers.

But Corwin Vale was old and his feet hurt and he had walked a week to say a true thing, and the true thing was that a city was coming apart, and she had never in her life learned how to turn away from a true thing. So she said yes, and Alice put water on, and that was the mistake, the small one, the one she would file later beside the others. She let them in to talk.

* * *

They talked through the afternoon, at the long table where the bowls of water had been, and it went the way she should have known it would.

They were not stupid men. That was what made it hard. If they had been stupid she could have heard the monstrousness in it at once and shown them the door. But

Vale laid the city out for her the way Alice laid out a wound, plainly, without flinching, naming the bleed and the break and the part that would go bad if no one held it. He told her about the deaths with no wound, more of them than the papers printed, because the papers were a week behind and a coward besides. He told her about a market in the eastern quarter where a quarrel over the price of grain had ended with three men dead and not a mark on them, and the crowd that had gathered after, and how the crowd had not been angry but *afraid*, because every person in it had looked at the three dead men and understood that they themselves carried the same hand and had only, so far, chosen not to use it. He told her about the faction in the river district that had started checking people's hands, making them prove they could hold the dark half steady before they were let across a bridge, and how that was the order again, the sorting again, growing back out of the ground where they'd torn it up because the ground remembered the shape.

"It will not hold," Vale said, into the low afternoon light. "I have given it a year. I am a patient man and I have given it the most patient year of my life and I am telling you, as a man who knows how a city is fed, that it will not hold another. The ones who want the old order back are gaining, because the old order at least fed people, and a hungry frightened person will take a wicked order over no order every single time, and they are *right* to, and that is the thing the people who tore it all down never understood. You do not get to tear down a thing that feeds people unless you have already built the thing that feeds them next. We did not build it. There was no one to build it. There was no head."

"And you want me to be the head," Viridia said.

She said it flatly, to put it on the table, to make him say it in the open so she could see its whole shape, and Vale, to his credit, did not flinch from it either.

"No," he said. "I am not a fool. A girl of sixteen is not the head of a city. I have grandchildren your age and I would not let them run a market stall." He folded his soft hands on the table. "But you are not only a girl of sixteen, are you. That is the thing none of us up there can get our minds around and the thing that I, sitting across this table from you, am only now beginning to feel in my stomach instead of my head. You are the one who did it. You stood somewhere a year ago and reached into every core in the world and changed all of them at once, without asking, because there was no time to ask. We don't fully believe it. We can't. But our bodies believe it, every one of us, because every one of us woke up changed and no one we trust can explain it any other way." He leaned in, and the careful grey mask came off, and under it was a tired frightened old man who had walked a week. "So I am not asking you to be the head of a city. I am asking you a smaller thing and a larger thing. I am asking you to *fix it*. You feel them, don't you. The cores. All of them. You changed them once. The deaths with no wound, the soured markets, the man who reaches into his neighbor in a quarrel because no one ever taught him not to and there's no law left to stop him." His voice dropped. "You could reach in again. Couldn't you. You could take the dark half back out of the ones who can't be trusted with it. Or you could hold it for them. Steady it, in all of them, the way your healer there steadies it in four people over four bowls of water, except all of them, all at once, the way you did it the first time. You could make them safe from each other. You're the only thing in the world that could. And I have walked a week to ask you to."

And there it was, on the table at last, plain and reasonable and walked a week to be said, and it was the thing.

It was the thing she had fought. It was the exact thing. It was the council's argument in a tired old man's mouth, *take*

the dark half out of the ones who can't be trusted, hold it for them, decide for them which of them gets to keep the whole of themselves, and it was monstrous, and it was correct, and the dreadful part, the part that came up under her breastbone the way the tear had, was that he had said *you're the only thing in the world that could* and he was right, and a part of her, a small cold honest part, had already, in the second before she answered, felt how it would be done.

Because she did feel them. The source-sense ran under her all the time, the whole living tide of cores born and gone, and she had taught herself to read it as weather, as a sum without faces, but it had faces if she reached for them, it had every face there was, and she knew, sitting at the long table with her own untouched water going cold in front of her, that what Vale was asking was not impossible and not even difficult. It would not be like the rebirth, which had nearly become her. The rebirth had been giving, all at once, the whole weave run full, a thing that spent her to the wick. This would be the other half of the gift, the dark half, the taking, and she had run the whole weave once and a city was nothing, a city was a handful, and to reach across the miles into a frightened man in a river district and find the dark half sitting unused and afraid in him like a tool in a drawer and simply *draw it out*, take it, hold it, leave him bright and safe and lesser and never knowing what had been done to him, would be, she understood with a cold and total certainty that frightened her more than the Horror had, *easy*.

It would be the easiest thing she had ever done.

* * *

"No," she said.

She said it quietly, and she said it fast, faster than she had meant to, because she had felt the easiness and the speed of the no was the only wall she had against it. Vale opened his

mouth and she went on over him, which she did not do, which Amber did, not her, but she did it now.

"No. And not the way you'll hear it, Mr. Vale, which is a girl being squeamish, or frightened of the work, or hiding in this valley because she's tired. Hear it right, because you walked a week and you're owed it said right." She looked at the cold water in front of her and made herself look up from it, into the tired grey eyes. "You're asking me to do the thing they did. The exact thing. Six hundred years ago a council looked at a world full of power they were afraid of and decided which half of it people were allowed to keep, and they were sure they were right, and they had reasons, good ones, the same ones you have, deaths and fear and a city that wouldn't hold. And they reached in and took half of everyone, without asking, for everyone's good, and they were *right* that it made people safer. It did. It made a calm safe murdered world that killed a boy in a square to keep itself calm and safe, and they would have told you, every one of them, that they did it because they were the only ones who could and the alternative was chaos." She heard her own voice and it was steady, the flat hard certainty that held when nothing else did. "I'm the only one who could. You're right about that. That's not a reason to. That's the reason not to. The fact that I'm the only one who could is the most dangerous fact in the world and the only safe thing to do with it is to refuse, and to keep refusing, every day, forever, because the day I decide for them again is the day there's no difference between me and the thing I burned a school getting out of."

Vale was quiet. Across the table Amber had gone very still, watching her, and Raizen, by the cold hearth with the apple, watched her too, and she could feel the bond carrying his attention, grave and proud and not surprised, because he had known the answer was in her before she said it.

"You decided for them once," Vale said at last, gently, and it was the cruelest thing he could have said and he did not say it cruelly. "You said it yourself. A year ago. Without asking. You made them whole without asking, and you called it worth more than their consent, and you were *right*, and they are whole, and not one of them would give it back. So forgive an old man, but I don't understand the line. You decided once. Why is once allowed and twice forbidden. Where exactly is the wall, girl, and how do I know you'll be able to find it in the dark a year from now when the city's burning and someone you love is one of the deaths with no wound?"

And that, she had no clean answer for, and she did not pretend to.

Because it was Amber's question. It was Amber's question in an old man's mouth, the one that had grown teeth across the year, *how do you tell the difference, from the inside, between you and them*, and she had let it go unmade for a year of days and here it was on the table demanding to be answered by a tired man who had walked a week and was owed it, and she did not have the answer, and the not-having frightened her, because she could feel, under the breastbone, how easy the other thing would be, how the easiness would only grow, how a year of saying no to a burning city while you alone held the power to stop the burning was a kind of weight that might, in the end, be heavier than the weight of the source itself.

"I don't know where the wall is," she said, and it was the true thing, and she gave it to him because he was owed a true thing. "I know I have to find it every day instead of building it once. I know the first one was giving and this one is taking and that the difference matters more than I can prove to you across a table. And I know that you came here because I'm the only idea left that everyone's afraid of in the

same direction, and that you're right, and that being the thing a frightened city all agrees to be afraid of is exactly how the council started." She stood up, because she had to do something with her hands and her body and the thing rising in her, and she gathered the cold cups off the table the way she had gathered the beans off the wall, because it was a thing to do. "Stay the night. The roads are bad. In the morning I'll give you what I can, which is true, and it isn't what you walked for. I'll send a healer who taught me the dark half back with you, if she'll go, to teach your river district to hold their own hands instead of being held. That's the only safe answer there is. It's slow and it's small and people will die while it's slow and small, and I know that, and I'm choosing it anyway, and I'll have to keep choosing it, and I am asking you to help me make it the answer the city believes in instead of the easy one." She set the cups down by the basin. "Because the easy one is there. I want you to understand that I know it's there. I'm not refusing because I can't. I'm refusing because I can, and that's the only refusal that means anything."

Vale looked at her for a long moment, the tired grey eyes, and she did not know what he saw, and she could not read whether it was relief or despair or only the exhaustion of a man a week from a burning house being handed slow bread instead of the loaf he'd walked for. Maybe all three. Maybe he didn't know either. People mostly didn't, she had learned, know which thing they were feeling when more than one of them arrived at once.

"Slow and small," he said. "While the city burns."

"Yes," she said.

"And if the slow small thing fails. If the river district burns the bridges before your healer's taught them anything. If it comes apart up there the way I'm telling you it's going to." He stood, his soft hands flat on the table, and

the last of the careful mask was gone, and what was under it was just the question, naked. "Will you still say no then. When it's not an argument across a table but a city on fire and you the only water. Will you still find your wall in the dark."

And she opened her mouth to say *yes*, the flat hard certain yes that held when nothing else did.

And under her breastbone, unbidden, in the part of her that did the arithmetic so the rest of her could survive the choosing, she felt the river district. She felt it the way she had not let herself feel it, reached for it the way she had refused to reach, and there it was, a knot of frightened cores a week to the north, every one of them carrying the dark half unused and afraid, every one of them a drawer with a tool in it, and she felt, clear and total and quiet as the water going still under Alice's hand, exactly how she would reach in and take it. How little it would cost her. How much it would save. How no one would ever have to know, and the bridges would stand, and the killings that left no mark would stop, and a frightened city would be safe and calm the way the world had been safe and calm for six hundred years, and how the only price would be a girl in a valley who had decided, alone, again, for everyone's good, which half of themselves they were allowed to keep.

She felt how easy it would be.

She closed her hand on the edge of the basin and did not answer him, and outside the light went long over Wend, and the mill turned, and somewhere very far to the north a tear leaned a fraction wider toward the warmth she had become, and she stood in her own kitchen with a tired old man waiting for a *yes* she was no longer entirely sure was the only word in her.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Easy Mark

The second one came while they were still a half-day short of home, and it announced itself the way the first had not, which was loudly, in the body of a man running down the slow line's dead track toward them with his hat gone and his breath tearing and a word he could not get all the way out.

"The bridge," he managed, when Amber caught him by the arms and held him up, because he had run past the point where his legs were his to command. "The Hallow side. There's a, there's a hole in the air, there's a thing, it took Dell's boy off the wall, it took him right off, and then it took the dog, and we ran, we all ran, and it didn't follow, it just, it's just standing there drinking the bridge." He got his eyes onto Viridia and they did the thing eyes did. "You're her. You're the girl. They said go and find the girl."

She was already moving. She had felt it open under her breastbone four miles back and had said nothing, because there had been nothing yet to say that running would not say faster, and now she ran, and counted while she ran, the distance, the slope, the warmth thinning ahead of her the way it had thinned three days before, a steady small subtraction at the edge of everything, and behind it, under it, the half-finished thing she had filed away at the first tear and not let arrive, leaning toward arriving now whether she let it or not.

* * *

The bridge at Hallow had been let go in the winter, the man with the lantern had said, and so it had, the rail rusting, two planks gone over the beck, but it had still been a bridge that people crossed because there was no other, and now it was a bridge with a wrongness standing on it.

She saw the tear before she saw the Horror. It hung over the centre of the span where the planks were widest, the same frayed rent she had set her hand against in the emptied hamlet, the same smear in the daylight with no heat in it, except that this one was bigger. The first had been the height of a man. This was the height of two, and its parted edges did not hold still; they crept, a thread at a time, the worn place worrying itself wider as she watched, and the cold pouring off it came down the beck like a draught under a door, and where it touched the running water the water did not freeze but slowed, went thick, went grey, the small life in it draining sideways into the thing on the bridge.

The Horror stood under the tear with its back to them and drank.

It had no more shape than the first one, the same height of moving absence that the eye slid off and could not hold, and it was bent over something on the planks, and Viridia did not let herself look long enough to learn what the something was, because a part of her already knew it was small, and the running man had said *Dell's boy*, and there are things the carrying does not require the watching of.

"Same as before," Amber said, at her shoulder, breathing hard, the long knife already in her hand and already, Viridia knew, useless, and Amber knowing it useless and holding it anyway because her hands needed a thing to be. "You go for the tear. We pull its eye. Raizen lights up, you mend the..."

"No," said Raizen.

He had come up last, on his two unhurried legs, and he was looking at the tear with the dark ordinary eyes, and there was no urgency in him at all, which frightened her more than the urgency in the hamlet had, because the urgency had meant *act* and the stillness meant *think*.

"It is bigger than the first," he said. "You felt that. I felt it through you. You mended the first one hand over hand and it cost you nearly the whole of yourself and that one was the height of a man. This is twice that, and it is still widening, and you have a half-day's run already in your legs." He did not look at her. He looked at the tear, and at the cold coming down the beck, and he did the arithmetic she did, the way he had learned to from the inside of the bond. "If you pour yourself into this one the way you poured yourself into that one, you will close it, and you will be a girl on the planks afterward, and the next one, and there will be a next one, you have told me there will be a next one, the next one will stay open, because there will be nothing left in you to give it." He turned his head then. "So do not give it yourself. There is another way to shut a door, little one, and you have carried it a year. My father set it in your hand on a mountain and you have not let yourself draw it since. Draw it now."

* * *

And on the dead track above the Hallow bridge with a Horror drinking a child off the planks below, the year fell away, and she was on a cold mountain again with the old one, with Drake, the ancient banked eye and the splinter of dark stone and the grit she had drawn the shape in until her hand stopped trembling.

She had hoped, for many months after that lesson, never to need it, and in all the time since she had drawn it only once, the day she ended the true-glass and the lens went dark mid-drink, and had not let her hand near it again. But

her hand had not forgotten. There has always been a mark, Drake had said. The makers of the world set it under everything as a courtesy, the way a builder leaves a thing a way to fall down, because a thing that cannot end is a worse cruelty than a thing that ends. The mages had it once and named it the symbol for Death, and then the order that cut her world in two decided no one should hold the half of the gift that knew it, and they let it go out of the books, because a council that means to rule forever does not teach its people the shape that ends things.

It does not mend, Drake had said, and made her say it back. It ends. You set it against a working and the working stops. Set it against a made door and the door is no longer made. Turn it on a tear in the daylight and the tear is no longer a tear, because the mark does not care what a thing is, only that it is, and it makes it not-be. It is the simplest working there has ever been. That is why they buried it. The simple things are the ones you must never let a frightened person hold.

Raizen was watching her remember. The bond carried it both ways, and he had been inside her when the memory came up, and he did not speak across it. He only said, when it had finished, the dark ordinary eyes on the tear and not on her, "He told you you would hate how easy it is."

"He did."

"He was not wrong about much." And then, lower, the one thing he wanted her to carry: "It asks nothing. The mending asks everything, your warmth, your self, hand over hand, because mending is the harder thing and the harder thing is the safer thing. This asks nothing. You will feel that it asks nothing and you will be glad, and the gladness is the danger, and no one alive can make you afraid of a thing that does not hurt. That is the whole reason it is buried." He looked at her

then. "Now go and shut the door, and do not pour yourself into it, and do not enjoy how little it costs."

* * *

She went down to the bridge.

She did not run at the Horror. There was still nothing to run at, and she had learned that. She went down the bank and onto the planks at the Hallow end, and the cold came up to meet her, the draught with no bottom in it, and the thing on the bridge did not turn, because it was busy, and below the planks the beck went grey and thick and the small lives in it went sideways and out.

Amber went wide along the far bank drawing the eye that was not an eye, and Raizen let the light off himself in a long banner into the cold air, the warmth so present that the thing of absence began, slowly, to turn from the small shape on the planks toward the brighter warmth, and Viridia stood at the foot of the tear and lifted her hand and drew the mark on the empty air.

She had braced for it to cost. That was the thing she would remember after, the thing she would not be able to make Amber understand at the fire that night. She had braced the way she had braced in the hamlet, had set her feet against the long pouring-out of herself, the spending at both ends, the grey shaking emptiness of giving her own warmth to a cold that could not be filled. She had braced to be wrung to nothing again, and to do it anyway, because a child was on the planks and there was no luxury of being sure first.

And none of it came.

She drew the line, and the closing of the line, and the still point at its heart where the closing met, and the tear stopped. Not slowly. Not hand over hand. There was no re-knitting, no gathering of worn threads, no warmth

pressed into a wound that drank and drank and was not full. There was only the mark, set against the wrongness, and the wrongness *ceasing to be a wrongness*, the parted threads not drawn back together but simply, gently, without protest, no longer parted, no longer threads, the rent in the daylight folding shut along the line she had drawn the way a held breath is let out, and the cold pouring down the beck thinning and stopping, and the place where the tear had been becoming a place where nothing had ever been wrong.

It took perhaps the length of a breath. It cost her nothing. She stood on the planks with her hand still raised and her warmth still whole in her, every ounce of it, the source still full under her breastbone, not spent at all, not spent in the smallest part, and behind her the Horror, cut off from the far side that fed it, with only the near world's warmth and a dragon's bright blood half-drunk in it, came apart, and made no sound coming apart, and she did not watch it.

She stood on the planks in the sudden ordinary daylight with the beck running clean again under her and her whole self intact in her hand, and the thing she felt, before she could stop herself feeling it, before Raizen's voice in her hand could reach the front of her mind, was not horror and was not grief.

It was relief. It was the cleanest, simplest, most total relief she had felt since the cavern, the relief of a thing that had been going to hurt and had not hurt, and on its heels, quick and quiet and terrible, came the second thing, the thought that arrived before she could file it.

That was easy. That was so easy. I could do that all day.

* * *

She knelt by the small shape on the planks for a while, because someone had to, and there was nothing to do, the core long gone before they reached the span, drained down

the cold with the dog and the life of the beck, and she put her hand where the warmth had been the way Alice did, as though there were something left in it to read, and there was nothing, and she had known there would be nothing, and she did it anyway.

Dell's boy. She did not know which one Dell was. She would learn, going back through Hallow, and would wish she had not, the way you always wished it after, that a name made a thing heavier and you took the name anyway because the alternative was to let a person go into the ground a *boy off the wall* and that was a worse thing than the weight.

Amber came and stood at the end of the planks and did not come closer, and Raizen folded the light back down into himself and came to the foot of the bridge and stopped, and none of them said anything, and the beck ran clean, and that was the whole of the mercy there was, that the water at least ran clean again.

"It didn't cost you anything," Amber said at last. It was not a question. She had watched from the far bank. She had watched Viridia brace and not be spent, watched her go down to a thing that had nearly killed her three days before and walk away from it with her colour in her face. "I saw it. You did the thing with your hand and the hole just went. And you're not grey. You're not on the ground. You're not wrung out to nothing. After the last one Alice had her hand on your pulse telling you you'd spent yourself to the wick." She was working at it, the way Amber worked at a thing she did not like the shape of, dressing the worry in the flat hard fact. "So that's good. That's better. Why are you making the face, then. That's the good news. Why does Raizen look like you just did a murder."

* * *

They did not talk about it until the fire, a mile south of Hallow under a broken wall, and even then it was Raizen who talked, because Viridia would not, because the relief was still in her and she did not trust her own mouth around it.

"She found a thing today that asks nothing of her," Raizen said. He had fed a stick into Amber's too-large fire, carefully, the way he did everything, and he turned the next one in his hands without feeding it, and the firelight did not catch in his eyes the way it would have caught in a dragon's, the dark human eyes only dark, only ordinary. "You want to know why I look as though she did a murder. It is because the council that cut her world did one, six hundred years over, and they did it with a thing that asked nothing of them. They reached into every living core there was and took the half of it they were afraid of, and it cost them nothing, and a thing that costs nothing, you do not stop doing. You do not weigh it. You weigh the things that hurt. The things that do not hurt, you simply keep doing, until you have done them to everyone, because there is never a reason on the day to stop." He set the unfed stick down. "She has carried, all this year, a thing she could do that would save thousands and cost her nothing, the taking of the dark half out of frightened people, a reaching into all of them at once, and the only wall between her and it has been that she can feel how monstrous it is. Today the world handed her a second thing she can do that saves people and costs her nothing, and this one is not monstrous. This one is good. She shut a door and a beck runs clean. And so the wall she built against the first thing does not stand against the second, because the second is *right*." He looked at Viridia across the fire. "And a thing you can do that is right and free, you will do, and do, and do, until the doing has become the only thing you are. I have lived a long time, little one. I have watched it happen to

better creatures than men. The free good thing is how you lose yourself. Not the monstrous one. The monstrous one you can see coming."

Amber was quiet. She had stopped working at the fire.

"He's saying," she said slowly, to Viridia, not to Raizen, "that you liked it."

Viridia looked at the fire.

"Say the true thing," Amber said. "At the start, for once. Not at noon."

"I liked it," Viridia said.

She said it flatly, the way she said the things that were too big to say any other way, and she made herself look up from the fire and into Amber's face, because Amber was the one she gave the true things to and this was a true thing and it was owed saying right.

"I went down to that bridge braced to be spent to nothing. I have closed exactly two of these now and the first one nearly took me apart, and I went down to the second one knowing it was bigger and ready to give it everything I had, because that's the price, that's what closing a tear costs, you spend your own warmth into a cold that won't be filled and you shake and you go grey and you do it because a child is on the planks. And then it cost me nothing. I drew a mark on the air and the wrong place stopped being a wrong place and I had my whole self still in me, every ounce, and the beck ran clean, and a thing that was going to gut me just didn't." She held Amber's eyes. "And I was glad. Not glad it worked. Glad it was easy. Those are different and I felt the difference and I was glad it was easy, and I'm telling you that at the start of the conversation instead of at noon because Raizen's right and it scares me, and the thing that scares me isn't the Horror." She looked back at the fire. "It's that I already want to do it again."

* * *

She slept badly and woke before the others, the way she did, and sat with her back to the broken wall while the dark went grey, and let the source-sense come up under her, the long low breathing of every living core the world held, and she did not, this time, find it a comfort.

Because her hand remembered the mark. That was the thing she had not told even Amber. It had sat all but unused in her hand for a year, a shape Drake had set there that she had drawn exactly once, on a true-glass, and refused since, and now that she had turned it on a tear it would not sit quiet again, the line and its closing and the still point at the heart of it, a thing she could draw on the air without thinking, and the source ran full and warm under her breastbone and her hand knew the mark that asked nothing, and she understood, sitting against the cold wall in the grey, exactly the shape of the danger Raizen had not been able to make her feel, because it did not feel like danger. It felt like having a tool you had been carrying a heavy load without.

She thought of the man Vale, gone back down the slow line two days since with Alice's promise and not the one he'd walked for. And the river district a week to the north came up in her too, the knot of frightened cores, every one of them a drawer with a tool in it. She had told Vale the easy thing was there and that she refused it because she could and not because she couldn't. She had been so sure of the wall.

She had not known, saying it, that the world had a second easy thing in it. A clean one. A good one. A mark that shut a door and asked nothing and left a beck running clear, and she could not yet tell whether the wall she had built against the monstrous easy thing would stand against the good one, and she suspected, in the cold honest grey before anyone

else was awake, that it would not, because Raizen was right, because you do not weigh the things that do not hurt.

She drew the mark on the air, once, with one finger, just to feel her hand know it. It knew it. She put her hand back in her lap and was ashamed, and let no one see the shame, because no one was awake to see it, and that was its own kind of mercy and its own kind of warning, that the shame had no witness, that she could carry this one entirely alone if she chose to, the way she carried the count, and that a thing you carry entirely alone is a thing no one is left to stop.

* * *

They went home, and it was a day and a half by foot and the dead line, and Wend was as they had left it, the mill turning, the smoke going up, the goat back on the roof, two hundred people living inside the change and not yet knowing what had been let off the Hallow bridge or what their girl had learned to do with her hand.

Alice met them at the long table behind the mill, and she had her bowls of water out, and she looked at Viridia's face and then at Raizen's and then she put the lid back on the box where she kept the dry things, which was the thing she did instead of asking, and she came and took Viridia's wrist in the healer's grip that was a reading and not a comfort.

"You're not wrung out," she said. She had been braced for grey, the way she was always braced now. She found a pulse with the warmth still in it and her stilled calm did not break but something moved behind it, the way the present girl moved up behind the calm and went under again. "You closed something and you're not wrung out. After the last one I could feel you'd spent yourself near to nothing." She did not let the wrist go. "Tell me how."

So Viridia told her, there at the long table with the still bowls between them, told her about the mark that ended

things, and Alice listened the way Alice listened, plainly, without flinching, the healer naming the bleed, and at the end of it she let the wrist go and was quiet a while, and then she said the thing, the thing none of them had said, the thing only a healer could say.

"My whole craft is the long, patient work," Alice said. "You understand that. Every day at this table, over these bowls, I teach four frightened people, a winter of afternoons at a time, to carry the bright and the dark together, because the slow way is the only way that's theirs at the end of it. There's a fast way. There's always a fast way. I could reach into the miller's wife and steady her dark half for her in a breath and she'd walk away calm and safe and it wouldn't be hers, it'd be mine, holding it, and the day I stopped she'd drop it. My way costs me a winter of afternoons and the fast way costs me nothing." She looked at the mark Viridia had drawn, unthinking, on the table in the spilled water with one finger, and Viridia saw that she had drawn it and went still. "And the day I find myself doing the fast one because I'm tired, or because there are too many of them and not enough afternoons, is the day I've stopped being a healer and started being a thing that decides for people. I know that wall. I live on it." She put her own hand flat over the spilled mark, gently, and wiped it from the wood. "You've got a fast way now too, Vir. A clean one. I'm not going to tell you not to use it, because there's a child on a bridge somewhere and the patient way would have killed you. I'm going to tell you the thing I tell myself, which is the only thing there is." She found Viridia's eyes. "Count what it costs even when it costs nothing. *Especially* when it costs nothing. Make yourself weigh the free thing. Because the free thing doesn't weigh itself, and a thing that doesn't weigh itself will let you do it all day, and one day all day is everyone, and you won't have felt the wall go because there wasn't one. There's never a wall on

a thing that doesn't hurt. You have to be the wall." She wiped the last of the water from the wood. "Every single time. That's the job now. I'm sorry. I'd have given you an easier one if it had been mine to give."

* * *

That night Viridia did not sleep, and in the slack dark she went up the terraced gardens behind the houses to the high wall at the top, where the valley fell away and the cold edge of the world lay open to the part of her that could read it, and she let her sight unfold as far as it would go, which was further than it had gone a year ago and not yet as far as it would go, and she looked north, and she did the thing she had not let herself do at the fire or the table, which was count.

The tear she had mended at the hamlet was closed still. The clean place where the wrong place had been. The one she had shut at Hallow was closed too, the same clean nothing, the mark holding where her own warmth had held, and holding easier, and she filed that and did not let herself be glad of it twice.

But the others.

She had felt three at the first fire, perhaps four, faint, scattered along the cold rim at the top of the world where the weave wore thin. She had closed two. Two of the four, the easy way, in three days, and walked away whole both times, and the arithmetic she had been afraid to do said that two from four was two, and she had thought, going up the gardens, that she would find two.

She did not find two.

She found, along the cold rim where the warmth thinned to nothing, where she had felt three or four faint pressures leaning in from the far side, more. Not three, and not four either. She could not get a clean count, her sight guttering at

the edge of its reach the way it always guttered, but where there had been three or four there were now, she thought, six, and then thought seven, and then a fainter one beyond the seven, opening even as she counted, the smallest fraction, a place where the world's woven cloth was being pressed at from the cold side and beginning to part, and beyond it, fainter still, the breath of another. The rim was not a row of doors she could walk along and shut. The rim was wearing. The whole cold edge of everything was being leaned on at once, patient and certain and in no hurry, and the leaning found the worn places and came through, and there were more worn places this morning than there had been when she walked north, and there would be more tomorrow than there were tonight.

She had spent the whole walk home afraid of the mark that asked nothing, afraid of the wall in herself it might not stand against, afraid of the relief and the wanting-to-again, and she stood now at the top of her own gardens and understood that the fear had been the wrong size, had been a fear shaped for one girl and one mark and the slow erosion of one soul, and that the world had a larger fear in it than that, and the larger fear was simpler and did not care about her wall at all.

She had a way to close them now that cost her nothing.

And she was not going to be able to close them fast enough.

She stood at the high wall with the cold rim wearing open faster than her hand could draw, and she did the arithmetic, the tally taking the six or the seven and the one beyond it and the breath beyond that, setting them beside the count and the weight and that other thought she had filed at the first tear and still would not let arrive, and the arithmetic came out the way it had been going to come out since the wall in Wend, since the first cold breath at the edge of the

source-sense, and she stood with it in the dark and did not say it, even to herself.

This time she let the sum arrive.

It was not a count anymore. It was a rate. The doors were opening faster than one girl with a free and terrible gift could ever, in a single given night, draw them shut, and the gap between the opening and the closing widened every time she set her eye to it, and no mark that asked nothing of her could close a gap that grew. Whatever stopped this was going to be something else. Something she did not have yet, and did not want, and could already feel waiting for her at the far end of the arithmetic she had spent three countries refusing to finish.

CHAPTER FIVE

What She Will Not Do

Vale and his colleagues went down the slow line in the grey of the second morning, on foot from the mill to the dead track, and Viridia walked them as far as the first bend because it was a thing you did, and because she did not trust the night's silence between them to have meant a no he could carry home.

He had not slept either. She had felt him not sleeping, the way she felt everyone now, his core a small worried wakefulness in the dark room over the mill, turning and turning the way his hands had turned on the table, and she had lain in her own dark and felt the whole house breathing its little cores around her, Amber's quick and even, Alice's banked and steady, the two strangers, the goat, and under all of it the long low tide that did not sleep, the births and the deaths of the world going on without her leave, and she had thought: he is right that I could. That is the part he does not know he won that he won.

At the bend he stopped and put out a soft hand and she took it.

"You'll send the healer," he said.

"If she'll go. I won't make her. That's the whole point of the thing, Mr. Vale, that I won't make her, so I can't very well start by making her."

"Slow and small," he said, "while the city burns," and it was not cruel this time, only tired, a man saying back the words he had been given so he would not forget them on the road, and she let him keep them.

She watched the three of them down the track until the mist took them, three shabby city men growing smaller against the wet green, and she stood a while after they were gone, and what she felt was not relief. She had refused him. She had said the no and meant the no and would mean it tomorrow. And already, without her leave, she was counting the bridges he had named and the markets and the wounds with no blade in them, and setting them on the scale beside her no, and finding, the way it always found, that her no had a price, and that the price was paid in a city she would never see by people who had not been asked.

She walked back up the lane. The mill turned. Somewhere far to the north the rim wore a fraction wider, patient, in no hurry, and she kept her eyes off it yet.

* * *

Amber found her at the high garden wall that afternoon, which was where Viridia went now when she needed to do the looking, because it was the highest point in Wend and the cold rim lay open to it, and because no one came up here but Amber, who came up here precisely because no one else did.

"You're doing it again," Amber said. She had a heel of bread and a thumbnail of cheese and she ate as she climbed, the way she did everything, on the move and slightly cross about it. "The face. You went up Vale's track this morning with a no in you and you came back down with a sum. I watched you do it from the orchard. You said the right thing to him and then you spent the walk home proving to yourself it was the wrong one."

"I didn't."

"You did. You're doing it now." Amber dropped onto the wall beside her, boots swinging over the drop, and looked out at the valley going gold under the long light, the mill, the doubled gardens, the orchard, the two hundred lives folded into a place built for forty. "Go on, then. What's the sum. I can see it sitting on you. Just say it out loud so it stops being a secret you're keeping from yourself with your own face."

Viridia was quiet a while. The rim breathed cold at the edge of her, and the tears along it had not gone away while Vale talked, and she had a count to give them and was not ready to give it.

"He said I could fix it," she said at last. "The city. He said I could reach into every frightened core up there and take the dark half back out of whoever can't hold it, or hold it for them, the way Alice holds it for the miller's wife, except all of them at once. And he's right that I could. I want you to understand that I'm not being modest about it and I'm not being careful with you. I could do it. It would be easy. It would be the easiest thing I have ever done, easier than the rebirth, because the rebirth was giving and this is only taking, and the taking is the half that asks nothing."

"I was there for the no." Amber tore the bread. "Heard it. Good no. Best no I've heard you do."

"It was a good no."

"So what's the sum."

Viridia looked at the rim. "The sum is that people are going to die because I said it."

Amber chewed. She did not say anything quickly, which was how Viridia knew she had heard the real thing and not the small thing, because Amber dressed the small thing in a joke and went quiet at the real one. "Yeah," she said finally. "Probably they are."

"Not probably. Vale knows the feeding of a city and he says it won't hold another year, and I believe him, because he is a man who is right about the boring things, and the boring things are the ones that kill people. The deaths with no mark on them are going to keep happening. The river district is going to keep checking hands at the bridges, and the checking is going to turn into the sorting, and the sorting is the thing I burned a school getting out of, and it's growing back out of the ground a week to the north while I sit on a wall in a valley and refuse to stop it, and I could stop it, and I'm choosing not to." She heard her own voice stay flat and level, the thing that held. "So when you ask me what the sum is, the sum is that my no is going to be paid for by people I'll never meet, and I made that trade across a table this morning, alone, the way I make all of them, and there isn't a name for a person who gets to do that."

"There's a name," Amber said. "It's the one Vale used. You're the girl who already did it once."

* * *

The thing about Amber's questions was that they grew.

Viridia had learned this across two years of them, that Amber did not ask a thing the way other people asked it, all at once and then done, the question spent. Amber asked a thing and then went away and lived with it, carried it around through the ordinary days, the bean-shelling and the wood-hauling and the small crossnesses, and the question grew teeth in her the way a stone grows a shell, and then one day she said it again and it was a bigger and sharper thing than it had been, because she had been feeding it.

The first version, two years gone, had been small and clean and a child could have asked it: *how do you tell the difference, from the inside, between you and them?* She had asked it in the bad days, when Viridia was first learning what she

could do, and it had been a fair question and Viridia had had a fair answer, which was *because I don't decide for people*, and they had both been satisfied with it for a while.

Then the rebirth happened, and Viridia decided for everyone, all at once, without asking, and the answer broke.

And Amber had not asked the new version for a year. She had carried it. Viridia had felt her carrying it, the way she felt everything, the question sitting in Amber's wakeful core through a winter of afternoons, and she had known it would come back bigger, and she had hoped it would not come back today, on the wall, with Vale a morning gone and her own no still ringing.

"Can I ask you the thing," Amber said.

"You're going to anyway."

"I'm going to anyway, but I'm asking if I can, because it's a worse one than I've asked you before, and I want you to know I know that." She had stopped eating. She had her hands flat on the cold stone of the wall, the black nails chipped down to nothing, and she was not looking at Viridia, she was looking at the valley, which was how Amber looked at a person when the thing mattered most. "When you first started, I asked you how you tell the difference between you and the bad ones. And you said, because you don't decide for people. That was the answer. The whole answer. You don't reach into a person and decide a thing about them, and the bad ones do, and that's the whole wall, that's the line, easy, anyone can stand on it." She turned her head. "And then a year ago you reached into every person alive and decided the biggest thing there is about them, and they're glad, and they didn't ask for it, and you'd do it again. So the answer's gone. You don't have it any more. You used it up."

"I know."

"I'm not finished." Amber's voice did not rise. That was the thing that made it land. "Because here's the part that

grew. You used to not be able to feel them. When I asked you the first time, you could do things to people, but you couldn't *feel* them, not all of them, not the whole world at once. Now you can. You sit on this wall and you feel every core there is, the river district and the city and old Tem dying before the knock and a tree flowering, all of it, all the time, and you've told me you can reach for any single face in it if you want to. So." She made herself say it. "Now that you can feel every living core there is, what actually stops you from running all of them? Not should. I'm not asking should. Vale already did should. I'm asking what *stops* you. What's the wall, now that the old wall's gone and you can reach anyone and you'd be right and it'd be easy and you already did it once and they're glad. From the inside, Viridia. What's between you and the thing you fought, today, this afternoon, that isn't just you having decided to be good. Because you decided to be good last year too, and you remade the world."

The light went long over Wend. The mill turned. Viridia did not answer, because she did not have an answer, and the not-having was the whole of it, and she would not insult Amber by pretending.

"That's what I thought," Amber said, not unkindly, and picked the bread back up, because she had done the hard thing and now she would let them both have a minute. "Just so we both know it's not a question with a good answer in it yet. I'd rather we knew that than have you tell me a nice one."

* * *

She did not answer it on the wall. But she had to answer it somewhere, because Amber would not let it go, and because she had learned that a question Amber asked and you did not answer was a thing that went bad in the dark, and so she made herself, sitting there with the cold rim breathing at the

edge of her and the valley going gold, do the thing she did with the worst sums, which was to take the question apart into the pieces that were true and the pieces that only frightened her, and look at the true ones plainly.

The true piece was this: there was no wall.

There was no line in the world, no rule written under anything, that stood between her and reaching into the river district and taking what could not be trusted. The making of the world had not given her a wall. The Death symbol had taught her that already, on the Hallow bridge, the thing that asked nothing: there was never a wall on a thing that did not hurt. The wall was not a thing she had. The wall was a thing she did, every day, the way Alice did it over the bowls one afternoon at a time, the way you do not build a fire once and have warmth forever but feed it stick by stick or it goes out. The wall was the choosing, made fresh each morning, with nothing under it but the choosing, and a wall with nothing under it but the choosing is the only kind of wall there is for a person who can do anything, and it is also exactly the wall the council had, six hundred years ago, when they chose, each morning, that taking half of everyone was kind.

She had no better wall than the council had. That was the true piece. She had only chosen a different thing on the far side of the same nothing.

"That's not an answer to Amber," she said aloud, to the valley, to no one, "that's just the question with the lie taken out of it."

But it was the truest she had, and she found, having said it, that she was not more frightened than before. She was the same amount frightened, which was a great deal, and somehow steadier in it, the way you are steadier standing on a known edge than on one you have been pretending is solid ground.

She would tell Amber there was no wall, then. She would give her that, because it was the true thing, and Amber asked for the true thing at the start and not at noon. She would say: nothing stops me. I stop me. And I have to do it again tomorrow, and the day I'm too tired to, no one will be able to tell, including me, and that is the actual shape of the danger, and you, Amber, are part of what I do instead of a wall, you and Alice and Raizen, the three of you are the thing I have instead of a wall, which is people who would look at me differently the morning after I started running cores, and the fear of that look is not a wall either but it is a great deal, on a hard day, more than a wall, because a wall does not love you and you cannot disappoint it.

She did not say all of it. She would, later, by the fire, in fewer words. But she had it now, and it would do, and it was not a nice answer, and that was how she knew it might be a true one.

* * *

The tears were the other thread, and they did not wait for her to be finished with the first one. They never did. That was the year she was having.

She went back up to the wall after dark, when the house was down and the looking came clearer with no living warmth close to crowd it, and she let her sight unfold north along the cold edge of the world, out to the limit of its reach, which was further than a month ago and still guttered at the end. And she made herself, this time, not just count them, which she had done at Hallow and frightened herself with, but *read* them, the way Alice read a body, looking not at the number of the wounds but at the pattern they made, because a number tells you how bad and a pattern tells you why.

She had been treating them as weather. A storm does not have a reason; it has a direction and a strength and you batten the shutters. She had been battening shutters. Six, seven, the fainter one beyond, opening faster than she could close them, and she had stood here three nights ago and despaired at the count and gone down to bed with the despair, and that, she understood now, sitting in the dark with her sight out along the rim, had been a failure of the arithmetic itself, a place where the fear had got into it and made it stupid. Weather has no reason. But the tears, when she stopped looking at how many and started looking at *where*, had one.

They were not scattered.

She had thought they were scattered, because they came faint and one at a time and she had read each one as it tore and never laid them all down on the same map at once, the way you never notice a man is walking a straight line if you only ever see one footprint at a time. But she laid them down on the same map now, in the dark, the hamlet and the Hallow bridge and the faint ones beyond, the whole count of them since the first cold breath at the wall in Wend, and she set them along the cold rim in her mind the way you set pins in a chart, and they were not a scatter. They were a *trail*.

They ran west.

Not due west. The rim was not a wall you could lay a ruler on; it curved with the edge of everything, and the warmth thinned toward it unevenly, and a tear wore open where the cloth was thinnest, not where she would have drawn a line. But under the unevenness, when she took the faint pressures and ordered them by when they had opened and not just by where, there was a drift in them, a leaning, the worn places marching, one and then the next and then the next, away to the west and the north of west, toward a far quarter of the world she had never been to and could not

read clean, where her sight guttered out entirely into a grey she could not pierce, somewhere past the capital, past the river district, past anything Vale had named, out where the maps in the old broadsheets went vague and put pictures of mountains because they had nothing truer to put.

The earliest tears were furthest west. The newest were nearest. The trail was not spreading out from a centre like a stone dropped in water. It was *coming this way*, opening as it came, a thing that had begun somewhere far in the grey west and was working east along the rim toward the warmth, and the hamlet had been a stop on its road, and the Hallow bridge had been a stop on its road, and Wend was further along the same road, and she sat on the high wall of her own valley in the dark and understood that she had been closing the footprints of a thing that was walking toward her.

"Oh," she said, very quietly, to the dark.

She refused the gladness of having found it, the way she had refused the gladness of the easy mark. But there was a clean cold relief in it all the same, the relief of a storm turning out to have a reason, because a reason can be gone to, and a reason can be a place, and a place far in the west where the very first tear had worn open was a place a person could, in principle, walk to and stand in and find out what had been done.

She would tell them in the morning. There was a trail. The tears were not weather. Something in the west had begun this, some working, some door, some hand, and it ran east toward the warmth, and they could stop closing footprints one at a time on the road north and instead go to where the foot came down first.

It was the first hopeful thing in a year of the source-sense, and she sat with it in the dark and let herself have a single clean unguarded breath of it.

And then the second thing arrived, the way the second thing always arrived on its heels, quick and quiet and terrible, and it was not on the map.

* * *

Because there was a trail in the tears. But there was also, she realized, sitting very still now in the dark with her sight out along the rim, a direction in the *pull*.

She had been refusing to feel the pull for a year. That was the half-finished thought she had buried at the first tear and never let surface, the leaning thing under everything, the reason the Horrors came through the worn places and did not attack but only *drank* and drifted, the reason the cold poured off a tear like a draught under a door and the warmth went sideways and out. Water runs downhill. She had known that since the hamlet, had said it to herself in those words, *the Horror is the water and the tear is the drain*, and she had stopped the sentence there every single time, on purpose, by main force, because the sentence did not stop there. Water runs downhill *because the low place pulls it*. The draught comes under the door *because there is somewhere on the other side it is going to*. The warmth does not just leak out of the world through the tears. It is drawn out. It is drawn toward.

And tonight, having found the trail, having laid the tears down on the map and felt them marching east toward the warmth, she made the mistake, or the choice, of asking the question she had refused for a year: *toward what*.

The pull had a direction. She could feel it now that she was looking, now that the trail had pointed her at the question, the long low draw under everything, not the births-and-deaths tide she read as weather but the thing under the tide, the slow current the warmth ran along when a tear opened and the world bled. It was not random either. Of course it was not random. Nothing was random; she had

just learned that an hour ago and not let herself carry it the whole way. The current ran somewhere. The warmth that the Horrors drank did not vanish; it went, it went *along* a thing, the way water finds not just a low place but the lowest place, the one place all the low places drain toward in the end, and she sat on the wall and felt the current and let her sense run along it the way she had let her sight run along the rim, following the draw, following where the world's warmth went when it went, down and down the long pull, past the hamlet, past the road of tears, down under all of it to the place the pull came from, the deep low place the whole frayed rim leaned toward, the warmth of the world quietly falling toward—

—and it was the source.

It was the source. The current ran to the source. The pull came from the source.

The pull came from her.

She sat on the wall in the dark and did not move and did not breathe for a moment, her face holding still because there was nothing else holding, and she felt the truth of it the way she felt a death, instantly and entirely and before she understood it, the small true thing arriving whole the way the small true things always did, ahead of all the reasons. The trail of tears ran east toward the warmth. And the warmth they drank ran west and down toward the source. They were the same thing read from two ends. The far cold was leaning on the rim because the rim leaned toward the source, the way a held breath strains toward the mouth, the way the fuller the lung the harder it is to keep the breath in, and the source was full, the source had been run full a year ago, fuller than it had been in six hundred years, by a girl who put her hand in a pool in a cavern and mended every core there was, and the void out past the last of the warmth had been a shade wider after that, she had felt it and put it

away unlooked-at, and now the difference between the full warm world and the cold beyond it was a difference that *pulled*, and the cold came toward the warmth because the warmth had been heaped up, by her, in a girl, and the warmth was heaped up in *her*.

She had thought, all year, that she was the one closing the tears.

She was the reason they opened.

The half-finished thought finished itself. She did not let it; it simply, finally, in the dark, after a year of filing, arrived, and stood in the front of her mind where she could not put it back, plain and total and quiet as water going still.

I made this. The pull is the rebirth. The Horrors come toward the source because the source is too full, and I filled it, and they are coming toward me.

* * *

She stayed on the wall a long time after that, and she did not go down and wake anyone, and she kept her eyes dry, because she always did; she simply sat with the thing in the dark and let it be the size it was, which was very large, the other half of the rebirth, the cost of it that no one could have seen and that had been falling due all year while she closed footprints and refused to count. She had felt the edge of it once before, the second spring, a cold somewhere far off past the green pressure of the flowering tree, the place the warmth thinned toward and did not reach, and she had not gone looking, the way no one turns over a stone they have already decided is only a stone. It had not been only a stone.

She set her hands flat on the cold wall and made herself run the arithmetic one more time before she let herself be only afraid. She was not standing outside the world's trouble with a power she might or might not use on it. She was its source. The pull that wore the rim open and drank the

hamlet and took Dell's boy off the bridge wall ran to her, came from what she had made herself, and every tear she closed with the free clean mark was a footprint she wiped from the road of a thing whose first cause was a girl on a wall who had wanted, more than anything, to make the world whole, and had.

You could not close that with the mark. The mark ended a door. This was not a door. This was a pressure, and the pressure was her, and you do not draw a symbol against yourself.

She knew where she had to go. She had known, really, since the trail turned west, before the pull turned the trail back around to point at her; she had only thought she was going to find a working, a hand, a man, a stranger's mistake out in the grey west to be closed and ended and blamed. She was still going to find that, maybe. Vale's mistake had a face and so might this. But it would not matter. Closing the man in the west would be closing a footprint. The road did not begin in the west. The road began in a cavern, at a pedestal, over a pool that was not water, where a year ago she had put her hand in and run the weave full, and if she wanted to read the truth of this and not just its symptoms she would have to go there, to the source itself, and read the rim from the one place the rim was actually leaning toward, and find out, with her own hand on the thing she had become, exactly how full she had made it and exactly how far the cold had widened to meet her.

She would have to go and stand at the centre of the pull and feel it pulling.

She got down off the wall in the dark. The valley breathed its little cores around her, Amber and Alice and Raizen and the goat and the two hundred, and the long low tide went on under everything, births and deaths, the world living its life on the warmth she had heaped up, not one of them knowing

that the heaping was the thing the cold was coming for, that the gift had a draught under its door, that the price of the whole bright world being whole was a current running down and down to a girl walking back to her own bed in the dark with the worst sum of her life finished in her at last and no one to give it to until morning.

She would tell them in the morning. The trail ran west. The pull ran to the source.

The source was her.

And somewhere far in the grey west, past the capital and the river district and the place where the maps put pictures of mountains because they had nothing truer, the rim leaned a fraction further open toward the warmth she had become, patient, and certain, and unhurried, because the thing it was coming toward was not going anywhere.

It was going to bed. It had a long day ahead.

CHAPTER SIX

The Cost of Half-Sight

She had said the trail ran west, and she had said the pull ran to the source, and she had said the source was her, all of it at the long table in the grey of the morning after, flat and plain and in fewer words than the night had cost her, and she had watched the three of them take it. Amber had gone still in the way that meant the question had grown again and would have to wait its turn. Alice had put the lid on the box of dry things. Raizen had not said anything, only come and stood at her shoulder so that the bond carried the weight of it both ways and she did not have to hold the whole of it in one body, which was the thing he did instead of speaking, and which was worth more than speaking, and which she could not have told him without spoiling.

And then, because the world did not stop for a girl to finish being afraid, the day had gone on. It was a Tuesday, or near enough; the days in Wend had stopped having proper edges since the rescued folk doubled the place, and one ran into the next on the same bread and the same turning mill. There were beans. There were always beans. Amber said a true thing about the beans and Viridia did not hear it, and the morning got itself spent the way mornings did.

She had meant to go up the gardens at noon and read the rim again in the flat light, to settle the count for the

going-west she had not yet worked out how to begin. She did not get to noon.

* * *

It opened at the mill.

She felt it the way she felt all of them now, the cold breath coming up under the source-sense, the small wrong subtraction starting somewhere in the warm crowd of the valley's cores, and her first thought, sitting on the orchard step with the beans, was *north*, was *the rim*, was the long reach out to the cold edge where the worn places wore, because that was where the cold had always come from, that was the road of the thing, the hamlet and the Hallow bridge and the trail in the west, and her sense went the wrong way first. It went up and out, north, along the road she knew the danger took, and found the rim quiet, and that quiet cost her the beat.

The beat was the whole of it.

Because the cold was not north. The cold was *close*. It was so close her sight should have had it before it opened, should have read the cloth of the world thinning at the mill the way she read a body's fever, a day before, an hour before, time to walk down to the place and set her hand on it and hold it while it was still only a thinning and not yet a tear, the way you press a thumb on a seam before it splits. A year ago her sight would have had it close like that, would have laid the near and the far down on the one map at once, would never have gone hunting north while the floor went out from under her own mill. But her sight was not a year ago. It was returning, layer by guttering layer, reaching further along the cold rim every month and still not whole, still thin at the near and short at the far both at once, a lamp turned low that lit the road ahead and left the doorstep dark.

She read the doorstep a beat too late.

She was on her feet and the beans were going off her lap and across the step and she was already running, the orchard, the gardens, the lane, the mill coming up grey-shouldered against the bright noon, and she ran with the counting going under the running the way it always went, the distance, the cores, the warmth thinning at the centre of the wrongness — and the warmth thinning had a face.

That was the thing. That was the part the count would not let her not-know. The faceless ones far off were arithmetic; she had told Alice as much. But the near ones had faces, and this one was near, and the face was the miller's wife, who had a name Viridia had never used because everyone called her the miller's wife, and who came to the long table four afternoons in five and bent over a still bowl and learned, a bowl at a time, to hold the dark half, and whose mother would have called the dark half a sin and who said so every single time and laughed her short laugh at herself for saying it, and who was, this noon, at the mill, where the wife of the miller would be, doing a wife's noon things, when the floor of the world parted under her.

* * *

She came round the corner of the mill and the tear was there.

It was small. That was the cruelty of it; it was the smallest one she had seen, no taller than a sitting child, a frayed rent low in the air by the grain bins where the cool shade pooled, a smear in the daylight with no heat in it, the worn place barely worn through, a thing a thumb on the seam an hour ago would have stopped before it was anything at all. And under it, where the cold spilled down off it the way a draught finds the gap beneath a door, was the miller's wife on the swept boards with the grey already in her, and bent over her,

drinking, the height of moving absence the eye slid off and could not hold.

Viridia did not look at the worst of it. She had learned that on the Hallow bridge, that there were things the carrying did not require the watching of, and she put her sight on the tear and her hand came up with the mark already in it, the unjoined ring and the line drawn inward toward the centre it never reached, because her hand knew the mark now, her hand had not forgotten the mark since the bridge, and she drew it on the air over the grain bins and the wrongness ceased to be a wrongness, folded shut along the line, the cold stopping, the rent that had been a rent becoming a place where nothing had ever been wrong, and it cost her nothing, and it took the length of a breath, and it was a breath too long.

The thing of absence, severed now from whatever fed it, came apart in silence, and she kept her eyes off the coming-apart, because she was already on her knees on the swept boards with her hand going to the place the warmth had been.

There was nothing left in it to read, and she had known before she touched it that there would be nothing. She put her hand where Alice put hers, the healer's reading that she had no right to and did anyway, and the core was gone down the cold the way Dell's boy had gone down the cold, drained sideways and out, not ended but *taken*, gone somewhere, gone along the long low current that ran down and down and west to a girl on her knees who had filled the source too full. The miller's wife's eyes were open and her hands were soft and there was flour on her apron and on the backs of her fingers, ordinary flour, noon flour, and one of the grain bins had its lid off because she had been into it for the noon bread when the floor went out, and Viridia knelt in the cool shade of the mill she had walked past a thousand times and

held a hand with nothing in it and did the arithmetic she could not stop.

A day, with whole sight. An hour. Time to press a thumb on the seam before it split.

She had gone north.

* * *

She did not weep. She knelt there on the swept boards in the noon shade with the mill turning its slow blind turn overhead, grinding nothing, going on the way the world went on, and she held the hand, because the not-weeping was a thing she did now without choosing it the way her hand drew the mark without choosing it, the grief going down inward to wherever the grief went, into the same low place everything went, and she let it be the size it was and made no sound at all, and her face held still, the flat hard certainty, holding because there was nothing else to hold.

She heard them come. She heard Amber's boots, quick, and then stopping quick, the in-breath that was not a word. She heard Raizen, unhurried even now, even into this, because the bond had carried it to him the instant it reached her and he had nothing left to be surprised by, only the coming and the standing-close. She did not hear Alice's feet at all, because Alice came up soft on a sickroom always, even running, the calm hands and the soft step the same craft, and the first Viridia knew of her was the warmth of her crouching down on the other side of the still shape, on the side away from Viridia, and Alice's hands going where a healer's hands go.

"She's gone, Vir," Alice said, low, the slow-way voice, the one for the living in a room with the dead. "She's been gone a few minutes. There's nothing." She was not telling Viridia a thing Viridia did not know better than anyone alive. She was telling her so that Viridia would have to hear it said, so it

would be a thing said in the room and not a thing carried alone, because Alice knew her, because Alice had known her over a desk years ago when Viridia was only a frightened clever girl learning to keep her face still, and Alice's whole craft was that she would not let a person carry the unbearable thing entirely alone in their own face. "Vir. Let go of her hand. Let me."

Viridia let go of the hand.

* * *

There were children.

She had not thought of the children, in the running, in the count; the count did not do children until they were in front of it. But there were two of them at the foot of the mill stair, a girl of perhaps six and a smaller one she was holding by the back of his smock the way a child holds a thing they have been told to hold, and they had been there the whole time, they had been there when the floor went out from under their mother, and they were not crying, which was worse than crying, they were watching, the way children watch a thing too large to have a shape yet, the way Viridia had watched her own once, and the smaller one was eating something, a heel of bread, eating it slow, because he was small and he was hungry and the world had not yet told him in a way he could hold that it had changed.

Amber went to the children. That was the thing Amber did, the going-quiet-and-useful the instant it counted, the dressing of nothing in something to do; she went down on her heels in front of them and said something low and cross and ordinary, beans probably, the goat probably, the small true crossnesses that were the one thing on earth that could make a six-year-old's shoulders come down a half-inch in a room with her dead mother in it, and the smaller one held out his half-eaten bread to Amber the way small ones do,

offering the thing they love most, and Amber took a polite bite of it and gave it back and the boy was, for one half-second, pleased.

Viridia watched that and held still and made no sound.

Raizen had come and crouched at her shoulder where the bond was, not touching, because touching was for after, and he looked at the swept boards and the still shape and Alice's working hands and the small clean place over the grain bins where the rent had folded shut, and he said, very quietly, only for her, "You closed it in a breath."

"A breath too late."

"I know." He did not tell her it was not her fault. He never told her a thing that was not true to make it sit easier; that was the whole of why she did not lie to him. "I know what you are doing in there. You are running it back to find the hour you should have caught it. Do not finish that. Not here. Finish it later, alone, the way you finish the bad ones, but not here, with the children watching, because the part of you that runs it back is the part that will keep you here on these boards, and the children need you to stand up."

She stood up.

* * *

They carried the miller's wife to the long table, which was where everything happened in Wend, the bowl-of-water lessons and the noon bread and now this, and they laid her on it, and Alice did the things a healer does for the dead that have nothing to do with healing and everything to do with letting the living look at them without flinching, the closing of the eyes, the folding of the soft hands, the flour wiped gently from the fingers because a thing like flour on a dead woman's hand is the kind of small wrongness that breaks a person who is holding on by the skin of the careful, and Alice knew that, and wiped it, slow, while the valley came.

They came because in a place of two hundred folded into a place built for forty there is no such thing as a death no one knows of by noon. They came down the lane and across the stream and out of the doubled gardens, and they stood at the edges of the long table the way people stand, and the miller came, the husband, who had been up the slope at the high terraces and had run the whole way down when the word reached him and had no run left in him by the time he got there, and he stood at the foot of the table and looked at his wife and did not understand, the way none of them ever understood the first minute, the death with no wound in it, no fall, no fever, no blade, only a woman who had gone for the noon bread and not come back from it.

"There's not a mark on her," the miller said. He said it to Alice, because Alice was the healer and a healer was supposed to have the next sentence. "She's not hurt. Look at her. There's nothing wrong with her."

"No," Alice said. "There's nothing wrong with her." And she did not say the rest, the *because the wrong went somewhere else, the wrong went down a cold the size of the world to a place none of you can see*, because it was not hers to say and it would not have helped him and it was, Viridia understood, standing at the table with her face held flat, the truest sentence anyone could have spoken over that table, and the cruellest, and Alice had the mercy not to.

Viridia did again what she had done at the Hallow bridge. She went round the table to the husband and she asked him the name, the wife's name, because she had never used it, because everyone said the miller's wife, and she made herself ask it and take it and hold it though she knew the name would make the weight heavier and she took the name anyway because the alternative was to let the woman go into the ground a *miller's wife*, a thing attached to a man and a building, and that was a worse thing than the weight.

The name was Sela. The miller said it, Sela, and then he said it again, the way people say the name twice when the first one does not believe itself, Sela, and his voice did the thing voices did, and his hands did not know what to do and went to his own face and came down again, and Viridia stood and held the name and kept her face still, because no one saw her do it, because she never did, and she carried Sela down into the low place with the rest, where she would feel it later, alone, the way she felt the worst sums.

* * *

It was Amber who said it, after, when the valley had thinned away and the children had been taken in by the woman three houses up who had milk to spare, and the four of them were at the long table in the going light with the still shape carried inside and the table empty and the bowls of water put away.

"It opened in the mill," Amber said. She was not crying either. Amber dressed the true thing in the cross thing, always, and the cross thing now was a flat hard fact she set down on the table between them like a stone. "Not the rim. Not three days north past Hallow. The mill. Where she goes for the noon bread. Where the children play on the stair." She looked at Viridia, the black nails flat on the cold wood. "You said the trail runs west. You said it's coming this way, opening as it comes, working east toward the warmth. Well. It got here. The road came to the door. That's what today was."

"Yes."

"And you didn't catch it." Amber said it without cruelty, which was the only way the true thing could be said. "You catch everything. You felt old Tem go before the knock came. You've been telling me for a year you feel every core

there is. And one opened in our own mill at noon and you didn't catch it till it had her."

Viridia was quiet. The mill turned. Somewhere far to the north and the west the rim wore a fraction wider, patient, in no hurry, and she did not keep her eyes off it this time. She made herself say the true thing at the start and not at noon, because Amber asked for it that way and because Sela had paid for the not-saying of it.

"My sight isn't whole," Viridia said. "It hasn't been whole since the cavern. It's been coming back across the year, a layer at a time, and I've been reading the rim with it and closing the tears with the mark and telling myself it was enough, and it reaches further north every month and I let that fool me into thinking it was getting *whole*, but it isn't whole, it's just *longer*, and a sight that reaches three days north and can't read its own mill floor is not a sight that protects anyone." She kept her voice flat, the thing that held. "A year ago, with whole sight, I'd have felt that seam thin a day before it tore. An hour at the worst. I'd have walked down the lane and set my hand on it while it was nothing and held it shut and Sela would be teaching the noon table tomorrow about how the dark half is a sin her mother wouldn't have held with. I went north. The cold's always come from the north, so I went north, and the floor went out under my own mill while I was reaching for the horizon, and the half-second it took me to bring my sight back home was the whole of the difference between a woman and a clean place over the grain bins." She looked at the empty table. "That's the cost of half a sight. It's not paid by me. It's never paid by me. The mark asks nothing of me and the half-sight asks nothing of me, and the bill goes to a woman with flour on her hands who never once asked to be protected by a girl with half her eyes."

Alice put her hand flat on the table, the way she had wiped the flour, the way she had wiped the mark from the spilled water at this same table. She did not reach for Viridia, because Viridia did not take being reached for, even now, especially now. She just put her hand down where Viridia could see it.

"You closed it in a breath," Alice said, which was the thing Raizen had said. "When you got there. You closed it before it could take the children. You came round that corner and your hand was already drawing it and the children are alive tonight because of the speed of you, Vir, the same speed that wasn't enough by a breath for Sela was enough by a breath for them." She said it plainly, the healer naming the whole of the bleed and not only the part that hurt. "I'm not telling you it's even. It's not even. There's nothing even about it and I won't insult you. I'm telling you the count has two columns and you're only reading one of them, the way you do, the way you've always done, you take the column that costs and you leave the column that paid, and a count with one column in it is the surest way I know to make a person hate themselves into being no use to anybody." She found Viridia's eyes. "Read both columns. That's the job. You taught me harder things over a desk once. Read both."

* * *

She went up the gardens that night, after the house was down, the way she did, to the high wall at the top where the cold edge of the world lay open to the part of her that could read it, and she did not go up to count the tears. She knew the tears. She went up to look at the thing the day had shown her, which was not a number on the rim but a truth about her own eyes, and she sat on the cold stone with her hands flat on it and let her sight unfold out to the limit of its reach.

It went north. It went out along the cold rim to the limit of its reach, which was further than a month ago, the worn places leaning in from the far side, the trail marching east, the count she would not let herself dwell on, six or seven and the fainter ones beyond, the road of the thing coming toward the warmth she had become. She could read all of that. She had got good at reading all of that, the far cold edge of everything, the leaning-in, the slow erosion of the rim.

And she turned her sight the other way, down, close, in, onto the valley itself, onto the two hundred sleeping cores folded into Wend, Amber's quick and even and finally still, Alice's banked and steady, Raizen's bright and strange and always knowing where she was, the children three houses up sleeping the bottomless sleep of the small that the worst day cannot keep them from, the goat, the orchard, the almond tree's slow green pressure at the garden bottom — and she pressed her sight into the near the way she had pressed it into the far, asking it to read the cloth of the world close to her, to read a seam an hour before it split, the way it would have a year ago, the way it had not at noon.

It would not. It guttered. The near went soft and uncertain the way the far edge of the reach went soft and uncertain, and she understood, sitting on the cold wall, the actual shape of what the cavern had taken and was giving back so slowly. The sight came back as *distance*. It had stretched itself thin and long across the year reaching for the rim, because the rim was where she had taught it to look, where the danger had been, and in stretching it had gone shallow, a thing all reach and no grip, and she could not read her own mill floor because she had spent a year teaching her own returning eyes to look at the far cold edge of everything and not at the warm woman going for the noon bread under her own roof.

It would keep coming back. It would keep coming back across more of the year, a layer at a time, the near filling in and the far reaching further, until one day it was whole again, both at once, the doorstep and the horizon. One day. Not this year. Not in time for Sela. Not, the cold part of her said, setting it on the scale without being asked, in time for the next one, or the one after that, because the tears were opening faster than her hand could close them and now faster than her eye could find them, and a sight that arrives a breath late at the mill is a sight that will arrive a breath late again, and again, and the bill for every breath would go to someone with flour on their hands.

She could wait for the sight to come whole on its own. That was one road. Close the tears one breath late, one drained core at a time, all year, and grieve them inward where no one saw, and wait the slow patient months for her eyes to knit, and call it the best a half-blind girl could do.

She did not take that road. She had taken the slow patient road for a year, the battening of shutters, the closing of footprints, the waiting, and Sela had died of it under her own mill while she reached for the horizon.

* * *

She had said it on the wall the night before, and she had thought she meant it then, but she had meant it the way you mean a thing you have worked out and not yet paid for. She meant it differently now, with flour wiped off a dead woman's hand and a small boy offering his bread to Amber, with her face held all day over a grief gone down inward to the low place where everything went.

She would go to the source.

Not to find the man in the west, the working, the hand, the stranger's mistake. That was a footprint and she had stopped believing in footprints. She would go to the source

itself instead, to the physical place, the cavern she had portalled into a year ago, the low rough chamber older than old, the pedestal, the pool that was not water, the one place in all the world the rim was actually leaning toward, because the rim leaned toward the source and the source was her, and a sight that could not read its own mill floor from a wall in Wend might read the whole rim true and clean if she stood at the centre of the pull with her own hand in the thing she had become.

She would go and stand where the warmth was heaped up and feel it pulling and read, with the source itself under her hand and not at the guttering far end of half a sight, exactly how full she had made it and exactly how far the cold had widened to meet it and exactly where, on the great cold edge of everything, the tearing truly began — not the man in the west, not the footprint, but the *thing*, the leaning, the first cause under the first cause. She could not read it from here. Her eyes were half eyes and the danger was teaching her, breath by drained breath, exactly how much that cost and who it cost it to. But there was one place a half-sight might see whole, and it was the place she least wanted to go, the scene of the making, the pool she had run too full, and that was where she was going, because the alternative was another noon, another mill, another name to take and hold and carry inward, and she had taken the name Sela today and she was not going to spend the rest of a long life learning names off the dead because she had been too slow and too careful and too kind to herself to go and read the truth from the one place it could be read.

She got down off the wall in the dark. The valley breathed its small sleeping warmths below her, the two hundred living on the warmth she had heaped up, the children three houses up sleeping, the miller not sleeping, his core a raw torn wakefulness she could feel and could not mend with

any mark or any mending, because grief was not a tear and there was no symbol for it and the only way to close it was the long way, a winter of afternoons, the way Alice did everything, and Viridia could not give him even that, because she was leaving.

She would tell them in the morning. She would say it plainly and in few words, the way she said the hard things. The half-sight had a cost and Sela had paid it and she would not let it keep being paid. There was one place she might see whole. She was going to the source.

She went down to her bed in the dark with the name Sela held in the low place where the grief went, and the worst sum of the day finished in her, and no one to give it to until morning, and her hand, lying open on the cold blanket, drew the mark once in the dark, without her asking it to, the unjoined ring and the inward line that unsaid the making, a thing that asked nothing and ended anything and could not, for all that it asked nothing and ended anything, have reached down the long cold current to where the warmth went and given a woman back her noon.

There was no mark for that. There was only going to the place it came from, and reading it true, and finding out at last, with whole sight or with half, what a girl who had wanted only to make the world whole was going to have to become to keep the world she had made from being eaten one noon at a time.

She would go to the source.

In the morning she would tell them. Tonight she held the name, and held her face still, and let the grief be the size it was, which was very large, and made no sound, and slept, eventually, the thin sleep of a girl with a long road in front of her and one more name than she had woken with.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Rim, Read Whole

There is a thing she had been doing for a year without naming it, which was keeping the count small enough to carry.

Not lying. She did not lie, not to Raizen and not to the count, because a lie in the count was the surest way she knew to come round a corner and find a woman drained on swept boards with flour on her hands. But there is a difference between a lie and a kindness you do yourself by not adding the next column, and she had been doing the second one all year, reading the rim out to the limit of half a sight and finding six tears, seven, the fainter ones beyond she could not resolve, and setting that number down and battening her shutters against it and going to her bed, and never once making her returning eyes reach past the resolving edge of themselves to ask the question under the number, which was not *how many* but *how wide*. How wide the cold had grown. How wide, and against what, and at what speed. She had kept the count to the tears she could close because the tears she could close were a thing a girl could do something about, and the thing under the tears, the leaning, the differential, the slow patient widening of the world's cold edge against the warmth she had made too great — that was not a thing a girl could close with a mark, and so she had let her half-sight be too short to read it, and called the

shortness of her sight a mercy, and never said the word mercy even to herself.

Sela had ended that. You cannot do yourself the kindness of a small count over a table you have laid a name on. The name was Sela and the kindness was over.

So she would go and read the whole of it, from the one place it could be read whole. That was the road she had walked down from the high wall in the dark, and she had not changed her mind by morning, and she told them in the morning the way she told the hard things, plainly and in few words, and they took it the way they took the hard things now, which was without arguing the thing itself and arguing only the shape of the going.

* * *

"Not alone," Amber said.

"Yes alone."

"You said that about the rim and the rim opened in our mill." Amber had her arms folded and her black nails dug into her own sleeves, which was the tell, the dressing of the fear in crossness. "You said *alone* a lot, the year before the war, and I watched where that road went. I'm not doing the watching part again. I've decided."

"It's a sealed chamber at the bottom of the world through a portal I draw with my own focus," Viridia said. "There's no road to it. There's no ground a tiger can stand on. You can't come because there's nowhere to come to, not because I won't have you." She let that sit, because it was true and because Amber would test it against the year and find it held. "If I could bring you down into a hole I have to be the source itself to reach, I'd bring you. I can't. No one can come where I'm going. That's not a thing about you. It's a thing about the place."

It was Alice who found the seam in it, the way Alice found seams. "How long does the sight take, when you get there. To come whole."

"I don't know. It came all at once, the once. But the once I had nothing of myself walled off and a war's worth of grief opening the whole of me, and I'm not going down there broken open. I'm going down there to read a number." She heard how that sounded, the flat hard certainty over the part that did not believe its own flatness, and she let it stand because correcting it would have cost more than it bought. "An hour. Less. I stand at the pool, I read the rim from the centre of the pull instead of the guttering far end of it, I find where the tearing begins, and I come back and we go to it. That's the whole errand."

"And the part where you stand in the thing you ran too full," Raizen said. He had not spoken until now. He was at the window with his ordinary brown eyes on the orchard, learning, still, after a year, how to be a man at a window in a morning, and he did not turn round to say it. "The part where you put your hand back in the source you became. You've said the errand. You haven't said that part."

"No," she said. "I haven't."

"I'm not asking you to. I'm saying it's there so you don't have to carry it being unsaid as well as carry the rest." He turned round then, and the bond carried what his face was careful not to, which was the thing it had carried all year, the weight of a long life with her in it and the particular dread of watching her go somewhere he could not follow even by the bond, because the bond reached to wherever he was and the source was the one place that was not anywhere. "Go. Read your number. But you take the going-down seriously, not just the number, because the last time you put your hand in that pool you came out of it the most alone a person has ever been, and that was when you were whole. You're going down

half-blind to a place that nearly kept you. Read the rim. Then come up. Don't stay down to be sure. Sure is the thing that keeps you."

"I'll come up."

"Say it again so I can hear you mean it."

"I'll come up, Raizen."

He looked at her a moment longer and then he nodded, once, and that was the argument over, because the thing about Raizen was that he asked you for the true sentence and then he believed it, and a person who believes your true sentence is a person you cannot afford to give a false one.

* * *

She drew the portal at the top of the gardens at noon, in the flat light, on the high wall where she read the rim, because it was the only place in Wend with sky enough open over it and because she wanted, foolishly, the last thing under her feet before the chamber to be the wall she had sat on the night she decided. The orchard breathed below. The almond tree stood its slow green vigil at the garden bottom. Amber stood at the wall's foot with her arms still folded and did not say anything else, having said it, and Alice stood beside her with the calm hands folded and the soft face that gave nothing to the wind, and Raizen stood a little apart where the bond ran clean, not touching, because touching was for after.

The portal-scroll was not a scroll any longer. She drew it now the way she drew everything now, with her own focus and her own hand, the racing chain of glyphs lit against the noon sky, the place-mark for the source set the way a man on a bench had taught her to set it years ago with two blank coins for eyes, except that the man was a scorch on a flag and the chamber was hers to reach without him. The air split along a line with no edges she could name. Dark on the far side of it. She did not look back at the three of them,

because she would not let herself look back and because the bond carried the look without her turning it, and she stepped through, and the seam sealed shut behind her without a sound, the way it had sealed on the girl who came before, the way a thing closes that means to keep her.

* * *

The cave was dark, and cold, and the only light in it came from a stone pedestal a few feet ahead, where something glowed.

She knew it before her eyes had it. That came first, before the cold, before the size of why she had come: she knew this place, low and rough and older than old, the walls unworked stone, the air still and dry and tasting of nothing but stone, of the deep places of the world that had never had weather and never would. There was no sound. Not the drip of water, not the stir of air, not the orchard, not the almond tree, not a tiger's breath or a healer's quiet or the strange clean pull of a bond. The silence had a weight to it, the silence of a room that had been waiting. It had waited for a clever tired first-year banking her core to an ember. It had waited for a broken-open girl come to mend the root of the world. It had her again now, a third time, half-blind and afraid and not broken open at all, only carefully, terribly intact, and the room did not care which girl she was. It only held its pool of pale even light and waited the way it had always waited, with all the patience of a thing the world is borrowed from.

She crossed the unworked floor to the pedestal.

In its hollowed top lay the pool, and the light came from the pool itself, a clean pale glow with no source above it or below it, only the liquid shining of its own accord, and it was not water. She had learned that the once, in the first half-second of touching it, and the once was enough, and she did not touch it now. That was the difference she had

promised Raizen and the difference she had promised herself: she had not come to put her hand in. She had come to stand beside it half-blind and let the nearness do what nearness did. Because her sight came back as distance, she had learned that on the wall, all reach and no grip, stretched thin and long across the year toward the far cold rim and gone shallow everywhere — but here there was no distance. Here the source was not three days north up the failing reach of half a sight. Here it was a hand's breadth from her face, the centre of the pull itself, the warmth heaped up to its very fount, and a sight too short to find its own mill floor across a valley might still read a thing it was standing inside of.

She did not touch the pool. She opened her sight beside it, slow, the way she opened it on the wall at night, and she waited to see what a half-blind girl could read with her eyes laid flat against the thing all eyes were a borrowing from.

It came back.

Not all at once and not as a tide; it was not the rebirth and she had not opened herself to be poured into. It came back the way warmth comes back to a hand brought in from the cold, the feeling arriving before you can use it, a prickling and then a flooding and then, all at once and without her choosing it, the long thin shallow reach of her year-stretched sight standing up off its shallows and going *deep*, the grip coming back into it the way grip comes back to a numb hand, the near and the far laid down on the one map at last, both at once, the doorstep and the horizon, the whole of it, the way it had been before the cavern took it. She could read her own mill floor from here. The thought arrived sideways and uninvited, savage: she could have read Sela's seam thin a day before from a thousand miles, with this, with whole sight, and she shut the thought because it was the

running-it-back Raizen had told her not to finish and this was not the place and she had work.

She had her eyes back. For an hour, in this chamber, a hand's breadth from the fount, she had the eyes she used to have.

She turned them on the rim of everything.

* * *

There is a way she had always read the rim, which was the way you read a coastline from a high place, the worn edge of the cold against the warm weave of the world, the leaning, the trail, the count of tears like wrecks on a shore. She had read it that way half-blind for a year and it had told her *six, seven, working east, coming this way*. She read it now from the centre of the pull with whole eyes, and the coastline was not a coastline. It was a tide line, and the tide was out, and she was looking for the first time at the whole width of the beach the sea had left, and the beach went further than her sight, which now had no further.

The rim of everything was the place that is not a place, the abstract counterpart to the well under her, the absence that balances the presence, the held breath against the full lung, the nothing the something is cut from. She had half-seen it at the rebirth as a girl going under, a shade at the far edge of a drowning, a thing she had filed and not followed because she had a war's worth of mending under her hand and no eyes to spare. *A shade*, the source had let her half-see, a year and a season ago. *No more than a shade*. That was the measure she had carried, the only measure she had: a shade wider than it should be, not enough for anyone to feel.

It was not a shade. It had not been a shade for a long time and it was not pretending to be one now.

She stood at the fount with whole eyes and read the differential, and the dread that had lived in her all year as a

feeling, a cold breath under the source-sense, a wrongness with no number, crystallised in the chamber's silence into measurement, and the measurement had a scale, and the scale undid the small count she had let herself carry the way a true number undoes a comfortable guess. The cold was not leaning in at six or seven worn places. The cold was leaning in along the *whole* rim, every span of the boundary of the world at once, the entire held-breath absence drawn taut toward the full lung she had made of the source, and the tears she had counted on her coastline were not the thing. They were only the places the cloth had already failed, the wrecks the tide left, and the tide itself, the great even drawing-in of nothing toward the something she had heaped too high, ran the whole length of the world's edge and her old count had read perhaps a hundredth of it.

She made herself put a number to it, because the part of her that reckoned would not let her not, because a dread without a number is a dread you can keep small and a dread with a number is a thing you have to carry true. The differential at the rebirth, the shade: she had it still, the feel of it, the way you keep the feel of a thing you touched once. The differential now was not twice that, not ten times that. She stood at the fount and laid the two against each other, the shade she remembered and the tide she read, and she did the sum and set it down and she had to brace her hand on the unworked stone of the pedestal's lip, not the pool, the stone, because the sum was so far past the shade that the shade was not a measure of it any more, the shade was a thing that had happened at the start of a thing, the first faint draught under a door before the door comes off its hinges, and the door was coming off its hinges, and she was the room the cold was coming into.

And it was not still. That was the part the silence gave her that no half-sight ever could have. On the wall at night the

rim looked patient, in no hurry, the slow erosion of a coast over a life. From the hub of it, with whole eyes, she felt it move. She felt the drawing-in have a *rate*, the way a fever has a rate, the way a body running down has a rate, and the rate was not the rate of a coast wearing over a life. The widening she had filed at the rebirth as a shade no one could feel had, across the year of her battened shutters and her small comfortable counts, grown not by addition but by the other way, the way a thing grows that feeds on its own growing, faster now than a season ago and faster a season ago than the season before, the curve of it steepening under her read like the long indrawn breath before something very large goes over an edge, and she understood, standing in the cold that had no weather, that the question she had kept small all year was not *how many tears*, was not even *how wide*, was *how fast*, and the answer to *how fast* was the only answer that had ever mattered, and she had passed a whole year not looking at it because no mark she had could close it.

The whole world was being pulled at. Not threatened, not attacked, not besieged at six or seven worn doors by a cold that meant it harm. Pulled. Drawn, evenly, along every span of its edge at once, toward the centre of the pull, and the centre of the pull was the source, and the source was the warmth she had poured the world too full of, and she knew already and from before this chamber whose hand had heaped it and she did not need the chamber to tell her again, that was settled, that was a year old and a name on a table old, that was not why she had come. She had not come to learn she was the axis. She had come to learn how large the wheel was that turned on her, and the wheel was the whole world's edge, and it was turning faster, and she stood at the hub of it with whole eyes for one hour and read exactly how vast the cold had grown against the warmth she had become.

It had widened past the shade the way the sea is past a glass of water.

* * *

She kept her eyes dry. There was no one to see, in the chamber, only the pool's pale even patience and the unworked stone, but she held them dry there too, because the holding was a thing she did now without choosing it, the same as the mark, the grief and the dread alike going down inward to the low place where everything went, and she let the scale be the size it was, which was the size of the world's whole edge, and made no sound at all in a room that had no sound to give it to.

And then, because she had not come for the scale alone, because the scale without a direction was only a despair and she had not crossed to the bottom of the world to bring back a despair, she did the second thing, the harder thing, the thing the fount could give her that the wall never could. She read the tide for its source-point.

A tide drawn evenly has no source-point; it is drawn toward the moon and the moon is everywhere over the sea at once. The cold drawn toward the source was like that, mostly, an even leaning of the whole rim toward the one centre, and if that had been the whole of it there would have been nowhere to go, no errand, no road, only the slow patient eating of the world one noon at a time until the shutters could not be battened any more. But it was not the whole of it. She read along the great even drawing-in with whole eyes, the entire boundary leaning the one way, and she found, the way you find the one warm spot in a cold sheet, the one place the leaning was not even. The one place the cold did not merely lean toward the source but *broke* toward it, a thinness in the rim sharper than thinness should be, a place where the cloth of the world was not

failing in the slow even way the whole of it was failing but failing *fast*, a fast worn place feeding the fast curve, a wound where the great even draught had a draught of its own running through it the way a river has a current faster than its banks.

It was not on her coastline. It was not north, where the cold had always come from, where she had drilled her shallow sight all year to look. It was the other way along the rim, off to the side of the world she had not learned to read because the danger had never come from there before, and she turned her whole-eyed sight to it and held it and read it the way she read a body's fever, the way she had failed to read Sela's seam, and she read where it lay against the warm weave of the world. It lay west.

It lay west, and it lay far, far past the trail she had been tracking east toward Wend, far past the Hallow bridge and the hamlet and the worn places leaning in, west and further west, to the grey edge of the maps she carried in her head, the grey west where the rescued folk had said the order had collapsed hardest and soonest, where a leaderless country had gone furthest into the chaos of sudden equals, and the fast worn place sat out there in the grey with an edge to it that the rest of the rim did not have, a clean sharp leading edge the way a tear has a leading edge and a slow erosion does not, the way a cut has a shape a wound from wearing never has.

And the reckoning, which she had not asked for and which did the sum without asking the way her hand drew the mark without asking, set the shape of it down beside the rest, and the shape was not the shape of something that had merely happened. It was the shape of something being done. The whole even rim leaned because she had heaped the source too full and that was no one's hand reaching in, that was only weight, only presence drawing absence the way it

always would, the cost of the mending, the bill of saving the world. But the fast worn place out west had a leading edge, and a leading edge is a thing that is being made, the way a tear is made and an erosion is not, and somewhere out in the grey west of the world, under the even great draught she had set running with her own full hand, something was reaching at the rim the way the council had reached at the root six hundred years ago, and widening it, and the widening it made fed the curve, and the curve was the thing that was getting fast.

She did not let herself name the something. She had stopped believing in footprints, she had said so over Sela's table; she would not climb out of this chamber with a man's face in her head she had invented from a leading edge. It was not a face. It was an inkling, a place on the rim where the even tide had a cut in it, a made cause under the made world, a hand she could not see and would not invent doing out west the kind of reaching that tore. That was all the fount would give her, and it was enough, because it was not despair and it was not nothing. It was a direction. The scale was the whole world and the speed was a curve steepening toward an edge and there was, for all of that, a place to put her feet. West. To the grey west, where the rim broke faster than weight alone could break it, where something with a hand was making the worst thing in the world worse, and no reach from here would reach it and no mark would fold it shut and no patient waiting-out would end it, because it would not end on its own, because someone was working it, and a thing someone is working is the one kind of cold in all the world that a girl might still walk to and put her hand on.

* * *

The hour was nearly up. She felt the grip going out of her sight the way warmth goes back out of a hand that leaves the

fire, the near beginning to soften first, the doorstep dimming while the far still held, the year-stretched shallowness rising back up under the deep she had borrowed, and she let it go, because Raizen had asked her to come up and not to stay down to be sure, and she was sure, she was as sure as the chamber would ever make her, and staying would only be the wanting to be more sure than the world allows, which was the thing that kept her.

She stood at the pedestal one moment more with what was left of whole eyes and did not touch the pool. She looked at it, the clean pale glow shining of its own accord, the well she had filled past its brim, the centre that the whole world's edge now leaned toward, and she felt the size of what she had done land in her not as guilt and not as despair but as the plainest fact she had ever held, plainer than Sela's name: she had wanted only to make the world whole, and she had made it whole, and a whole world heaped too full at its centre draws the nothing in toward it from every edge at once, faster and faster, and there is no mark for that, and there never would be, and the thing she had been afraid of all year was not that she might become what she fought. The thing she had been afraid of was true already and was not a maybe. She *was* the weight at the centre. The only question the fount had left her was the one she could still walk toward, which was the cut out west in the grey, the made worse, the hand at the rim, and whether reaching it and stopping it would slow the curve or only show her, the way every road this year had shown her, one more true thing she could measure and not mend.

She drew the portal home with the last of the grip in her eyes.

* * *

She came up out of the air at the top of the gardens in the late flat light of an afternoon, the hour gone in a breath the way it always went where the chamber was, and the orchard was below her and the two hundred sleeping and waking warmths of Wend lay folded under her returning, ordinary, half-blind sight, the near already soft again, the mill floor she would not be able to read tomorrow already going dim, and she let none of it pull her eye yet. She looked at the three of them at the foot of the wall, who had not moved, who had stood the whole hour the way people stand who have decided not to count the minutes out loud.

Amber's arms came unfolded. Alice's soft face did the thing it did, the held wind going out of it. Raizen did not say *you came up*, because the bond had told him the instant she did, the long thin braced wire of it singing whole again all the way to wherever it reached, and he only looked at her and let her see that he had been holding it the whole hour, the dread of the one place the bond could not follow, and that he had put it down now.

"Well?" Amber said, which was Amber's whole heart dressed in the one cross word.

She came down off the wall into the late light. She had a name held in the low place from yesterday and a number held cold from the hour, and the number was too large to lay down the way she had laid down Sela's name, so she set the part of it a person could carry, the way Alice had taught her to read the column that paid and not only the column that cost, the way you give people a road and not a despair.

"It's not six tears," she said. "It's not the rim wearing slow. It's the whole edge of the world leaning in at once toward the source, and it's getting faster, and I can't close it and I can't wait it out." She let that be the size it was and did not soften it, because they were not children and Sela had died of the not-saying. "But there's one place on the rim it

isn't only weight. There's a place out west where someone's hand is making it worse. The leaning's the bill for what I did, and there's no mark for the bill. But the hand out west is a thing with feet to walk to." She looked at the grey edge of the maps in her head, west and further west, the clean sharp leading edge of the cut sitting out there in the chaos where the order had fallen hardest. "Whatever's tearing it faster than weight alone, it's west. Somebody's working it. We don't wait for it to come east to the next mill. We go to it."

The almond tree kept its green at the foot of the slope, and the light went flat and gold over the doubled gardens, and far out west, past the grey edge of every map, the rim of the world wore a cut that had a hand in it, and the cut fed the curve, and the curve steepened, patient and not patient, unhurried and in a terrible hurry both at once, toward an edge none of them could see, and Viridia stood in the gold light with whole sight already guttering back to half and her feet pointed, at last, the right way along the rim, west, into the chaos, toward the made worse, into the second act of a thing she had set running with the one full unguarded hand she would carry to the end of a very long life.

She would go west. In the morning they would pack the dry things. Tonight she held the number, which was the whole edge of the world, and her face still, and a direction at last to put her feet to, and she gave nothing away, and the count of names she carried was still, for one more night, only one more than she had woken with, and she meant, with everything in her, to keep it that way west.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Man Who Picked Up the Chalk

The grey west was grey the way a thing is grey when no one has decided what to do with it.

They went on foot and by the few miles of the slow line that still ran, and then on foot again where it stopped, and the country changed under them the way a face changes when it stops being looked at. South of the capital the war had ended in a morning and left the houses standing. Out here the order had not so much fallen as let go, the way a hand lets go all at once, and the country had come down out of that grip into nothing in particular and was lying where it landed. There were towns with the doors off. There were fields no one had decided whose they were and so no one had sown. There were two men checking hands at a ford, not because anyone had told them to but because the checking of hands was a thing their fathers had done and a man reaches for the old shape of a thing when the new shape will not come, and Viridia showed them her hand because it was easier than the other thing, and they looked at the plain silver-blond girl and the plain dark-haired young man beside her and waved them across to a country that had no further use for them.

She read the rim as she went, half-blind, the way she read it everywhere now that was not the fount, and the cut she had found from the chamber held its place ahead of them,

west and further west, the one sharp leading edge in the long even leaning of the whole world's cold against the warmth she had become. It did not move. That was the thing she held onto, the small true thing under the largeness: a thing that is made stays where the hand made it. The even tide had no centre to walk to. The cut did.

Amber had argued the rim, on the wall, the night before they left, the way Amber argued the things she was afraid of. "If it's a hand," she had said, "then a hand can be talked to. That's better than weather. I'll take a hand."

"A hand can also not stop," Viridia had said.

"I know what a hand can do." Amber had not been talking about the rim then and they had both let it be unsaid, the murdered parents at eight and the shattered core, the things a hand could do, and Amber had folded her arms over her bitten nails and looked west into the dark and said the thing she said when she was most afraid, which was the small cross practical thing. "We'll need more bread than this. The line doesn't run out there and there's nothing to buy where there's no one selling."

They had brought more bread. It was a Tuesday when they crossed the last of the line, or near enough; Viridia had stopped keeping the days with any care once the days stopped mattering for anything but the count.

* * *

The lab was not hidden.

That was the first wrong thing about it, and she felt it before she saw it, the way she felt the wrong deaths before the knock. A thing that tears the world ought to hide, ought to be down a hole or behind a ward or at least up a road no one took. This sat in plain afternoon light at the bottom of a long bald valley the colour of a slate roof, a low stone building with a slate roof to match, squat and square and

unremarkable, a building that had once been a granary or a pumping-house or a county records office before the county that kept the records let go of itself, with a chimney that smoked and shutters that were drawn and a path worn to it across the bald grass by feet that came and went. Smoke from the chimney. Someone in there was warm and making tea.

And the rim broke over it. She came over the lip of the valley and her half-sight, stretched thin and shallow as it was, did not have to reach for the cut any more, because she was standing nearly on top of it, and the clean sharp leading edge she had measured from the bottom of the world lay across this bald grey valley like a fault, the cold drawing in through it the way water draws through a cracked hull, fast, far faster than the slow even leaning of the rest of the world's edge, a current inside the tide, and at the bottom of the current was the low stone building with the smoking chimney where someone was making tea.

"There," she said.

Raizen had stopped beside her. He did not see what she saw, none of them did, but he had walked beside her sight for a year and could read the place she pointed it. The faint prismatic shimmer ran off his fingers, the light of the thing he was that he could not stop being even in a man's shape, and he closed his hand to bank it, folding the glow back in like a banked coal. "It's a house," he said.

"It's the cut." She looked at the smoke. She had already run the sum, the way she ran every sum so the rest of her could survive the choosing, and what it returned to her was so plain and so small that for a moment she could not make it fit the size of the thing she had read from the bottom of the world. The whole edge of the world leaning in, the curve steepening toward an edge none of them could see, the sea past a glass of water, and at the bottom of the current a

chimney with tea-smoke coming out of it. "Somebody lives there," she said, and heard how stupid it sounded, and meant it anyway.

* * *

She knocked.

She had thought about not knocking, all the way down the bald slope, had turned over the shapes of the other ways in, the door taken off its hinge by a word, the shutter unmade, the whole low building unsaid around the man inside it the way the mark unsaid a door. She had the means to come in any way she chose. She had had the means for a year and the having of it was the thing she watched in herself the way you watch a fire you have not yet decided to let into the house. And in the end she knocked, with her knuckles, on the plain weathered wood, because a person who comes through your wall has already decided what you are, and she had not decided, and she would not let the means decide for her. That was the whole of it. She knocked because she could have done otherwise.

There was a silence on the far side of the door that was the particular silence of someone deciding whether to be home. Then a bolt, and the door, and a girl.

Not a girl. A young man, but young enough that the eye reached for *girl* first and corrected, slight, perhaps seventeen, with ink on the side of his hand from writing left to right and a smear of pale dust across one cheek he did not know was there, and the quick wary readiness of someone who has learned that the door is mostly bad news. He had a kettle's worth of warmth to his core and not a grain more, an ordinary candle of a gift, the kind the whole valley had carried before the morning the world changed, and over the top of the ordinary candle sat the new dark half everyone carried now, untouched, unlit, a tool still in its wrapping. He

looked at the three of them on the step and his readiness sharpened toward fear and then, oddly, toward something almost like relief, as if bad news arriving was at least bad news arriving, at least an end to the waiting for it.

"We don't," he started, and stopped, because there was no *we don't* that fit three strangers who had walked across a country to a building with no road to it. "Are you from the river district?" he said instead. "If you've come to check hands, his is," and stopped again.

"We've not come to check hands," Viridia said.

The young man looked at her hand anyway, the old reflex, and then was ashamed of looking, and the shame was the most hopeful thing she had seen in three days of a country reaching for the old cruel shapes. A boy who was ashamed of checking a hand. She filed it without meaning to, the way she filed the things she wanted to be able to feel again.

"Fen," called a voice from inside, thin and dry and not unkind, the voice of a man talking to a person he is used to talking to. "Who is it?"

The young man, Fen, did not answer right away. He looked at Viridia, and at Raizen's banked hand, and at Amber's folded arms and Alice's still calm face, and some animal part of him weighed the three of them against the man inside and came down, fractionally, on the side of the strangers, which she also filed, and which she would, much later, on a worse day, be glad past saying that she had seen. "People, Marick," he called back, over his shoulder, not taking his eyes off them. "I think you'd better come."

* * *

Marick was a small man.

She had built him larger, on the road, without meaning to, sizing the man by the size of what he had done. The hand

at the rim, she had thought, the made cause under the made world, and the hand had grown a man around it in her head, broad, certain, a council's worth of will. The man who came out of the back room wiping pale dust off his fingers onto an apron was none of that. He was perhaps forty, narrow in the chest, balding at the front with the hair grown long at the back to make up for it, spectacles pushed up onto his forehead and forgotten there, and he had the particular stoop of someone bent a whole life over books held too close to a lamp. There was chalk on his fingers. There was chalk worn into the creases of his knuckles the way coal works into a miner's, a chalk that had been there long before today, the dust of a thousand slates worked and wiped and worked again, and she looked at his hands before she looked at his face, because his hands were where the thing was, and his hands were ordinary, ink-stained, chalk-worn, the hands of a clerk or a schoolmaster or a man who copies out other men's sums.

He saw her looking. He did not understand the looking. He pushed the spectacles down off his forehead onto his nose, and behind them his eyes were tired and clever and faintly, permanently aggrieved, the eyes of someone who had spent forty years being cleverer than his gift would let him show, and he looked at the three travel-stained strangers in his doorway with the wariness of a man who has had the river district at his door, and under the wariness, plain as the chalk, the thing she had come three days to find and had not let herself name at the chamber: he was *pleased*. Some part of him, under the wary part, was pleased to be called on. A man does a great work in a low room with the shutters drawn and no one to see it, and a part of him waits, forty years, for someone to come and see.

"I don't know you," he said.

"No," Viridia said.

"Then I'll thank you to," and then he stopped, because Raizen had moved, only a little, only shifting his weight on his new feet the way he did, and the light of the thing he was had run off his fingers before he banked it again, a fast prismatic shimmer there and gone, and Marick's tired clever aggrieved eyes had caught it and gone very wide and very still. He knew a thing when he saw it. He had read about things like it in his bound volumes for forty years and had never once expected to see one stand in his doorway. "What are you," he said to Raizen, and it was not quite a question, it was the sound a man makes when the thing he has only read about walks in.

"A friend of hers," Raizen said, which was true and was also all the answer he gave anyone, ever.

And Marick turned back to Viridia, and looked at her again, the plain slight silver-blond girl who had nothing to show, no shimmer, no horns, no fang, nothing the eye could catch and call a power, and she watched the clever part of him try to fit her to the thing beside her and fail, and that failing was the most dangerous moment, because a clever man who cannot account for you decides either that you are nothing or that you are the answer to the thing he has been working, and she could not tell yet which way Marick would fall.

"You'd better come in," he said, "before someone on the road sees a dragon-thing on my step," and turned, and led them into the low stone room where he had picked up the chalk.

* * *

The room was a working room and it had been a working room a long time.

Slates everywhere, leaned against the walls, stacked, hung, every flat black face of them crowded edge to edge

with the close cramped mathematics of a man who could not buy enough slate to hold his thinking. Bound volumes, more than a poor man should own, more than a candle's wage could have bought, ranked and re-ranked and broken-spined with use. A bench down the centre under a hung lamp, and on the bench a great slate laid flat, the master slate, the one the others all fed toward, and on it, drawn large and clean and recent, the chalk-dust still loose in its lines where his sleeve had not yet smeared it, a symbol.

And past the bench, against the back wall, where the lamp's light went thin, the tear.

It was not large. That was the third wrong thing, after the not-hiding and the smallness of the man: the cut that drew the cold in faster than the whole rest of the world's edge was no taller than a doorway and no wider than a man, a vertical seam in the air with no frame to it and no edge she could name, the world stretched and frayed toward it, the lamp-light going in along its margins and not coming back. It was the smallest tear she had seen and the worst, because the others were worn-open places, the cloth failing slow under the even lean, and this one had a shape. This one had been *drawn*. The leading edge she had found from the fount was here a clean made line, the difference between a hole worn in a sleeve and a hole cut in it with shears, and she understood, looking at it, looking from the small clean made tear to the small clean made symbol on the bench, that Marick had not found a worn place and widened it. He had made a door where there was no door, with chalk, the way a man on a bench had once taught her to make a portal, and the door he had made opened on the one place a door should never open, the abstract cold past the rim, and the cold had come through it and was coming through it still, fast, patient, a current in the tide.

"You did this," she said.

Marick followed her eyes to the back wall and something crossed his face that she would spend a long time afterward trying to name, because it was not guilt and it was not fear and it was not even pride exactly. It was the look of a man showing you a thing he has made that he believes you do not understand. "I opened a severed-half working," he said, and there was, under the wary clever dryness, the smallest tremor of the thing he had waited forty years to say to someone who might know what it meant. "The fourteenth. From the old volumes. No one has been able to close the fourteenth working in six hundred years, because the fourteenth needs both halves of the gift held at once, and no one has held both halves in six hundred years." He looked at his own chalk-worn hands. "And then, a year ago, on a grey morning, I held both halves. I don't know why. No one came. No one told me. I woke and the dark half was in me, whole, six hundred years of severed depth handed to a candle that had spent its life wanting exactly this, and the fourteenth working lay open in front of me at last, and I." He stopped. The pride and the wonder of it were on him plain, and under them, very deep, where she did not think he could see it himself, the first cold thread of the other thing. "I had wanted to do it my whole life," he said. "Do you understand? My whole life. And then I could."

* * *

"There was a warning," Viridia said.

She had not known there would be until she said it. She had known it the way she knew the wrong deaths, from under the surface, from the shape of the thing. A working buried six hundred years deep, in the oldest volume a clever resentful candle could not stop buying: of course there was a warning. The council that severed the world and buried the

mark that ends things did not leave the door to the rim standing open with nothing pinned to it.

Marick's clever eyes flickered, and he did not answer, and Fen, by the door, where he had stood the whole time saying nothing, made a small sound. Not a word. The sound a person makes when a thing they have carried is said aloud by someone else.

"There was a warning," Viridia said again, to Fen now, because Fen was the one who would tell her true, and Fen looked at Marick and then looked at the floor and said, in a low voice, the voice of someone repeating a thing they had said before and been answered, "Under the symbol. In the oldest volume. The warning was written under the symbol in a hand so old it had near worn away, and he read it, I watched him read it, and I asked him what it said, and he said." Fen stopped.

"I said it didn't matter," Marick said. Flatly. Not ashamed. A man defending the one decision his whole small clever aggrieved life had been built toward. "It had worn nearly to nothing. I could make out perhaps half of it. A warning written six hundred years ago by men who cut the world in two and called it kindness, men who buried the things they were afraid of and called the burying wisdom, men who would have left me a candle forever because a candle is easier to rule than a fire. I read what I could of their warning." He lifted his chin. "And I decided that the men who broke the world were not the men I would take my caution from. I had spent forty years being made small by their kind. I picked up the chalk."

And there it was, the whole of him, and she saw it land in the room, saw Amber's arms tighten and Alice's still face go a degree stiller, because he was not wrong. That was the terrible thing, the thing she had come three days through a let-go country to find and had not been ready for: he was not

wrong. The men who buried the warning were the men she fought. The kindness that severed every core six hundred years deep was the monstrous thing. A man handed back the half of himself that had been stolen, who looks at the warning the thieves left and decides he will not be ruled by the people who robbed him, that man had reasoned exactly as she had reasoned, in a kitchen and a school and a year of war, that you do not take your caution from the hand that cut you. He had picked up the chalk for the same reason she put her hand in the pool.

"What did the half of it you could read say," she asked.

Marick was quiet a moment. The aggrievement went out of him for the length of it, and what was left was only a tired clever man who had got a thing he wanted. "It said the door does not close," he said. "That was the half I could read. *The door, once opened, does not close.*" He almost smiled, the smile of someone who had thought of the obvious objection long ago and answered it. "Which is what men write to frighten you off a power they want kept for themselves. Every buried thing has a curse written under it. The curse is how they bury it." He looked at the tear against the back wall, the small clean made door drinking the lamp-light. "It does not close. Well. I have been trying to close it the better part of a year. That much of the warning was true. I'll grant them that much."

* * *

She closed it.

She did not announce it and she did not weigh it, which was the thing she would think about afterward, on the bald grey slope, the not-weighing, that she had stood a year being afraid of the mark for exactly how little it asked, had made herself count what it cost even when it cost nothing, had told Alice you have to be the wall, and then a small clever man

had said *the door does not close* in a dry aggrieved voice and her hand had come up of its own accord, the way it came up now without choosing it, and drawn the mark.

It was not a large thing to draw. It never was. An unjoined ring, a single line drawn inward from the gap toward the centre it did not reach, the oldest and the simplest working there had ever been, the shape the council buried because a council that means to rule forever does not teach the shape that ends things. She drew it small and clean in the air over the bench, between herself and the made door, and the inward line reached back past the making of the thing to the breath before it was made and said, the way it always said, *no, once*. It did not fight the door. It unsaid it.

The tear ceased to be a tear.

It did not close like a wound or heal like a seam or knit the way the costly mending knit, hand over hand, warmth held in place until the parted threads remembered they were whole. It simply was not, all at once, the way a thing is not that was never made. The world stretched toward the back wall came unstretched. The lamp-light that had gone in along the frayed margins came back and lay ordinary on the stone. Where the cut had been there was a back wall, slate-leaned and chalk-dusted, a wall that had never had a door in it and did not remember one.

It cost her nothing. Every ounce of warmth still whole in her, the hour's walk not even spent, a breath drawn and let, and the worst made door in the world was a wall again, and the gladness of it rose in her the way it always rose, swift and warm and terrible, *that was easy, I could do that all day, I already want to do it again*, and she had a year's practice now at standing on the gladness the way you stand on a coal, so she stood on it, and she did not enjoy how little it cost, because Raizen had told her once not to and the

not-enjoying was a wall she had built one brick at a time across a whole spring.

Marick had made a sound when the door went. A small involuntary sound, the sound of a man watching forty years of wanting unsaid in a single breath by a girl who did not even seem to try. He stared at the back wall. He stared at his own slate, the symbol on it gone meaningless now, a key to a lock that was not there. "How," he said. "How did you. That took me. I worked the fourteenth for a year before the morning, and you," and he could not finish it, because there was no finishing it, because the thing she had done in a breath was the opposite of the thing he had spent his life on, the unmaking against the making, and a lifetime learning to make leaves a man no words for how cheap the unmaking comes to someone built for it.

"I'm sorry," she said, and meant it, and was not sure he heard.

* * *

And the pull did not slow.

She felt it the instant the door was gone, because she had her half-sight laid against the rim out of long habit, the way you keep a hand on a rail, and she had been braced for the thing she had crossed a country for: the slackening, the current going out of the tide, the fast-worn cut sealed and the curve she had stood at the centre of easing back toward the slow even lean of the rest of the world, the made worse made un-worse, the hand stopped, the thing with feet to walk to walked to and put a hand on and ended. She had let herself want it the whole grey way west, the small clean hope of it, that there would be a cause and the cause would have a face and the face would have a hand and the hand could be stopped, and that stopping it would matter, would be the kind of true thing you could measure *and* mend, for once,

just once, after a year of measuring things she could not mend.

The door was gone, and the rim leaned in exactly as hard the instant after as the instant before.

She stood in the low stone room with the chalk dust settling and read it again to be sure, made herself read it twice, three times, the whole even tide of the world's cold drawing toward the warmth she had become, and where the cut had been, where the current had run faster than the tide, the river inside the river, there was now only the tide, the same even patient steepening lean, no slower for the door's unmaking by any amount her whole-numbered dread could find. The cut had been real. The cut had drawn the cold faster. And the cut had been a *symptom*, a place the leaning pressure had found a man foolish and clever enough to give it a door, the way water under pressure finds the one cracked stone in a wall and runs through it, and you can mortar the cracked stone, you can unmake the very door, and the water does not slacken, because the water was never the door. The water was the pressure. The pressure was the differential. The differential was the whole rim leaning toward the source, and the source was her, and Marick's door had only let the cold in a little faster in this one bald valley and had never, not for one breath, been the thing that was tearing the world.

She had found the proximate cause. She had named it and closed it and it changed nothing.

* * *

She must have made some sound, or none, or only stood too still, because Raizen was beside her, and the bond carried what her face would not, and he said, low, only for her, "You closed it."

"I closed it."

"And."

"And nothing." She heard her own voice come out flat and hard over the part that did not believe its own flatness, the careful surface laid down over the place where the small clean hope had been a breath ago. "The cut's gone. The pull's the same. I've spent three days and a country walking to the hand at the rim, and the hand at the rim was a tired clever man who read a warning he couldn't finish and picked up a piece of chalk, and I've closed his door, and the world is leaning into me exactly as hard as it was leaning a minute ago, because his door was never the tear. His door was a leak in the tear. The tear is," and she did not finish it, in the room, in front of him, because Fen was three feet away with his ink-stained hand and his ashamed-of-checking-hands shame, and Marick was at his bench staring at a wall that did not remember its door, and they did not need to hear the rest of the sum, which was the oldest sum she had, a year old and a name on a table old and now confirmed in a bald grey valley past the edge of every map: *the tear is me. The pressure is the rebirth. There is no hand at the rim to stop. The hand at the rim was mine, and I cannot draw the mark against myself, because you do not draw a symbol against the weight of your own full hand.*

Marick had turned from his wall. He was looking at her the way the clever look at a thing they have just understood, the spectacles down his nose, the chalk in the creases of his knuckles, and she saw the question forming in him, the dangerous one, the one a clever man who cannot account for you finally arrives at. "You felt it," he said slowly. "When my door went. You felt something not change. You're reading something I can't read." His tired aggrieved eyes had a new light far back in them, and it was the worst light she had seen on the whole grey road, worse than the hand-checkers at the ford, because it was *recognition*. "You closed the fourteenth working in a breath and it didn't matter to you

whether it closed, because you're listening to something larger than my door." He took a step toward her, not threatening, the opposite of threatening, the step of a man toward the one person in the world who might finally see the thing he sees. "What are you listening to? What's so large that closing the door to the cold past the rim doesn't even,"

"Don't," she said.

She did not say it loud. She said it the way she said the things that were true, plainly and in few words, and he stopped, because the flatness of it had a wall behind it he could feel without seeing. But she watched the question go into him and lodge, the clever resentful forty-year wanting turned now toward a new and larger thing, and she knew, the way she knew the wrong deaths, that she had not stopped anything by coming here. She had closed one door. She had left, in a low stone room in a let-go country, a clever culpable sympathetic man with both halves of the gift handed to him unearned and a brand-new question lit at the back of his tired eyes, the question of what a plain silver-blond girl was listening to that made the cold past the rim a small thing, and beside him, by the door, a slight young assistant with ink on his hand who had come down, when it counted, fractionally on the side of the strangers, and who was watching all of it, and who said nothing, and who filed it away in whatever low place a boy keeps the things he is not ready to know.

The chalk dust settled on the bench. The mark she had drawn over the closed door hung a breath in the air and went. The wall did not remember its door, and the rim leaned in, and Viridia stood in the unremarkable afternoon light at the bottom of the long bald valley, the proximate cause found and named and shut behind her, with nothing slowed and nothing mended and the whole even weight of the world's cold drawing toward the warmth of her own full

hand exactly as hard as it had drawn before she knocked, and understood that she had walked three days west to learn the one thing she had already known at the fount and had let herself hope, just this once, the road might unsay: there was no hand to stop. There had only ever been hers.

"We can't fix this here," she said, to Raizen, to all of them, to the room. "He's not the cause. He's just the first one who'll work out what I am."

CHAPTER NINE

Drake's Daughter, Again

She went up the way she had gone up the first time, into the wind and the thin biting cold of a place the air had given up most of what made it kind, and she came out of the seam standing, because she had learned years ago that the black rock did not catch you, it only let you arrive.

She had not told them she was going, not at first. She had told Raizen, because she could not not tell Raizen, and because the going was as much his as hers, his father at the top of it. But she had told the others only that she would be a day, perhaps two, and Amber had looked at her over the bread she was wrapping and said, "A day where," and Viridia had said, "To ask someone who's old enough to know," and Amber had let it stand, which from Amber was a gift, the question filed and not pressed, because some questions a person trades for the right to ask a worse one later.

Raizen had come up the seam half a breath behind her. He stood on the black rock now in his man's shape, dark-haired, ordinary-eyed, the wind taking his coat, and the only thing about him that was not a man's was the attention behind the eyes and the faint prismatic shimmer that ran off his fingers when the cold made him forget to bank it. He had been quiet the whole way. He was quiet the way a person is quiet who is coming home to a place that was never quite his, who had been born on this rock and

learned to be a dragon on it and had never once stood on it as the thing he was now.

"They'll know I'm different before they see me," he said. It was not quite a question.

"They'll know everything before they see you," Viridia said. "They always do." She looked up the height, into the grey, to the place the old one was always lying before her, and he was. He was there the way the mountain was there, a darkness laid along the high stone with no edge the eye could find, the single banked coal of his open eye watching them arrive out of the seam, and beside him, lower, close to the ground the way she grieved close to the ground, a deep scarlet shape gone almost black in the failing light, and Viridia felt the old fear of them go through her, the clean true fear a small warm thing feels in the presence of something six thousand winters deep, and she kept her back straight under it, and she walked toward them across the cold.

* * *

"You came by yourself," Drake said, and then, "No. You did not. You brought the rabbit." The coal eye moved past her to Raizen, and held, and something went through the enormous banked dark of him that she had no word for, the way a fire shifts when a thing it had given up on comes back into the room. "On two legs. Walking. Looking at his own feet to keep them under him."

"Father," Raizen said.

"Do not. Do not say it gently, as if I am a thing that breaks." But the old voice had gone rough in a way the wind did not account for, and the great head came down off the high stone, down the long slope of the dark, until it hung level with the two of them, near enough that his breath moved their hair, the breath of a thing that breathed jet-black death-flame and was, just now, only breathing.

"You gave up the wings," Drake said. "You gave up the sky and the fire and the six thousand years and you took a man's small handful of them instead, for her, and you stand on my rock looking at your feet, and I find I cannot decide whether to grieve it or be glad, and a thing my age does not often meet a feeling it cannot decide." The eye banked low. "So I will be glad, and grieve it later, which is a privilege of the old. Come here, rabbit. Let your mother see your ridiculous brown eyes before she pretends she does not care to."

* * *

Varissa had not moved the whole while.

She moved now. She came up off the ground without seeming to gather herself to do it, the way fire stands up off a coal, and she crossed to her son and put the great scarlet head down close to him, the gold-white centre of her eyes fierce and present and now, nothing old in them the way there was in Drake's, only the fierce now of her, and she breathed him in, the new shape of him, the wrong small warm two-legged shape of the child she had borne to the sky.

"You smell like a person," Varissa said. It was not kind. It was not unkind. It was the flat appalled fact of it. "You smell like bread and cold and a woman who is not your kind. You smell like a thing that will die in eighty years if it is lucky, and take the long part of my son's life into the ground with it, because that is what the bond does, that is what it has always done, and I told him, I told him on this rock when he was small enough to ride my back, do not tie your life to a thing that ends, and he did it anyway, the day he met her, before she was even grown." The flame guttered along her jaw. "I have hated you for that, girl. I want you to know it plainly, because I am not Drake and I do not weep my truths out over three days, I say them once and mean them. I hated you for a

year for being a thing that ends, that he tied himself to. And then you did not end. You poured yourself out into the whole world at once and you did not end, and you mended the gift for every living core there is and you came up off the bottom of it, and I find I do not know what to do with a daughter-in-law I cannot kill in my heart anymore." She drew back her head. "It is very inconvenient."

"I know," Viridia said.

"You do not. You are sixteen. You know nothing convenient or otherwise." But the flame had gone down, the way it had gone down once before on this rock, guttered and shrank to a glow at the edge of the jaw and then to nothing, and Varissa folded back down close to the ground beside her son, and Raizen, after a moment, sat down on the cold rock beside her, leaning the new small length of him against the great scarlet flank, and she did not move him away.

* * *

"You did not climb my mountain to let my mate insult your stomach," Drake said. "You came to ask a thing. Ask it. I am old and the light is going and you are cold, though you would die before you said so. Ask."

Viridia sat down on the stone where she had sat the first time, the cold coming straight up through her, her mother's blue stone cool at her throat, and she asked it the way she had learned to ask the old one, which was not to dress the question or lead up to it, because he had no patience for the run-up and would only wait, banked, until she stopped.

"There's a wrongness at the edge of the world," she said. "I've been reading it since the autumn, since my sight came partway back. Tears wearing open along the rim, and things coming through them that aren't alive, that drink the warmth out of people and leave them empty. I went looking for the cause. I found a man with chalk on his hands who'd

opened a door he shouldn't have, and I closed his door, and the wrongness didn't slow by so much as a breath." She made herself say the rest of it level. "Because his door wasn't the wrongness. It was a leak in the wrongness. The whole edge of the world is leaning in toward the warmth, all at once, and the leaning is getting faster, and I read it whole from the source and it's vast, it's the sea past a glass of water, and I can close every door a fool ever draws and it won't matter, because it isn't doors. It's a pressure. And I came to you because you're old enough to have seen a pressure before, and I need to know how it gets closed."

The wind dropped. The whole mountain seemed to wait around the question, the way it had waited around the old grief the first time.

"It does not," Drake said.

* * *

He was quiet a moment after he said it, the coal eye gone down the centuries the way it went, and Viridia held her silence, because she had learned that the only true answer to a thing this old was to give it the room to finish.

"I told you about my daughter," Drake said. "On this rock, the morning I taught your hand the mark. I told you she flew at a door she should have flown around, a great standing door the severing-hands tore into a place that is not a place, and that what came through it did to her what it does to everything, made her into nothing, and I knelt in the place where she had been and there was nothing to carry home. I told you all of that." The eye came back. "I did not tell you what I have understood since. Because you were a child with a war on your back and you did not need the rest of it, and now you are a child with a world on your back and you do."

"Tell me."

"The door I shut." Drake's great head settled lower against the stone. "I used the mark on it. The oldest one, the unjoined ring with the line run inward, the one you have used now, I can smell it on you, you have used it more than once and it has begun to be easy, which I warned you of and will not warn you of again because warnings spend themselves. I drew the mark on the door that killed my daughter and the door simply was not, anymore. One stroke. One breath. And I knelt there in the place where she had been, where the worst thing in six hundred years of my life had just been unmade by a thing so easy it frightened me worse than the door had, and I thought I had won. I thought I had ended it." The coal of the eye dimmed and steadied. "I had ended a door, child. I had not ended the thing that wanted the door."

"The pressure," Viridia said.

"You have a word for it already. Good. I had to find mine the long way." The wind moved over them. "The severing-hands did not invent the cold past the rim. No hand invented it. It was there before there were hands, before there was a rim to be past, before the source your kind drinks from was anything but a warmth with nothing to lean against. There is a warmth and there is a cold, child. There is a presence and there is an absence. They are not a war. That is the thing your kind has never been able to hold in its small bright head, that they are not a war, that the cold is not evil and the warmth is not good, they are the two halves of a single breath, the lung filling and the lung emptying, and a thing that only fills is not alive, it is only swelling, and a thing that only empties is only dying. The world is the holding of the breath between. The source on the one side and the absence on the other, leaned against each other, even, so that neither falls into the other. That is

the world. That is the only world there has ever been. Not the warmth. The *balance* of the warmth against the cold."

* * *

"My daughter's door," Drake said, "was a hole the severing-hands tore in the held breath, on the warmth's side, and through it the cold came rushing the way a low place pulls water, not because the cold was hunting her, the cold hunts nothing, it does not want, it only goes where the wall is thin and the pressure sends it. They had cut the breath. They had made one side fuller than the other, and the cold poured into the fullness through every door they tore, and my daughter flew at one of the doors thinking it was a wall to be broken, and it was not a wall, it was an absence wearing the shape of an opening, and you cannot push an absence closed, you can only unsay it, which is what the mark does, and so I unsaid the door." The great head turned, slow, in the cold. "And the cold went on leaning. There were other doors. There are always other doors, where the breath is uneven, because the cold finds the thin place the way water finds the cracked stone, and you can unsay every door you find and you will spend your life finding them, and the leaning does not slacken, because the door was never the leaning. The door was where the leaning showed."

"That's what happened in the valley," Viridia said. Her voice had gone flat, laid down level over the place underneath. "I closed his door and the rim leaned in exactly as hard the instant after."

"Then you already know the shape of it, and you climbed all this cold rock to be told a thing you knew, which is a thing the frightened do, and I do not blame you for it." The eye held her. "The mark closes a door. There is no mark for a pressure. There has never been a mark for a pressure,

because a pressure is not a making, it is not a thing a hand did that another hand can unsay, it is the lean of one whole side of the world against the other, and you do not draw a symbol against the weight of the sea." He let that sit. "I have closed a hundred doors in six hundred years, where the breath ran uneven and the cold came through. I have never once made the breath even. I do not know how. I am six thousand winters old, child, and the oldest thing I have learned is the size of what I cannot do, and the evening of the breath is past me. It is past my kind. It was even when I was young, even, near enough, that the doors were rare and a creature could shut them as they tore and call it tending. It is not even now."

* * *

Varissa stirred against the dark. She had been still as banked iron the whole while, her son leaned against her flank, and when she spoke it came up out of the deep register of her, low, and the fierce now of it had gone somewhere stranger.

"It went uneven a year ago," Varissa said. "I felt it. He felt it. Every old thing on every mountain felt it, the morning the breath shifted, the warmth side filling, the lung drawing too full, the held breath gone harder to hold the way any breath goes harder the fuller the lung. We did not know why. We thought, a working somewhere, a fool with a door, the usual small wrongness. We did not think." She turned the gold-white eyes on Viridia, and there was no hate in them now, which was somehow worse than the hate had been. "We did not think it was a *mending*."

The rock went very quiet. Even the wind seemed to wait.

Viridia did not move. She had already run the sum, the way she ran every sum so the rest of her could survive the choosing, and it had been sitting in her since the fount, older

than the fount, old as her mother's name run down into the source, and she had known it in the valley with the chalk dust settling, *the tear is me, the pressure is the rebirth*, she had known it and said the half of it she could bear and filed the rest. But there is a difference between a thing you have worked out alone in the dark and a thing said back to you in the deep voice of a creature five thousand winters old who felt it happen from a mountain, and the difference went through her like the cold off the rock face, and she set her free hand flat against the stone to steady what it did to her, the way she had once steadied what the easiness of the mark had done to her stomach.

"Say it," she said. "Whatever you've worked out. Say it plainly. I'd rather have it from a thing that doesn't lie."

* * *

"The tiger does not lie either," Drake said, "but the tiger is gone home to his forest, and you are stuck with me, who is worse, because I am older and I have less left to lose by saying the whole of a thing." The great head came down the last of the distance and lay flat on the stone, level with her, the way a thing lies down that has been standing a very long time, and the coal eye was close enough now that she could feel the low heat banked behind it, the death-flame held kind. "You did a thing a year ago that no one has done in six hundred years and that perhaps no one has ever done. You mended the severing. You took the gift that the cutting-hands broke in two, the giving and the taking, the warmth and the part of the warmth that ends things, and you put it back together in every living core there is, all at once, with your own hand in the source. You made the world whole the way it had not been whole since before the cutting." He breathed, slow. "You made the warmth side of

the breath fuller than it has been in six hundred years. You ran the lung full."

"I gave them back what was stolen." It came out before she could file it, the flat voice cracking the smallest degree at the edge, the one human failure, and she held the crack to the edge and no further. "It was *taken* from them. Six hundred years of every core cut in half for a council's idea of safety. I gave it back. That isn't a wrong thing. That can't be the wrong thing."

"It is not a wrong thing." Drake's voice did not rise. It came down the slope slow and even as it always did, and that was the worst of it, that he did not argue, that he simply laid it out. "Hear me, because this is the thing you climbed my mountain not wanting to hear and will spend the rest of your long unfair life carrying, so hear it once, clean. It is not a wrong thing. The cutting was the wrong thing. The mending was right, as right as a thing can be, and I would have you do it again, knowing what I am about to tell you, because a world cut in half is a world half-dead and you would not let the world stay half-dead, and that is the best of you, that is the thing my son tied his life to. The mending was right." The eye held her, terrible and kind in the way only very old things are both. "And it ran the lung full. It put the warmth all the way back, the whole of it, after six hundred years of the cold leaning on a wall that was only half a wall, and the cold did not change, the cold never changes, it only leans, and now there is so much more warmth for it to lean toward. You did not make the cold. You did not call it. You made the warmth whole, and the wholeness is what it leans against, and the fuller you made the lung the harder the held breath is to hold, and the doors the fools tear are only where it shows, the way my daughter's door was only where it showed. The wrongness at the rim is not a thing that came for you. It is the cold finding the new fullness you made, the

way it has always found the fullness, only there is more fullness now than there has been since the world was cut, and so there is more leaning, and the leaning steepens because the more the cold takes the more uneven the breath, and the more uneven the breath the harder the cold leans, and a thing that feeds on its own going gets faster, which you have already seen, which is why you are here with your hand flat on my rock and your face doing the thing it does instead of weeping."

* * *

She let none of it show. She had not wept on a mountain or anywhere else, not since the once, and she did not now. She sat with her hand flat on the cold stone and let the whole of it come down the slope at her like the scree, and she made herself hold it, all of it, so the rest of her could stay where it was.

"Then I made the next threat," she said. "By curing this one. I gave them back the half of themselves that was stolen, and the giving back ran the lung full, and the full lung is what's pulling the cold in, and every person the Horrors have emptied since the autumn was emptied because I." She stopped. She did not finish it in front of Raizen, who had gone very still against his mother's flank, who carried what her face would not down the bond and was carrying it now, she could feel it land in him. "Every name I've taken at the long table traces back to my cure," she said instead, which was the same thing with the worst word left out.

"Yes," Drake said.

"And there's no mark for it."

"There is no mark for it. The mark closes a door. This is not a door." The great head did not lift off the stone. "You came here to be handed a thing the way I handed you the ending mark, a stroke and a breath and the worst thing in

the world unsaid. There is no such thing here. I do not have it. I am the oldest thing you know and I do not have it, and I will not send you down my mountain pretending the lack is smaller than it is, because you taught yourself a year ago not to be a person who makes a thing smaller than it is, and I would not unteach you that to spare you a cold ride home."

"Then what." She heard her own voice come out level and stripped, the way it always did at the edge of too much. "If it can't be closed. If there's no stroke and no breath. What do you do with a pressure you made and can't unmake and can't draw a symbol against?"

* * *

Drake was quiet for a long time. The light went out of the grey over the rock, degree by degree, until the only warmth on the height was the banked coal of his open eye and the small fires Raizen's hands threw when he forgot to hold the shimmer in, and Varissa lay still as banked iron with her child against her, listening, close to the ground.

"You do not close it," Drake said at last. "You hold it. The way the world holds it, the way the world has always held it, before the cutting and after, the held breath that does not fill all the way and does not empty all the way, the warmth leaned against the cold even enough that neither falls into the other. You do not beat the cold. There is no beating the cold, the cold is half the breath, a person who beats the cold has stopped the lung emptying and a lung that only fills is not alive, it is swelling, and swelling bursts. You do not give back the cutting either, do not let me see that thought finish on your face, you will not un-mend the world to ease the lean, that is the cold winning by your own hand, that is you doing the cutting-hands' work for them and calling it mercy, which is the oldest trap there is and the one you were made to refuse." The eye held her, banked and steady. "You find

the evening of it. The warmth full and the cold acknowledged, the breath held even, the world made sustainable instead of made *safe*, because safe was the cutting and sustainable is the thing the cutting was too frightened to attempt. I do not know how it is done, child. I have told you already the reach of what is past me. But I know it is not done by closing a door, nor by winning, nor by deciding for every soul that breathes the way the cutting-hands decided, and you knew all three of those before you came, which is why I trust you with the knowing of the fourth thing, which is that it has to be *balanced*, and balance is a thing you tend forever, not a thing you do once and set down."

"Forever," Viridia said.

"You are True-Bonded to a creature who will outlive almost everything you love. You already know the shape of the word *forever* better than any sixteen years has a right to." Drake's great head shifted on the stone, and the banked coal of his eye went, for a moment, to his son, leaned against his mother in a man's small wrong shape, and back. "You will not fix the world. Put the word down. You did not fix it a year ago and you will not fix it now. You will balance it, if you are very good and very lucky and very willing to carry a weight that has no last day to it, and you will hand the balancing to whoever comes after, and they will hand it on, and that is not a defeat, child, that is the only thing that was ever true, that is the breath the world has been holding since before there were hands to fear the holding of it. The cold is not your enemy. The cold is the counterpart. You made the warmth whole. Now you learn to be the wall that holds the whole warmth even against the whole cold, and there is no symbol for being a wall, there is only the being of it, every day, forever, which is the bill you signed when you put your hand in the pool, and which you did not read, because no one

reads that bill, because if they could read it no one would ever mend anything, and the world needs mending by people too young to read the bill."

* * *

The wind came back up off the rock face and went through the three of them, and for a while no one said anything, the old grief and the new one sitting together on the height in the dark, and Viridia let it sit, because some things are not answered, she knew by now, they are only carried, and the carrying is the answer.

Raizen got up off the stone. He came across to her on his new feet, not wobbling, the way he had not wobbled since the change, and he sat down beside her in the cold and did not put his arm around her, because she did not like to be held when she was still doing her sums, and he knew it, and he sat close instead, close enough that the wind could not get between them, and let the bond carry the thing his hands would not.

"He's telling you it's the rebirth," Raizen said, low, only for her, though both dragons heard, because there was no not being heard on this rock. "The whole of it. Not Marick. Not a fool with a door. The pull is the cure. You've known it since the fount. You've been carrying it folded up since the fount, hoping the road west would unsay it, and it didn't, and now the oldest thing either of us knows has said it back to you out loud."

"Yes," Viridia said.

"And he can't fix it. And neither can I. And neither can the source."

"No."

Drake's great head lifted off the stone, slow, the way a thing rises that has lain down a very long time, and the banked coal of his eye found her in the dark, and what was

in it was not comfort, because he did not lie, and a comfort here would have been a lie.

"I have grieved an absence for six hundred years," Drake said, "and I have closed a hundred doors, and I have never once been able to make the breath even, and I have made my peace with the size of what I cannot do, which is the peace of the very old. You are not very old. You are sixteen, and you have a world leaning into you because you made it whole, and you cannot close the leaning and you cannot win the leaning and you cannot give back the wholeness to ease the leaning, and the only thing left to you is the hardest thing there is, which is to hold it, even, forever, and learn the holding as you go, with no mark and no master and no end to the tending of it." The eye banked low, the lesson done, the way it had banked low the first time, the day he had taught her hand the thing that ends and warned her she would hate how easy it was. "That is the truth you came up my mountain circling, child, and would not let yourself say at the bottom of it, and here it is, said plainly by a thing that does not lie: the wrong thing at the edge of the world is not Marick, and it is not a door, and it is not anything you can draw a symbol against. The wrong thing at the edge of the world is the shape of what you did to save it. It has your name on it. And there is no closing it. There is only learning to hold it, and you had better start learning, because the breath is getting harder to hold every season, and you are the only wall there is."

CHAPTER TEN

Absence Drawn to Presence

She had thought, climbing down off Drake's mountain in the dark with the truth said out loud at last, that the saying of it was the worst of it, and she had been wrong, and she found out how wrong she had been three days later in the dark of the source-cavern with her sight come back the whole of the way.

It did not come back at the mountain. It came back here, where it had gone, the way a thing returns to the room it was lost in. The cavern she reached by the road she knew, alone, the low rough chamber and the unworked walls and the pedestal with its pool of pale even light that was not water and never had been, and she stood over it the way she had stood over it twice now in her life, and the third standing was the one her sight chose to finish on. It came up in her like warmth returning to a numbed hand, the prickle and then the ache and then the full burning of it, the lattice laying itself back over the world for her to read, the cores lighting one by one out past the cavern walls, the threads, the deep humming weave of everything, all of it sharpening at the edges as the wick she had burned to nothing here a year ago caught at last and ran full again. She held still and let it finish. A year she had waited for this. There had been nothing in that year she had wanted so much as to see again. And it finished, and she saw, and the seeing was the worst

thing that had ever been done to her, and she had done it to herself.

She put her hand on the cold lip of the pedestal to steady it.

* * *

Because now she could read the count.

Not the small count. Not the one she had kept all year, battened down to the doors she could shut, six and then seven and the fainter ones past the edge of half a sight. That count had a bottom to it, a kindness in it, a place where her seeing stopped and she could tell herself the rest was beyond her. There was no bottom now. The sight ran all the way out, the way it had at the rebirth, the whole lattice at once, every core and every thread and the great even hum of the source under all of it, and she could read, now, with the whole of her seeing, the whole of the cold leaning in against the world, and she could read, threaded all through it, every place the cold had reached the warmth and taken it, every soul the leaning had emptied since the autumn, each one a small dark absence in the bright weave at the spot a core had been and was not, and she could read where each absence joined the cold, and how the cold joined the warmth, and at what places the warmth had grown too great for the cold to lean against, and she could follow that line, the line of the warmth's too-greatness, all the way down through the lattice to the pool in front of her and to the wound she had closed in it a year ago with her own hand, and the line did not branch and it did not lie and it did not stop short out of mercy, because the sight had no mercy in it, the sight only showed her what was.

Sela first. The sight gave her Sela first, because Sela was the nearest of the dark places and the freshest, a small emptied absence at the edge of a mill three valleys off, the

warm working part of a miller's wife gone out of the weave like a snuffed wick, and Viridia's seeing traced the line from the absence outward and found the tear it had come through, and traced it back inward and found the lean of the cold that had opened the tear, and followed the lean down through the whole bright over-full weave to the wound run smooth in the source, and the line said, in the flat unmerciful grammar of the sight, *here, this, the warmth made whole, the lung run full, this is what the cold leaned toward to open the door that drank Sela*. The sight did not say it was her fault. The sight did not say anything. It only showed the line, unbroken, from the woman with flour on her hands to the girl with her hand on the source, and let her read it.

She had known it. She had known it since the fount, said it to Drake on the rock with the cold holding her face still. She had known it the way you know a number. *Every name I've taken at the long table traces back to my cure*. She had said exactly that, in those words, to a creature five thousand winters old, and it had been true when she said it and it was true now, and nothing in the fact had changed.

What changed was that now she could see the line.

* * *

There is a difference between a sum and a sight, and she had spent her whole life living on the right side of that difference and she crossed to the wrong side of it now and could not get back.

A sum you can hold at arm's length. A sum goes in the bins, in the place built for exactly this, where a thing too large to feel is broken down into a thing small enough to carry, a column and a column and a column, and the cold part runs the addition and hands you the total and you set the total down and you survive the choosing because the part that ran the sum is not the part that feels. She had been

doing it for a year. She had been doing it since before the war, since a school dormitory, since a stunted candle she grieved a month for. It was the truest tool she had. It had carried her over Jazen's still warm shape and into a pool with the whole world's grief running up her arm, by the simple grace of letting the cold part add the world while the rest of her held the rope.

But a sight is not a sum. A sight does not go in the bins. A sight comes up through the front of you whether you have a bin for it or not, comes up the way the lattice had come up her arm at the rebirth, all at once and too large to break into columns, and the cold working part stood in front of it the way it always stood, ready to take the number and parcel it out, and there was no number. There was Sela. There was the line from Sela to her hand. There was the next absence and the line from it to her hand, and the next, and the next, and the cold part reached for them to count them and could not count them, because they were not a count, they were a sight, they were faces in a weave, they were the actual emptied places where actual warmth had been, and you cannot put a face in a bin, you can only see it, and she saw them, all of them, at once, the way the rebirth had given her the world all at once, and the bins she had built to survive exactly this stood open and useless because you cannot file a thing you are looking straight at.

The hamlet she had read drained in the spring. The sight gave it to her not as a number, *eleven*, the number she had carried, but as eleven, as the eleven, each one a place in the weave, an old man and a child and a woman who had been quick with a second child, the small bright workings of them gone out, eleven dark absences where there had been warmth, and the line ran from each of the eleven through its tear and through the lean and down to her hand, eleven lines, all to the one place, and the cold part said *eleven* and

the sight said *no* and showed her the eleven, and she stood with her hand on the cold stone and let the eleven come up through the front of her with no bin to put them in.

* * *

She did not weep.

She wants that set down plainly, in the place where she keeps the things no one will ever read, because it is the truest thing about her and it was true even here, at the bottom of the worst seeing of her life. She held. The cold part could not file the count but it could still do the one thing it had always done, which was hold the front of her face still against a weight, and it held, the way it had held on the rock and in the pool and over the still warm shape on the rise, and her eyes burned and her throat shut and her hand on the stone went white at the knuckle and no tears came, because there was no one in the cavern to see it and none would have come even where there was no one, because the holding was not for the room, it had never been for the room, it was the shape of her, the wall she had made of herself a long time ago and would not unmake now for her own ease when she had refused to unmake it for so much worse.

But the bond was open. She had not closed it, coming down, never closed it now, had not closed it since the war, and Raizen was at the far end of it, up at the high house with the others, and he felt it land in her, the way he had felt the thing on the rock land in her, the thing she would not let her face carry going down the bond instead, because the bond carried what she would not let show. He went still up there, three valleys and a portal away. She felt him feel it. And she did not, this once, do the thing she had always done with him at that distance, which was to thin the bond down to a wire so that he got only the fact of her and not the size of it. She let it stay wide. She did not decide it the way you decide

a thing; it was more that she had no hand free to close it, both hands full of the seeing, and the part of her that would ordinarily have reached up to make the wire thin let the wire stay wide instead, and so he got the size of it, the whole size, the line and the eleven and the bottom under the count, coming up the bond raw and unbinned, in a way nothing had ever been let to come up it. It was the only place in her life it had ever happened. She let him have it. Not the room. The room would never have her, the room would always get the flat face and the white knuckle. But him, down the bond, the one thread in the weave, she let see the whole of it, the thing she had let no living soul see before, and three valleys away he did not flinch from the size of it and did not try to make it smaller and did not say a word, because he knew there were no words for it; he only took it, the way he had braced while the whole world poured up her arm, and held it with her, so that for the first time the holding was not only hers. She went on reading the line. But she read it now with him at the far end of it, knowing, and did not thin the wire back down.

* * *

The line, the line, the line. The sight would not stop giving her the line.

She had wanted to be done with the small count because the small count was a lie of mercy, and she had got her wish, she had got the whole count, and the whole count was not a count at all. It was a tracing. Every emptied place in the weave, and the sight ran a line from it, patient, unmerciful, accurate, down through the over-full lattice to the smoothed wound in the source under her hand, and every line arrived at the same place, and the place was her, and the lines did not branch and did not fork and did not split the blame across the council that had cut the world or the fools who tore the doors or the cold that did not want and only leaned.

The cold did not open the doors. She made herself see that, because it was the true grammar of the sight and she had trained herself a year ago not to make a thing smaller than it was. The cold did not open the doors. The cold only leaned, the way it had always leaned, the way it had leaned before there were hands. What opened the doors was the lean meeting a fullness it could pour into, and the fullness was new, the fullness was a year old, the fullness had not been there before a clever tired girl put her hand in this pool and ran the lung full after six hundred years of its running half. The cold had leaned against a half-full world for six centuries and the doors had been rare, rare enough that one old creature could shut them as they tore and call it tending. She had filled the world. She had made the warmth whole, all of it, every core at once, and the cold had a wholeness to lean against now that it had not had since before the cutting, and so the doors were not rare anymore, the doors were Sela and the eleven and the ones on the rim she could not have named and could name now, each of them a place where the new fullness she made had been thin enough for the cold to pour in, and every one of them a place the cold would not have found if the world were still half-starved, if Alice's candle were still stunted, if the children were still half-made, if she had never put her hand in the pool at all.

That was the thing under the thing. That was the bottom that the small count had been built to keep her from. The sight took her down to it and held her there.

If she had left the world cut, Sela would be alive.

* * *

She turned that over in the cold and it did not get smaller.

If she had left the world cut, the miller's wife would have flour on her hands tonight and a working in her chest, a small one, a half one, the dark side of it strangled to a thread

by a council six hundred years dead, but alive, the warmth in her not full but present, the wick not snuffed because there had been no fullness for the cold to pour toward and no door for it to pour through. The eleven would be eleven living half-made people, an old man and a child and a quick young woman, going about a spring they would not have liked the look of, cut and grieving and ungoverned but alive, all of them, every one, because the cold leans hardest against the fullest wall and she had built them the fullest wall the world had held in six centuries and called it a gift.

She had thought the cost of the rebirth was the sight. She had paid it standing on this same stone a year ago, the seeing burned to the wick, and had thought, blind and steadying herself on this same stone, *that is the cost, and no one will ever know I paid it, and that is the rest of the cost.* She had been wrong about that too. The sight was not the cost. The sight was the price of admission, the thing she had asked the source with and the source had taken because the source takes what you ask it with. The sight was a thing that came back. It had come back, just now, this hour, and shown her the real cost, the one that did not come back, the one that had been accruing in the dark for a year while she rode west closing doors and telling herself the doors were the wrongness, the cost that was not hers to pay because it was paid by other people, by Sela, by the eleven, by the ones on the rim, paid in the only currency the cold takes, which is warmth, the warmth she made, the warmth that was the gift, the warmth that was the mending, the warmth that was the best thing she had ever done.

The best thing she had ever done was eating the world.

* * *

And then, the way the hardest knowing had always arrived in her, all at once and out of the flood and not as a sentence, it stopped being too much and became one thing.

It did not lessen. She wants that set down too, beside the not-weeping, because it is the other true thing and the books all get it wrong, that the overwhelm breaks like a fever and you feel better. It did not break. It did not lessen by a grain. The eleven were still the eleven and Sela was still Sela and the lines all still ran to her hand. What happened was that the sight, having given her every line one at a time until she could not hold them, gave her, last, the shape they all made together, the way a wound that has frightened you across a whole body resolves when you finally look at it plain into one edge, the way the world's whole grief had resolved, here, a year ago, into a single cut she could draw together. It resolved now too. It resolved into one clear terrible thing, and the clarity was not a mercy, the clarity was the worst of it, because a thing you cannot see the shape of you can still hope is smaller than it feels, and a thing you have seen the shape of plain you can never hope about again.

She saw the shape. The cold leaning in all along the rim, vast, the sea past a glass of water, and the lean steepest exactly where the warmth was fullest, and the warmth fullest exactly where she had run the lung full, which was everywhere, which was every living core there is, and the great patient absence pouring in through every thin place toward the fullness, and the fullness pouring out into every emptied soul as the cold took it, and the shape the whole of it made, the shape of the thing eating the world, was not the council's shape and not the void's shape and not Marick's shape and not chance's shape.

It was the shape of the mending.

The thing eating the world was the exact shape and the exact size of the mercy she had done. Line for line. She had

mended every core there is and the cold was leaning against every core there is. She had run the warmth full to the edge of everything and the absence was pouring in along the whole edge of everything. The wound she had closed was, drawn inside out, the shape of the new wound, the one with no edges, the one that could not be closed because it was not a cut, the one Drake had no mark for, and she had not made it the way you make a thing, with a hand and a stroke, she had made it the way a presence makes an absence by being present, the way the fullness of the lung makes the emptiness it leans against, and the size of it was the size of her doing, and the doing had been good, and that was the clarity, that the doing had been good and the eating was the same size as the good, the same shape, the same line, that there was no part of the eating she could cut away and keep the good, that the warmth and the leaning were the two halves of one breath and she had filled the lung and the lung's filling was the cold's leaning and you could not have the one without the other, ever, and she had not known that when she put her hand in the pool, and it would not have stopped her if she had, and that was the worst of the clarity, that knowing it now she would still have done it, because a world half-dead was not a world she could leave half-dead, and so she had chosen this, she would choose it again, she had signed the bill she could not read and the bill said *the cold gets back exactly what you gave*, and the cold was collecting it now, in warmth, in Sela, in the eleven, in the ones she would never reach in time, name by name, down the whole length of a road that had her at the start of it and no end she could see.

* * *

She stood at the pedestal with her hand on the cold stone and her sight come whole and the whole shape of it laid

plain in front of her, and she did the thing she did instead of the thing a person does.

She did not sink to the floor. She had read of people sinking to floors and she did not understand it, had never understood it, the body folding under a weight, because her body had never once been allowed to fold, her body had a wall to be and the wall did not fold, the wall stood, that was the entire point of a wall. So she stood. Her hand stayed on the stone and the front of her face stayed flat and she let the seeing come up through her with no bin to put it in and she stood under it the way she had borne the world's weight in this room a year ago, by main force, by being the thing the weight rested on, except that there was no closing to do this time, no cut to draw together, no rope of a bond to haul on hand over hand, there was only the seeing and the standing under it, and the standing was harder than the closing had been, because the closing had at least been a doing, and this was only a knowing, and she had nothing to do with it but hold it, even, forever, which was the thing the oldest creature she knew had told her three days ago she would have to learn, and which she understood now he had not been able to teach her because there is no teaching it, there is only the day it lands.

It landed.

She felt it land all the way down, past the bins, past the cold, past the wall, into the place under the wall the wall was built over, the small girl's place, the place that had wanted only to make the world whole and had made it whole and had thought, banking her core to an ember in this room the first time, that whole was a thing you could be done with, that you mended a thing and it stayed mended and you set down the tools. It landed there, in the place that had wanted the mending to be good, the place that needed the mending to be good, because if the mending was not good then she

was the thing she fought, then she was the council, then she was a frightened person deciding for the world and calling it mercy, and the sight had shown her that the mending was good, was as good as a thing can be, Drake had said so, *I would have you do it again*, and the same sight in the same hour had shown her that the good thing was the thing eating the world, and the small girl's place under the wall had no bin for that, had no wall for it, had nothing for it at all but to feel it, and it felt it, the whole of it, all the way down, the warmth she made running out of the world's emptied chests one wick at a time with her name on every column.

And the wall held — for the room. That is the thing. That is the only mercy there was in the cavern and it was not a mercy, it was a habit, it was the worst-built best thing in her, that even with the seeing landed all the way down in the place that had no defenses against it, the wall in front of it held against the room, the face stayed flat, the eyes burned and did not spill. But the wall had never been a single thing. There was the side it showed the room and there was the side it showed the bond, and she had kept them the same all her life, flat to both, and now, this once, she let the two come apart. She held the front of her face still and she let the back of her, the bond side, the side three valleys away a man who had given up the sky for her was braced against, she let that side go. Not loudly. There was nothing in it a room could have seen even if a room had been there, no wail, no folding, no sound at all; it was a small thing, the kind of thing that in another person would have been the catch of a breath, the giving of a single inch, and it went down the bond instead of into the air, the inch she had never given anyone, the crack she had held shut at Jazen's still warm shape and held shut at the pool and held shut for a year of doors, the break she had spent her whole life refusing the world, given now, once, to the one person, in the one place no one else would ever

stand. At Jazen's death it had been torn out of her, in front of two armies, with no choosing in it. This was the other thing, the thing that had no name in her because she had never done it: this she chose. She felt the inch go down the bond and felt him take it, not as a thing to fix, only as a thing to hold, and she did not snatch it back. She let him see her break. The last thing she had that was wholly and only hers, the way the sight had once been, she did not keep alone this time. She gave it to him.

* * *

She lifted her hand off the stone, finally, when she could trust it to come away without shaking, and she made the cold in her do the one thing it could still do, which was not file the seeing, the seeing would not be filed, but tell her what the seeing meant for the next hour, which was the only span a person can ever really do anything about.

It meant the road west had been a wrong question, the way Marick's door had been a wrong question. She had ridden west to find where the tearing came from, and the tearing came from here, from under her hand, from a year ago, and there was no west to ride to that would unsay it. It meant there was no closing it, which she had known, and now felt. It meant Drake was right and there was only the holding, and the holding had no mark and no master and no end. It meant the cost of the rebirth had not been the sight after all, the sight was only the down payment, the cost was a thing still being paid, in warmth, by other people, and would go on being paid, in warmth, by other people, until she found the evening of it, the balance, the breath held even, and that she did not know how to do, and the oldest creature she knew did not have it either, and the source itself, humming pale and even in front of her, full to the brim with the wholeness she had given it, could not answer it, because the

source was not cruel and not kind and only answered what it was asked and no one had ever asked it this, because no one before her had ever been fool enough or brave enough or young enough to read the bill to fill the lung.

She looked at the pool a long time.

She thought about the thread at the bottom of it, the warm unfollowable one with her mother's name, and did not reach for it, because she had no self to spend on it and because some things are held over for a far-off door and because, if she was honest in the place under the wall, she was afraid that if she reached for it now, in this, she would not have the strength to let it go a second time. She thought about the children at the carts who would never know, and Alice with her warmth coming back and her crooked tooth, made whole in this room, alive because the cold had not yet found the thin place over her, and how thin that was, how thin the place over everyone she loved was now, how the cold leaned against Alice's new wholeness exactly as it leaned against everyone's, and she put that thought in the deepest place she kept, the place she did not visit, beside the buried absence and the unfollowed thread and the still warm shape on a stone, and she could not get the lid all the way down on it, and she left it not quite shut, the way you leave a door not quite shut on a room you will have to go back into.

* * *

The coffee at the high house was bad and she would drink all of it when she got back, she thought, and did not know where the thought came from, and let it go.

Then she steadied, the way she steadied, and she wiped her face on her sleeve twice, carefully, the old habit, in a room where there was no one and the wiping was for no one and the eyes had not spilled and the wiping was for the

burning, which was a thing you could wipe and a thing no one need ever know you had wiped. She turned from the pedestal. Her sight was whole. It lit the lattice for her all the way out to the cold edge of everything, the over-full weave, the lean steepening, the slow patient widening that did not slacken and would not slacken, and threaded all through it the small dark places, Sela and the eleven and the ones on the rim, each one a line that ran to her hand, and she would have to live in that sight now, having got it back, would have to read every birth and every death in it for as long as she lived, and the True-Bond meant that was a very long life, and every death she read across the whole length of it would run a line, and the line would run to her.

She found the seam in the air at the place the chamber ended, and she set her hand to it the way she had learned to, by meaning it, and the air split along its edgeless line and showed her grey on the far side, the high house, the morning, the world she had remade.

She did not step through yet. She stood at the seam with the cold cavern behind her and the grey morning in front of her and the whole shape of the thing laid plain in the sight she had wanted back for a year, and she understood, all the way down now and not merely as a sum, the thing she had carried west folded up and could never fold again: that the cure she had been so glad of, the finest thing she would ever do, the mending of a six-hundred-year wound she would do again knowing everything, had come with a cost that no one could see, that no one would ever see, that not one soul she had made whole would ever know to lay at her door, and that the cost was not behind her and not coming, the cost was here, now, in the weave, being paid out warmth by warmth down a road with no end, and it had her name on it. All the way down. Felt, now, and not merely known. And there was no one in the world she could tell, and no mark she could

draw against it, and no west she could ride to escape it, and nothing left to do but the one thing she had learned in this room a year ago and had to learn again now in a worse way: to take the weight up, and stand under it, and not break where it could be seen.

She stepped through, into the grey, into the world that did not know, with her sight come whole and her name on the cold, and let the seam seal behind her, and went up to the bad coffee and the people she loved and the door she had left not quite shut, carrying the only thing she had ever truly been alone with, which was now, and would be for the rest of a very long life, the knowing of exactly what her mercy cost.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Ledger Reopens

She came back from the source-cavern and drank three cups of the bad coffee and did not sleep.

Raizen had not asked. He had been at the kitchen table when she came through the portal, seated in the human way he still attended to with care, elbows on the old wood, and he had looked at her across the lamp and not asked anything, the bond between them carrying what it always carried and no questions running along it, only the patient held warmth of him, present. She poured the coffee. She sat down across from him. The lamp burned low and the house breathed around them, Alice asleep somewhere above, Amber's deep certain breathing through the thin wall that made itself so domestic a sound it was almost funny, and the two of them sat with the coffee between them and the knowing between them and nothing either of them needed to say.

After the third cup he put his hand over hers on the table, large and careful, the way he touched things now that he could break them.

"You are going to do the thing," he said.

"What thing."

"The thing where you file it and pick up the next task before the filing is done. I know the face of it. You are making it right now."

She looked at his hand on hers. The lamp guttered. "There's work to do."

"There is always work." He did not move his hand. "I am not telling you to stop working. I am telling you I can see the filing and the filing is not finished and you are going to hurt yourself on the unfinished edge of it and I would prefer you did not." The dark human eyes held her, the old attention unmistakable behind the ordinary color. "I have seen you set a thing that is too heavy in a cold place and call it done. I have seen what comes of it. I am noting it plainly, which is the one thing I have learned to do from your impossible friend, and then I will say nothing further, because I am also learning from you and you have never liked being pressed."

She turned her hand under his. She did not pull away.

"I know," she said. It came out leveled, the flat certainty, and she listened to it and knew he heard the difference between that and fine, and said, "I mean that. I know what I'm doing and I know what I'm not doing and I know the gap between them. I'm not calling the filing done. I'm saying I have to do the next thing first, because there isn't a choice about whether the next thing gets done." She looked at the lamp. "There are more tears. I can feel them, with the sight back whole. Three in the north, two on the western rim. And the cold is leaning in along every one of them."

Raizen was quiet. The bond lay warm and level between them.

"Then we close them," he said, at last. "In the morning. Because in the morning you will not be holding the weight you are holding now and you will not make the kind of mistake you make when you hold something this long without sleep."

"You can't know that."

"I can know it." He squeezed her hand once and let go. "I have been studying you a year. You go quiet when you are

about to do something you should not, and you are very quiet right now."

She looked at him a moment longer, and then, despite every instinct she had, she went to bed.

* * *

She slept badly and long, into the grey late morning, and woke with the sight already running, the lattice spread out under the floor of her awareness the way it had been spread out for the last year except that now she could see the full weight of it, every core bright in the world, every thread, and threaded through all of it, the lean of the cold, patient and vast and no hungrier than it had been last night, which was still hungrier than it had been the morning before.

She lay in her bed and tried to be still in the knowing without doing anything about it, which was the thing the pedestal had not allowed. The eleven were the eleven. Sela was Sela. The lines ran from every emptied place to her hand, she had felt the full weight of them, and the feeling had not gone away in sleep and it would not go away, and she lay in the grey light and let it be there without filing it and without picking up the next task and without doing the cold-part arithmetic, and it was the hardest thing she had done in a bed in sixteen years.

Then Alice knocked, and she said come in, and Alice came in with two cups that were tea and not coffee, which was a kindness Viridia registered and set beside the small true things she kept, and Alice sat on the edge of the bed and handed her one and was quiet, only looking at her with the healer's eyes that had always seen further than Viridia wished.

"You're different," Alice said. Not a question.

"My sight came back. Whole, this time."

Alice wrapped her hands around her cup. "That's not what I mean." She had her warmth back, all of it, the crooked tooth showed itself now half a dozen times a day without her noticing, and the hands that had been too perfect had their old small fidgets back, the thumb working the rim of the cup. "I mean you came through the portal last night and you looked the way you look after something that cannot be taken back." She did not push. She was better at not pushing than Amber was, which made her harder to resist. "So. The worst of it, or the middling of it, or none of it. I'll take whichever you're giving."

Viridia drank her tea. It was good tea, the kind that came up on the slow line from somewhere warm. She made herself taste it.

"The worst of it," she said, and told her, in the flat level grammar of the arithmetic, the shape of what the sight had given her at the pedestal. The lines. The count. Sela. The eleven. The shape the eating made being the shape the mending made. She told it the way she told the things that couldn't be felt in the telling, which was the only way she had, and Alice listened without flinching, which was a thing that came from practice, the healer's muscle, the deliberate not-flinching that was not absence but a kind of attention that made room.

When she stopped, Alice was quiet for a while.

"The lines run to your hand," Alice said.

"Every one."

"And you've accepted that." She said it carefully, not as an accusation. "You've looked at it and you're not running from it."

"It doesn't stop being true if I run."

Alice looked at the tea in her cup. The morning light came grey through the window and lay across the floor. Somewhere below, Amber was moving in the kitchen, the

familiar creak of the drawer that stuck, the sound of the iron pan being set down on the range. "That's not what I meant," Alice said, finally. "I meant — you've taken it up. The knowing. You've stood under it and held it, and I can see that it's not going to kill you, even though it looks like it should." She turned the cup in her hands. "I don't know whether to be frightened of that or grateful for it."

"Both, probably," Viridia said.

"Yes." Alice looked at her sidelong, and the look had the same thing the look had always had, the Alice underneath the healer, the one who had taught her Moravian on the flagstone floor of a dormitory in the dark, the crooked tooth and the laugh that showed it and the steady warm hand that had never once let go when it counted. "Both. And what I'm going to say next, I'm saying as the person who has known you the longest out of everyone left, which is that I am allowed to say it once and you're going to hate it and say I'm right anyway, so I'll just say it. You are going to need to let someone carry a piece of this with you. Not to solve it. Not to file it somewhere cleaner. Only to carry. And I know it's the thing you know the least how to do, and I'm telling you anyway."

Viridia said nothing. She drank her tea. The drawer in the kitchen stuck again.

"I know," she said, finally, and meant it the same way she had meant it to Raizen last night at the lamp, which was: *I hear you and I cannot argue with you and I don't know how to do it.*

Alice patted her knee once, the old familiar motion, the one that had started in a dormitory hallway and had crossed a war and come out the other side, and she stood up with her cup and said, "Breakfast is going to be burned if Amber makes it alone," and left.

* * *

The letter came at noon, by the slow line from the capital, and it was not the first, but it was the worst.

They had been receiving letters for four months, since the word had got out that the girl from the south was in the valley, the girl who had done it, the girl who had changed everything, all at once, a year ago. The first ones had been tentative. Requests, mostly, framed as invitations, framed as questions. *We are a delegation of the northeastern factional assembly and we would be grateful to speak with you, at your convenience, on the matter of governance.* She had answered those, carefully, without promising anything, and the care had not helped because the letters had gotten less tentative across four months.

This one was not tentative at all.

It came in an envelope with the old council's mark crossed through and the new factional seal over it, which told her it was official in the way things were official now, which was to say someone thought it was official and whether anyone else agreed was the particular disorder of the current government. She read it at the kitchen table with the noon light coming through the small window and Amber reading over her shoulder without asking permission, because Amber never asked permission for the things she considered surveillance in the public interest.

The letter said that in the valley of Lest, two weeks west by the main line, there was a fire that had begun as an ordinary fire and was not. It said three hundred people had fled to the schoolhouse in the center of town and the schoolhouse was now surrounded by factions who disagreed about whether those three hundred people had the right to be there, and by *fire* the letter did not mean flames, it meant a whole-mage whose dark half had come in wrong, all at once, uncontrolled, and who was burning through the town the way a man burns through his own house when

something has broken so badly inside him that the only thing left is the breaking. It said the factional mediators had tried for six days and the burning-man could not be reached by talk or treaty, and the factions surrounding the schoolhouse had reached the point where the three hundred people inside were in as much danger from the factions as from the burning-man, and the factional assembly was asking Viridia Saeren, formally, to intervene.

The letter said *to intervene*. It did not say *to advise* or *to assist* or *to consult*.

Amber said, from over her shoulder, "That's not a request."

"No."

"They're asking you to go in there and use the thing you are to stop a man who cannot stop himself." She came around the table and sat down across from it, her hands flat on the wood, the flat serious look she wore when she had decided to be serious and not dress it in anything else. "That's the thing you fought. That's exactly the thing, Viridia. Council used their power to govern the ungovernable and called it mercy. This letter is a different voice asking you to do the same thing."

"A man is burning three hundred people."

"Yes. And it's terrible, and it needs to stop, and I'm not saying you shouldn't go. I'm asking you if you've noticed the thing you're about to do, and whether you've noticed that if you do it, and it works, there will be another letter, and another, and every one of them will be a real burning-man and a real schoolhouse, and at some point you will have a very large territory over which you are the only thing that can keep the fire from spreading, and what is that called?"

Viridia looked at the letter.

This was not a new question. The first month in the valley, when the first delegation had arrived and she had let

Raizen turn them away gently, she had known the next one would come. She had stood over the pool at the source-cavern a year ago with the whole world's grief running up her arm and the decision had already been half made. On Drake's mountain, when the old voice had said *there is no mark for a pressure*, she had understood what lay underneath the statement: *the answer is not a symbol, it is not one clever person with a hand in the source, it is the long slow even holding of a thing too large for any person*. She had known Amber's question was building toward exactly this. She had been choosing not to finish it.

She had not thought about what she would do when a specific burning-man had three hundred specific people in a schoolhouse.

"I know what it's called," she said.

"I know you know." Amber picked up the letter and set it down again. "So what are you going to do."

* * *

She did not answer Amber right away. The questions Amber asked were never questions that wanted an instant answer; they wanted the real one, and the real one had to be found.

There was a thing she had been not-thinking about since the pedestal, the thought she had run once already in the cavern dark and shut behind a door, and Amber's question cracked the door the rest of the way. She sat with it a moment in the kitchen, with the cold afternoon light coming through the small window and the smell of the lunch Amber had made, burned, as she had promised, along the edge.

She could un-mend it. She had known that at the pedestal — that the source would take back what she asked it with, that she could run the weave thin again and snuff the dark halves she had lit, and the cold would stop leaning, and the doors would stop tearing, and the next Sela would not

happen. The cold part had held the whole monstrous sum out for her a year ago and held it out again in the bad sleep last night, and it came out the same both times, the same shape the council's mercy had, and she had learned enough about herself in sixteen years to know that the thoughts you most need to say out loud are the ones you are most ashamed to have thought.

She looked at Amber. "I thought about un-mending it," she said. "Giving the dark half back. Running the weave thin. Taking back what I gave."

Amber went very still. It was the stillness she used for the things she had not expected, the ones that were too large for her usual speed. "You thought about it," she said, not a question.

"The cold part ran it. I want you to know I ran it. I am not going to do it, but I ran it, because I run everything, and it matters to me that you know I considered the most monstrous thing available to me and decided against it, not because I didn't see it." She kept her voice level. "I decided against it because I cannot unmake people. That is the same reason I fought the council. You do not decide what other people's gifts look like because you have decided it is safer. You do not take back a wholeness you gave because the wholeness turns out to be expensive." She let it sit. "It's expensive and it's mine to carry and I am not taking it back."

Amber let out a breath, slow and controlled, the way she let things out she had been holding without realizing. "All right," she said. "All right. Good." She looked at the letter. "Then what."

She did not answer right away. She went to the garden, which was where she went when the reckoning needed room. The afternoon had come in cold and clear, smelling of the stream and the turned soil of the second garden, the one they had broken from the hillside over the winter. She stood

at the edge of it with her hands in her coat pockets and her sight spread out under the floor of her awareness, the whole lattice singing its low hum, and she thought.

The burning-man in the valley of Lest. She could read him from here, at the edge of her range, a blazing ragged thing in the weave, a core that had come into its full gift all at once without the frame to hold it, the dark half running wild and uncontained, pouring out through him into the world the way a burst vessel pours. She felt the shape of what was wrong in him the way Alice felt the shape of a broken bone under the skin. She could, if she stood close enough, reach in and correct it. Reach into another person's core and adjust it toward what she thought it should be.

That was the thing Amber was asking about. Not whether she *could*. Whether she would let herself be the person who *did*.

She stood in the cold garden for a long time.

The stream ran. The second garden waited, the dark turned earth of it patient under the sky. A pair of starlings worked along the stone wall, checking each gap with the systematic certainty of creatures who had decided the wall was theirs, which it now was, by the logic of sustained attention. She watched them without looking at them, the way she watched the source-sense in the background, both attended and not attended, a habit since she was fourteen and the gap between what she saw and what she was allowed to say had been the central problem of her life.

The burning-man could not be reached by talk, the letter said. She believed it. She had read enough uncontrolled power to know what *cannot be reached* looked like in the lattice, the way it folded inward on itself, the way the gift became a wall between the person and the world. She could go there and stand outside him the way the factions were standing outside the schoolhouse and try to talk him out,

and fail the way they had failed. Or she could go there and do the thing only she could do.

Or she could not go.

She stayed in the garden until the cold crept in through her coat and a goat from the upper pen, escaped again by the look of it, appeared on the garden wall and looked at her with the comprehensive indifference of a goat, and she made a decision that was not quite either of the things Amber was afraid of.

* * *

She came back inside and found them all at the table, which was where they ended up when something was happening, the kitchen table the shape their found family made around a problem. Amber, Alice, Raizen. The letter at the center. She sat down and put her hands on the table and said what she had decided.

"I'll go. Not alone. Not to reach in and correct him, because that's the thing I won't do — use the source to govern another person's gift, even for their good. That's the line and it stays the line even when the alternative is harder." She looked at Alice. "I need a healer. Someone who can work with both halves, who can reach a man who's burning with the giving hand and the taking both, and help him hold what's come into him instead of having it fixed by someone else's decision." She looked at Raizen. "And I need someone who's stood at the far edge of a thing too large for him and braced. Not to fight. To hold."

Raizen said, evenly, "When do we leave."

"Tomorrow morning."

Amber looked at her for a long moment. Then she said, "What about the burning-man. If he can't be reached."

Viridia was quiet. The lamp burned between them. The goat had made it from the wall to the step and was scratching at the door, hopeful, with no reason to be.

"Then I stand between him and the three hundred people in the schoolhouse," she said, "and I hold the doors between him and them and I keep holding them until he burns down to something that can be helped. And I don't reach in and fix him. I don't touch his gift without his asking. I just hold the doors." She heard herself say it and knew it was not the answer the letter wanted, and she said it anyway, because it was the only answer she had that was still hers. "It's the thing I know how to do. It's not enough and it's not clean and it is not going to be the last time someone sends a letter. But it's what I can do without becoming the other thing."

Alice was looking at her with the healer's eyes again. "And what about the ones he burns before you hold the doors."

It was not a cruel question. She meant it the way doctors mean hard questions, to find the place the medicine reaches and the place it does not.

Viridia looked at the letter.

"Those go in the ledger," she said. "Same column as the others. Same line, back to my hand."

No one said anything. The goat scratched the door. The lamp threw its small warm light on the four of them, the found family around the problem, the world outside the window going dark toward evening.

* * *

They packed that night, quietly, each of them with the old familiar practice of it, packing without discussion because they had all of them done it before, on an east road that was a year behind them and not as far as it felt. Alice rolled her kit. Raizen set his coat by the door with the slow deliberate

care he brought to objects he had decided mattered. Amber packed a bag with the focused efficiency of a person who had decided to go somewhere before she announced it and did not particularly welcome argument.

Viridia sat at the kitchen table after the others had gone up and re-read the letter one more time.

It was not really about the burning-man in Lest. She knew that, had known it before she finished the first paragraph. It was about the shape the world had made in a year without a head, and the shape it was going to keep making, a valley here and a faction there and a whole-mage in a town who could not hold what had been given back to him. The world was full of people who had never been trained for the dark half of themselves, who had carried it strangled to a thread by six centuries of a lie, and then had it back all at once, a year ago, without asking, because Viridia Saeren, at sixteen, had decided wholeness was worth more than consent. She still believed that. She was going to keep believing it. And the cost of believing it would arrive in letters with crossed-through council seals, in burning-men in schoolhouses, in the factional assembly asking her, formally, to govern by the gift she was not going to let herself use that way.

Amber's question. The hardest version of it, the one that had teeth now: *you couldn't ask them before you remade them; can you fix this without deciding for them again?*

She did not know. She had stood in the cold garden and not found the answer, only found the refusal of the wrong answer, and the refusal was not an answer, it was only a line, and a line was not a plan.

She folded the letter and put it in her coat pocket, where it would be when she needed to read it again at the edge of a town she had never seen, with a burning-man between her and three hundred people in a schoolhouse.

She turned down the lamp. She went upstairs.

In the morning they would take the train to the slow junction, and from there a portal west. They would go to Lest and she would stand in a place she had not yet stood and make a decision she had not yet worked out, and whatever the decision was, there would be another letter after it, and another after that. The ledger was open. It had been open since the cavern. It had just taken her a year and a full sight to be able to read the columns.

She lay down in her dark room and felt the whole world breathing, in and out, in and out, the surf of the source-sense running under her awareness, and the cold lean at the rim of it, patient, vast, no hurry in it at all.

Three hundred people in a schoolhouse. One burning-man who could not stop. One girl on a train in the morning with a line that ran from every one of them to her hand.

She was still deciding what it meant that she would go anyway.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Thing She Fought

The town of Lest had a wall around it, and the wall was the wrong shape, and Viridia saw the wrongness from the train before she saw anything else.

It was an old wall, a low field-stone thing that had once kept goats in and weather out, and someone had built it up in the last week into something that was meant to keep people out, raised in courses of fresh undressed stone laid fast and badly, and broken in three places where men with picks had opened gates that the old wall had never wanted. From the slow line coming down out of the western hills she could read the whole of it, the new gates and the men at them, the carts drawn up in rings the way carts are drawn when the people behind them expect to be charged, and threaded through all of it, faint and certain under the floor of her awareness, the cores. Hundreds of them. Bunched. Frightened in the way a core goes when the body it lives in has not slept, a low ragged flicker she had learned to read across a year of reading rooms she could not see. And at the center of the town, where the schoolhouse stood, a place in the weave she did not at first understand, because nothing she had read in her life had looked like it.

It was not a death. It was not a tear. It was a core gone wrong in a way a core is not supposed to be able to go, a brightness turned in on itself and pouring, a vessel that had

been handed the whole of a gift it had no frame to hold and had begun, slowly, all week, to come apart at the seams of itself, spilling the dark half out into the world the way a struck artery spills, without aim, without malice, without the man inside it able to do one thing about the spilling.

The burning-man.

"There," she said, and Amber leaned across her to look, and Alice looked, and Raizen, who did not need the window because he had the bond and could feel what she felt run along it, looked anyway, because he had decided that human people looked at the things they discussed and he was learning to be human.

"That's the schoolhouse," Amber said. "In the middle."

"Yes."

"And the wall's around the whole town."

"Yes."

Amber sat back. She had the flat serious face on. "So the three hundred are in the middle, with the burning-man, and everybody else is between them and the gates. The factions aren't keeping the burning-man in. They're keeping the three hundred in."

"Yes," Viridia said again, and did not say the rest of it, which Amber would already have, because Amber missed nothing she did not choose to miss: that the wall was not a wall against a fire. It was a wall against a question. Three hundred people had run to the one stone building in town when their neighbor began to come apart, and three hundred people inside a wall is a thing two frightened factions can argue about, can claim, can ration, can decide the fate of, and a town outside a wall is only a town. The wall had not been built to stop the burning. The burning was the reason. The wall had been built so that someone could own what was inside it.

The train came down into the valley and the wrongness got no better for being closer.

* * *

There was a man waiting at the halt with a sash across his chest, and the sash was a new thing, a strip of pale cloth dyed in a hurry, and it was the first thing she understood about the government of Lest, which was that it had been invented eleven days ago and was wearing its only clothes.

His name was Coyle. He was perhaps fifty, with the hands of a man who had done real work for most of his life and the eyes of a man who had stopped sleeping the week the sash went on, and he came down the platform toward her with a relief on his face so naked it embarrassed her.

"You came," he said. "You came. We sent the letter and half the assembly said you would not come and I said she will come, she is the one who did the great thing, she will not leave us in this." He took her hand in both of his before she had offered it. "You can stop it. You can make it stop."

"Tell me what's happening," she said, and took her hand back gently, because the wanting in his grip was a thing she had learned to take her hand back from.

He told her, walking, fast, the way a man tells a thing he has told too many times in a week. The burning-man was called Harl. He had been a wheelwright. He had gone whole a year ago, like everyone, and like most people he had carried it badly and unremarkably for a year, a man with a thing in him he did not understand and had no teacher for, and then nine days ago something in him had given, the way a green branch gives, all at once after long bending, and the dark half had come up in him uncontained and it had not stopped coming. He had burned his own house first. Then the houses by it. He had not meant to. Coyle was very clear that he had not meant to, said it three times, *he is not a wicked man, he was*

a good neighbor, he does not want this, and Viridia believed it, because she had read the core from the train and there was no wanting in it at all, only the spilling.

"And the schoolhouse," she said.

Coyle's face changed. The relief went off it and something more careful came on, the look a man wears when he has been caught partway into a thing he is ashamed of.

"People ran there," he said. "It is stone. It is the only stone in the middle of the town. They ran there to be safe from the fire, three hundred of them, more, families, and they are there now, and they cannot come out, because Harl is between them and every road, he stands in the square and the fire comes off him and a person cannot cross the square. And the assembly." He stopped walking. "There are two of us now. The assembly. There was one of us, and now there are two, because when a thing breaks, men who agree about nothing find they agree about even less. The other one is Renwick. Renwick says the three hundred are his to feed and his to protect and his to answer for, and I say they are the town's, and the only thing Renwick and I agree on is that whoever brings them out alive will be the one the rest of them follow after." He looked at her, and the shame was full on him now, and under it, worse, the hope. "You see how it is. You see what you would be ending. If you bring them out, you decide who they belong to. That is why I sent the letter and not Renwick. I sent it because I would rather you decided than him."

"I am not going to decide who anyone belongs to," she said.

He looked at her with the patient disbelief of someone who had long ago decided that powerful people always say that and never mean it, and he said, "Of course," and led her on toward the wall.

* * *

She heard the burning before she saw it.

It was not the sound of flame. That was the thing the letter had failed to put in her. Flame has a sound she knew, a roar, a snapping, the ordinary hunger of a fire in a house. This was under that. This was a low continuous tone like a struck rim of glass that had never been allowed to stop ringing, and it rose from the center of the town and stood in the air over everything, and the people at the gate flinched from it without knowing they flinched, a whole crowd of them leaning very slightly away from the middle of their own town like grass under a wind that did not move the grass.

She came up onto the new wall with Coyle, in a gap his men had left, and she looked down the long street toward the square, and she saw it.

The whole of her wants to look away from this and she does not let it, because she had come to do a thing and the thing required that she see what she was doing it to.

The square was white. Not with flame. With absence. The dark half coming off Harl had eaten the color out of the air over the square the way it ate everything, the cobbles bleached to bone, the front of the buildings ringing the square scoured pale, the well in the center of it dry and cracked, and in the middle of the white stood a man, or what was left of a man's standing, a shape that the eye kept trying to make into a person and could not quite, because the edges of him were not holding. He was on fire in the way the weave was on fire. There was no orange in it. He poured. And around him, at the mouths of the streets that fed the square, lay shapes she made herself count and then made herself stop counting, because the counting was the cold

part's trick for not seeing and she had promised herself in a cavern that she would see.

People had tried to cross to him. Or away from him. The square was the going and not-going of nine days.

"How many of yours are down there," she said. Her voice came out level.

"We stopped counting," Coyle said, which she understood, because she had nearly done the same. "He does not come out of the square. If you do not go in, he does not come out. We have been holding the streets nine days. We thought he would burn down. He does not burn down. He has been going whole all year and there is a year of it in him and it does not run out."

Behind her, very quietly, Alice said, "She can't reach a man like that with talk."

"No," Viridia said.

"And you're not going to fix him." Alice said it the way she had said it in a kitchen two weeks ago, not as a question, as a thing she was setting on the table so it would be in the room when the time came. "You said you wouldn't reach in."

"I'm not going to reach in."

"Then what will you do," Coyle said, and there was a crack in his hope now, the first one, the beginning of the thing she had known would come, which was the moment a man who had pinned his survival on her power discovered that her power came with a refusal stapled to it.

She did not answer him. She was looking at the square, and reading it with the whole of her sight, and what she read was this: that Harl could not be talked to, the letter was right, the gift had folded him inward the way uncontrolled power always folded a person, a wall between him and the world. That he was not going to stop. That every hour she stood on this new ugly wall, the dark half poured out of him into the white square and out past the white square, and somewhere

under all of it, faint, at the rim of her seeing, she felt the cold lean toward the spilling the way it leaned toward all the new fullness in the world, because Harl's wild dark half was a fullness too, was the remade weave coming apart at one of its seams, and the cold knew it, the cold always knew it. There would be a tear here soon. The burning would open a door. It always did.

And she could stop all of it. That was the thing standing in the white square with the dead. She could go down off this wall and walk into the square that no person could cross, because she was not a person in the way they were anymore, and she could reach into Harl's folded ruined core with the source running up her arm and she could take hold of the wild dark half he could not hold and she could fold it back into its frame, the way you set a dislocated joint, one motion, and the spilling would stop, the ringing would stop, the white would go back to color, the three hundred would walk out of the schoolhouse alive into the arms of whichever faction got to them first, and it would have cost her nothing she could feel and it would have taken about four seconds and it would have been, by every count the cold part could run, the right thing.

She stood on the wall and felt how much she wanted to do it.

* * *

The schoolhouse, from the inside, was a held breath nine days old.

This is the other thing that was happening, the part hidden from her eyes and given only to the seeing under them, the three hundred cores bunched in the one stone room at the center of a town gone white, and it ran under everything she did on the wall like the bass note under the burning. There were children in there. There were old

people. There was a woman near her time, Coyle had said it on the platform without knowing he had given Viridia the worst single fact in the valley, *a woman near her time*, because Viridia had read a hamlet drained in the spring and one of the eleven had been a woman quick with a second child and the sight had given her that one as a place in the weave and not a number and she had not got it out from behind the door since. The schoolhouse held its breath. It had food for two more days. It had been promised rescue by two men who hated each other and meant to use the rescuing. It had a burning-man between it and every road. It waited for the girl from the south who had remade the world, who was standing on the wall, who could end the whole of it in four seconds and was not, yet, doing it.

She did not know their faces. That was the strange mercy of it and the strange cruelty. She could feel the three hundred as a brightness bunched and ragged and could not put a single face to a single core, and the not-knowing was the only thing that let her stand on the wall and not go down into the square. Because the cold part had already run it. The cold part had run it on the train. Three hundred against one line she would not cross. Three hundred living against a principle. The arithmetic was not even close. The arithmetic had never once, in her whole life, come out on the side of the line she would not cross, and she had learned long ago that this was exactly why the line could not be a thing you decided by arithmetic, because arithmetic would spend any line for enough lives, and a line you would spend for enough lives was not a line, it was a price.

* * *

Renwick came up onto the wall while she was still reading the square.

He was younger than Coyle and better dressed and he had not stopped sleeping, which told her more about him than anything he said, and he came up with two men behind him and a third sash and he did not take her hand. He looked at her the way a man looks at a tool he intends to be the one holding.

"You'll have heard Coyle's version," he said.

"I've heard a version."

"Then hear the true one. Those people in the schoolhouse are alive because I have fed them across the lines for nine days while Coyle made speeches. They will come out because of me or they will not come out. And you." He looked her over, the slight girl in the travel coat, and she watched him decide she was small, watched the decision sit wrong on his face because some part of him had felt the thing she was and could not square it with the size of her. "You did a great thing once. Everyone says so. You changed the world. So change this. Go down and stop him. And when those people walk out of that square they will know who stood on this wall and sent you in, and the rest of this region, which has no government and is going to choose one out of whoever can keep it from burning, will know it too."

"You want me to stop the burning," she said, "so that you can be the one who stopped the burning."

"I want you to stop the burning so that three hundred people do not starve in a schoolhouse," Renwick said, and the terrible thing was that this was also true, that it was true at the same time as the other thing was true, that he was a man using a catastrophe and a man trying to end one and there was no clean seam between the two of him, and she understood, standing on the wall between Coyle's hope and Renwick's hunger, that this was what a year without a head had grown. Not the burning. The burning was an accident, a green branch giving. This. Two men and a wall and three

hundred held breaths, the whole machinery of frightened power assembling itself around a girl who could end the argument, if only she would consent to be the kind of thing that ends arguments.

"Go down," Renwick said. "Or admit you won't, and let a real one take charge."

And here was the edge of it. She felt herself come to the edge of it the way you feel the floor of a lake shelve away under your foot.

Because she could take charge. The thought arrived fully formed and reasonable, in the cold part's flattest, most helpful voice, the voice that had run every sum she had ever survived a choosing by. She could go down into the square and fold Harl's gift back into its frame, and then she could turn around and look at Renwick and Coyle and their sashes and their hating, and she could reach, lightly, the way she could now reach, and feel both their cores under her seeing, two frightened flickering human lights, and she could see exactly how to make this stop, all of it, not the burning, the whole rotten machine of it, because she could feel every core in this valley and she could feel every core in the next, and a person who can feel every core can do more than read them. She had spent a year not thinking about the more. She thought about it now, on the wall, with the white square ringing and the three hundred held and the two men waiting for her to be their weapon. She could simply be the head the city had no head for. She could decide where the three hundred went, and who fed them, and which sash was real, and she could do it well, far better than Renwick, far better than Coyle, far better than the dead council had ever done it, because she was not frightened and not greedy and she wanted nothing for herself and she could *see*, she could see the whole weave, she could hold every quarreling core in the region in the warm certainty of her attention and she could

keep them, gently, from doing to each other the thing they were lining up to do, and no one would have to starve in a schoolhouse ever again, because there would be someone watching over all of it who loved them and could not be bribed and would never, ever, decide a thing for a bad reason.

It would be so easy. It would be so good. It would solve the thing the burning was only a symptom of. It would be mercy, real mercy, the realest she had ever been able to offer, and the only price was that she would have to become the one who decided, for their own good, what they were not wise enough to decide for themselves.

She heard, very clearly, in the cold helpful voice, the exact words: *for everyone's good.*

And she knew where she had heard them.

* * *

She had heard them from the council. She had heard them her whole childhood, in every rule that had decided what a person's gift was allowed to be, in the strangling of half the world's warmth to a thread, in six hundred years of mercy administered by people who had looked at a thing too dangerous to be left ungoverned and had governed it, for everyone's good, and called the governing kindness, and the council had not been wicked men either, no more than Harl was wicked, no more than Renwick was simply wicked. They had been frightened people with power over the ungovernable, deciding, and the deciding had cut the world in half for six centuries and she had spent everything she had to undo it, had filled the lung, had read the bill, was paying the bill now in warmth down a road with no end, and the whole monstrous good of what she had done was that she had given the world back the right to be whole and ungoverned and dangerous to itself.

And here, eleven days into the world being ungoverned, with three hundred people starving in a schoolhouse because two men with sashes could not agree who they belonged to, the world was holding the answer up to her, gently, reasonably, in her own cold helpful voice, and the answer was: *put it back. Not the cut. The deciding. Be the one who decides, for everyone's good. You can see every core. Run them.*

It was Amber's question, the one she had carried out of a kitchen. *Now that you can feel every core, what stops you from running them all.*

Nothing stopped her. That was the answer she had never been able to give Amber. Nothing in the world stopped her. There was no council left to forbid it, no army to oppose it, no power anywhere that could stand against what she now was. The only thing in all the world that stood between Viridia Saeren and the governing of every core in it was Viridia Saeren, and she was standing on a wall above three hundred people who would die for the lack of her governing, and she was so tired, and it would be so good.

She pressed both palms down against the cold new stone of the wall and she held on to it.

* * *

Raizen's hand came down over her right one.

He did not say anything. He had felt it run along the bond, the whole shape of it, the way he had felt the thing in the cavern run along the bond, and he did not try to make it smaller and he did not try to argue her out of it, because there was no arguing a person off this edge with words, she knew that, she had been the one trying to talk a green-branch man out of a fire. He only put his hand over her hand on the stone, large and careful, the way he touched things now that he could break them, and the warmth of him came down through her wrist, ordinary, human, particular,

one core out of all the cores, the one she would never govern because governing was the opposite of the thing the bond was, and her sight, which had been spreading out over the whole valley toward the whole region toward the whole weave, came back in along the line of his hand to the place where his palm was warm on the back of her fingers, and stopped there.

On her left, Amber said, low, not for the men with the sashes, "I can see you doing the arithmetic."

"I know."

"You've got the face on. The flat one. The one you get right before you do a thing you'll spend the rest of your life calling necessary." Amber's voice did not rise. It never rose for the things that mattered most. "I'm not going to grab your arm and stop you, Viridia. I couldn't anyway. Nothing could, and that's the whole horror of it, isn't it, that's the thing you've been circling for a year. Nothing can stop you. So I'm just going to stand here and say the thing out loud, because that's the deal we made a long time ago, that I say the thing out loud, and then you do whatever you're going to do, and we both live with it." She breathed. "If you go down there and fix that man and then turn around and fix these two and their wall and their three hundred, you will be right. You'll be so right. And there won't be a single person left in the world who's allowed to tell you when you're wrong, because you'll have made yourself the thing there's no telling no to. And the day after that you'll be a little more right about the next thing, and a little more, and one morning a year from now you'll catch your own reflection deciding something small for someone's own good without even slowing down, and you won't recognize the face, and there'll be no one left who can make you look at it." She put her own hand, briefly, flat against Viridia's shoulder, and

took it away. "That's the thing out loud. I've said it. Now do what you're going to do."

And Alice, on the wall behind them, did not put a hand anywhere. Alice only said, in the warm steady voice that had taught a frightened child a working in a dark dormitory and had crossed a war and come out the other side, "Whatever you decide, I'll go down into that square with you and do the part that's mine. I'm not afraid of the burning. I'm telling you that so you know you don't have to be the one who fixes it. You were never the only pair of hands. You only feel like the only pair of hands because you can see the whole thing, and seeing the whole thing is the loneliest lie there is."

Three of them. One on her hand, one at her shoulder, one at her back. Not holding her down. None of them could have held her down, and all three of them knew it, and that was the point, that was the whole point, they were not a leash and they were not a cage, they were three people standing close enough that she could not pretend, even for the four seconds it would take, that she was alone with the whole weight and the single seeing thing above it. She had built her whole self on being the one who could see and could not be argued with. They had not argued with her. They had only stood close, and made it impossible to forget that she was a person among people, and not the warm certain attention hanging over the whole world, deciding.

She took her hands off the stone.

* * *

She went down into the square. She made them stay on the wall, all three, over Alice's objection, because there was a part of this she would not let anyone else stand in even the people she would let stand in her breaking, and that was the holding of the doors, which was hers, and only hers, and not a thing she would govern anyone else into.

She walked into the white where no person could walk, and she was not a person in the way they were, and the dark half poured off Harl and found her warm and did not eat her, because she was the source it was a far thin echo of, and she crossed the bleached square stepping carefully around the shapes of the going and not-going, and she came to stand a few feet from the ruined folded brightness that had been a wheelwright.

She did not reach in.

The whole of her wanted to. He was right there. His wild dark half spilled past her shoulder into the air, looking for a thin place, looking for the seam where it would open the door she could feel coming, and she could have closed her hand around it and set the joint and ended his nine days of unmaking himself, and every reason in the world said to, and one thing said not to, and the one thing was the line. Not his gift to govern. Not even to save him. Not even to save the three hundred. You do not reach into another person and decide what their gift should be, because once you are the person who reaches in for a good enough reason, you are only ever negotiating the reason, and she had watched a whole world get negotiated, and she would die before she made herself the council in a kinder coat.

So she did the thing that was hers. She held the doors.

She could not stop him spilling. But she could stand between the spilling and the world. Where the dark half of him reached for a thin place to open, she was there first, her own warmth laid over the seam, not closing it, not the Death symbol, just her presence, the source's own weight set against the lean of the cold so that the door could not catch. And where the spilling reached toward the streets that fed the schoolhouse, she was there, between, a girl in a travel coat standing in a white square with both arms full of an act no one watching could see, holding shut a thing that wanted

with all the patience of the void to open, and holding it, and holding it.

It cost. That was the part the letter could not have known to ask for. Reaching in would have cost four seconds and nothing she could feel. Holding the line cost everything, all of it, all at once and continuously, because the cold did not tire and she did, and there was no symbol to draw that would do it for her, no clever stroke, no easy mark that asked nothing, there was only her, standing, being the weight the spilling broke against, hour into hour into hour, while Harl burned down through the year of wildness in him toward the bottom of it, toward the place where there would at last be little enough left that a healer with both halves could reach a frightened unmade man and help him hold what remained.

She held the doors. Alice came down, against the order, because Alice had never once in her life obeyed an order that stood between her and a person who needed her hands, and the telling turns away here, from the worst of it, from the long hours of the holding and the burning-down and the moment near the end when the thing that had been Harl came briefly back into the shape of a man and saw, for one second, the square, and what had been done in it, and what he had done; the horror of that is not for describing and Viridia did not look away from it and will not write it down. She held the doors. When it was over the square was no longer white, and the ringing had stopped, and somewhere behind her a stone door opened and three hundred held breaths let go at once, a sound she felt more than heard, and she was still standing, because the wall did not fold, and she had not crossed the line, and the cost of not crossing it sat in her now where the four easy seconds would have sat, and she would carry it, because that was the trade, and she had made it with her eyes open.

* * *

She did not stay for the part where Renwick and Coyle discovered which of them the three hundred would follow.

She heard it begin before she was off the new wall, the two voices already finding the new shape of their old fight, *my men fed them, my wall held them*, the machinery starting up again over people who had not yet finished weeping, and she understood that she had ended a burning and changed nothing about the thing the burning was a symptom of, and that there would be another letter, from another valley, with another sash and another wall and another green-branch man, and that she could stop every burning in the world one at a time with her own body laid across the doors and the world would still be exactly this, two frightened men and a wall and the held breath of the governed.

Amber found her at the halt, in the grey, waiting for the slow line. She did not say *you did the right thing*. She knew Viridia did not want it and would not have believed it, and it was not, in the way Viridia counted, the right thing, it was only the thing that was still hers.

"They'll fight over them by morning," Amber said.

"Yes."

"And you can't fix that. Not without being the thing."

"No."

Amber was quiet a moment. The wind came down off the western hills, cold, smelling of stone. "So that's the question now," she said, slowly, working it out as she said it, which was the rare thing Amber did only when the question was real enough to outrun her quickness. "Not whether you'll rule. You answered that, on the wall. You won't. Good. I'll spend the rest of my life glad you won't." She turned to look at Viridia, and the flat seriousness on her face had something under it that was almost fear, the fear of a person

who has watched the easy answer get refused and seen, behind it, how much harder the hard one is going to be. "But there's still three hundred people in that schoolhouse, and a wall around them, and two men who'll bleed the region for them, and a cold thing leaning on the whole world because of a mercy you'd do again. And you won't fix it by deciding for them. So how do you fix a pressure," she said, "without controlling a single soul. Because that's the only question left, isn't it. And I don't think anybody's ever had to answer it before."

Viridia looked west, toward Lest, toward the wall, toward the cooling square and the two voices rising in it, and the answer was not in her, and she did not pretend it was, and the not-pretending was the only honest thing she had to offer the cold evening.

"No," she said. "I don't think anybody has."

The train came down out of the hills, late, its one lamp swinging, and she got on it to go home and find out.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Balance, Not Victory

There is a difference between fixing a thing and balancing it, and it had taken Viridia a year and three deaths and a white square to learn the size of the difference, and the size of it was this: a thing you fix you are done with, and a thing you balance you hold.

She had been raised inside the first idea. Everyone had. The whole of the world she had grown up in was built on the belief that a danger was a problem and a problem had a solution and a solution, once applied, stayed applied, the way you mend a roof or set a bone or, if you were a frightened council with your hands in the root of all magic, cut a world in half and walk away from the cutting as a thing accomplished. The council had thought they were fixing. That was the part she had finally understood, riding home in the dark from Lest with Amber's question sitting in her lap unanswered. They had not thought of themselves as oppressors holding a weight down by main force for six hundred years. They had thought they had solved something. They had drawn their line and stepped back from it and gone home to dinner believing the matter closed, and the matter had not been closed, the matter had been held, by the structure of the cut itself, by a strangling that had to renew itself in every generation of children born half

a thing, and they had not felt the holding because the holding was done by everyone except them.

That was what fixing was, she thought. Fixing was finding someone else to do the holding.

And she had done it again. She had done the opposite thing and arrived at the same trap. She had looked at a six-hundred-year wound and she had not throttled it, she had not strangled it, she had opened it, she had let the world run whole, and she had thought of that too as a thing accomplished, a wrong righted, a matter closed, paid for once and standing, by her, in a dark room. She had walked back out through the seam believing she was done. And she had not been done. She had only changed who did the holding, and the new holder was the void at the rim of everything, pressed against a world suddenly fuller than it had been built to be, and the new holding was being done not by children starved on half a wick but by a miller's wife named Sela and a wheelwright named Harl and eleven souls in a spring hamlet, drained one at a time to make the pressure even, the way water finds its level through any crack it can reach.

There was no fixing this. That was what the long ride had taught her, first and hardest, and she made herself hold it without flinching, the way she had made herself look at the white square. There was no stroke she could make that ended it. She could not un-mend the world; she had refused that on a kitchen night and refused it again, because un-mending was only the council's crime done backward, choosing for everyone that they should be half a thing again so that she could be done. She could not rule the world into safety; she had refused that on a wall above Lest with three people standing close enough that she could not pretend to be alone with the deciding. She could not even defeat the thing that was draining the world, because the thing

draining the world was not an enemy, was not a will, was not a creature she could meet and beat. It was a difference in pressure. It was absence drawn to presence, the oldest and least personal hunger there was, and you do not defeat a difference in pressure. You do not win against the fact that water runs downhill. You build the channel that lets it run without taking the village with it.

You balance it. You hold it. Forever.

* * *

She put it to them at the table at Wend, because the things she worked out alone went wrong, and the things she said out loud in front of Amber got their soft places found.

"Not victory," she said. "Balance."

Mrs. Zoran was there, which still felt strange to Viridia, a growth-teacher from a burned school sitting at a kitchen table a year and a war later with her hands wrapped around a cup, older and greyer and with a stillness on her she had not had in a classroom, the stillness of a woman who had walked out of a thing she should not have walked out of and spent the year since teaching frightened people to hold the dark half of a gift she barely held herself. She had brought Moravian back with her, three pupils' worth of it, kept alive in her head across the year the way you keep a fire alive on a wet trail, by tending it past all reason. She set the cup down to listen.

"Say the rest," Amber said.

"The world is too full." Viridia laid her hands flat on the wood. "Not too dangerous. Not too whole. Too full. I ran the lattice up tight and the void at the rim feels the fullness the way a low place feels a high one, and it pulls, and the pulling comes through any thin place it can reach, and the thin places are the tears, and the tears leak the Horrors, and the Horrors take a life and the life evens the pressure for an

hour and then the world is full again and the pull starts again. I cannot stop the pull. The pull is what the world is now. I made the world this way and I would make it this way again, because the other way was children starved to half their gift for six hundred years, and I will not put that back."

"So." Amber had the flat serious face. "We agree there's no fixing it."

"There's no fixing it."

"And you won't un-mend it and you won't rule it." Amber turned her cup a quarter turn on the wood, which was the thing she did with her hands when her mind was running ahead of her mouth and she wanted it to wait. "I've heard the two things you won't do for a year now. I'm starting to want to hear one you will."

"Contain it," Viridia said.

The word sat on the table. Mrs. Zoran's eyes came up.

"Not the world," Viridia said, before Amber could put the obvious knife in. "Not the people. I'm not going to contain anyone. The source is overflowing into a void that's too small for what I made, and the overflow is what kills, and the source is one thing in one place, and it is the only thing in all of this I have any right to put a hand on, because it is the thing I am." She heard her own voice go careful and flat, the surface coming up over the size of what she was saying. "I don't have to even out the pressure by spending lives at the rim. I can even it out at the source. I can stand at the fount and hold the overflow back, not close it, not the Death symbol, not killing magic again, just hold it, the way I held the doors at Lest, so the world stays full and the void stops getting the spillage that's drawing the tears open. Balance. The world whole and the rim quiet, both at once, held against each other."

"Held by what," Mrs. Zoran said. It was the first thing she had said in an hour, and she said it in the voice of a woman

who had spent a year teaching people that magic asks a price before it gives a gift, and who had heard a young one describe a free lunch.

"By me," Viridia said.

Alice, who had said nothing, who had been sitting at the end of the table with the long calm on her that the war had left her, the warmth banked and not out, the one crooked tooth catching the lamp when she turned her head, said, very quietly, "For how long."

Viridia did not answer that, because she did not yet know, and saying so plainly was all she had to give the table, and she had learned in a cold evening outside Lest that the not-pretending was worth more than the comfort.

"That's the part I don't have," she said. "How. And how long. The shape of it I think I have. The cost of it I don't. And there's only one place to learn the cost." She looked at her hands on the wood. "I have to go back down to the source. With the sight whole. And ask it what holding the balance would take."

Raizen, across the table, who had been turning a button on his cuff over and over because he still found buttons astonishing and used them the way other people used worry-stones, went still. The bond between them, which had been a quiet warm presence all evening, the way it was always there now, like a hand resting lightly on her shoulder from a great distance, drew tight. He had been at the far end of it in the cavern once. He knew what the source did to a person who put a hand in it whole.

"Then I go braced at the far end," he said. "Like before."

"Yes."

"And we go this time," Amber said. It was not a question and it was not an offer. It was the lesson out of Book Two laid on the table without anyone naming the chapter it came from, the lesson that the worst things should not be done

alone in the dark with no one to witness the cost. "All of us. To the cavern. We don't send you down the well and wait at the top counting."

"You can't come through the seam into the source itself," Viridia said. "No one can. That part is mine."

"Then we'll stand in the dark right outside the part that's yours," Amber said, "and that'll have to be close enough. It was the whole of what we could do at Lest and it turned out to be enough." She picked up her cup. The tea in it had gone cold, the way Amber's tea always went cold, because she only ever picked it up to have something to do with the hand that was not turning it. "When."

"Tomorrow," Viridia said.

"Tonight you eat," Mrs. Zoran said, with the flat finality of a teacher, and got up to find the bread, and the ordinariness of it, the bread and the lamp and the cold tea and the button, held the room up under the size of the thing they had just agreed to, the way the small warm true things had held her up her whole life under the cold reaching ones.

* * *

She opened the seam in the grey of the next morning, in the lee of a hill an hour's walk from Wend, with the four of them ranged behind her in the wet bracken, and she did it the way she did everything with magic now, not by reading a scroll but by meaning it, a thread of light magic drawn along an edgeless line in the air, and the air parted, and on the far side of it was the dark.

She felt the cavern before she stepped through, which was new, which was the sight come the rest of the way back over the slow year, an ember at a time, until now at last it was whole enough to feel the source itself reaching for her down the open seam, the old reach she had grown up beside. She had been blind walking out of this chamber a year ago.

She would not be blind walking back in. That was the one mercy the long count of weeks had given her and she was grateful for it the way you are grateful for a tool you are about to need.

"Stand here," she told them, at the mouth of the seam, in the changed feel where the wet hill ended and the dry deep stone began. "Don't come past this. If something goes wrong, you can't help by coming in. You can only help by being here when I come out."

"If you come out," Amber said, because Amber said the true thing, that was the deal.

"If I come out."

Raizen took her hand. He did not say anything. He only held it a moment in both of his, the way he had held it on the wall above the white square, large and careful, learning still the human business of touching the things you are afraid of losing, and then he let it go, because the going-in was hers, and he set himself at the seam's edge and she felt him brace, felt the bond go taut and steady and rooted, the one still line she would have at the far end of whatever came. Alice put a hand flat against the cold stone of the cavern wall and left it there, as if she meant to feel for tremors. Mrs. Zoran had her lips moving, soundless, three pupils' worth of Moravian running under her breath like a charm, which it was not, which she knew it was not, which she said anyway because a person tending a fire on a wet trail does not stop tending it just because the rain is coming harder.

Viridia crossed the unworked floor to the pedestal.

The pool lay in its hollowed top, pale and glowing of its own accord, lighting nothing but itself in the dry dark, and it was exactly as it had been, because it was the one thing that never changed, the thing the world was borrowed from. She stood over it. She did not have a broken-open self to bring to it this time, no continent of grief at her back, no cold part

shattered on a stone. She had a year of holding herself together and a worked-out problem and a level held stillness over a wanting she had kept at arm's length since the table. She leaned over the pool, and the light side of her stirred and the dark side stirred, both at once, and the split symbol rose to the surface to meet her, the two-halved mark her lost focus had worn and her mother's book had worn, and the pool divided, light to one side and dark to the other.

She put her hand into the source, and she asked it the question she had come to ask. Not *make me larger*. Not *show me the wound*. She asked: *what would it take to hold the balance*.

And the source, which only ever answered what it was asked the way it was asked, opened, and let her feel the answer instead of telling it, the way it had given her everything she had ever learned from it.

* * *

She felt the shape of the holding the way you feel the weight of a thing the instant before you decide whether you can lift it.

It was not a stroke. That was the first part of the answer and it landed like a stone going down a well, turning and turning and never hitting bottom. There was no symbol for it, no clever mark, no single act done once and walked away from. The Death symbol could close a portal; she felt that, felt it offered to her almost kindly in the weave, the easy clean thing that asked nothing, and felt under it the thing the easy clean thing would cost, which was a world with one fewer channel for its fullness, then two fewer, then the slow strangling of the source itself one sealed door at a time until the world ran thin again and she was the council in a kinder coat, having killed magic a second time to be done with the holding of it. That was fixing. The source showed her fixing, and showed her the floor under fixing, which was a

half-made world made half again by a girl who could not bear to hold a thing forever.

And it showed her holding.

Holding was her standing where she stood now, at the fount, with the overflow of the whole remade world coming up through the source toward the void at the rim, and her own self set against it, not closing it, not damming it, only being the weight the overflow broke against and was spread thin by and sent back out into the world even and unspilling, so that the rim stayed quiet and no Sela in any hamlet was drained to even a pressure she could even at the source. She felt how it would be. She felt the source running full up her arm and pouring on through her into everything alive, and felt herself become the place the running passed through and was measured at, the throat of the whole thing, the one core in all the weave that was tied to the source the way the source was tied to everything, made into the valve the council had never thought a world could have, because the council had thought the only way to control a flood was a wall and had never once imagined a person willing to be the riverbed.

And she felt the cost.

It came up her arm not as a knowing this time but as a duration, which was worse, because a knowing lands and is over and a duration does not land at all, it only opens out ahead of you and keeps opening. She felt that the holding was not a thing she did. It was a thing she became. She would not stand at the fount with her hand in the pool for an hour or a day or a hard year and then step back out and go home to bread and a lamp and a button turned on a cuff. The balance held only as long as the weight held, and the weight was her, and a weight that steps away is not a weight, it is a pause. She would have to be the holding. Not visit it. Be it. The source would run through her every hour she was alive

whether she was at the cavern or at a kitchen table a hundred miles off, because the tie did not need her hand in the pool, it had never needed her hand in the pool, the hand in the pool was only how she asked, and the asking was answered and the answer was: you are already the valve, you have been the valve since the day you closed the cut, the only choice left to you is whether to hold the valve true or let it spill, and holding it true costs you the whole of every remaining hour of the longest life that was ever going to be lived, and you have a very, very long life, because of the bond, because of what you are, you will outlive nearly everyone, and you will spend the whole length of it standing in a doorway you can never come out of, holding shut against the cold a thing that never tires, while everyone you love grows old in the warm rooms behind you and dies in them and is filed, one at a time, in the place you do not visit, and you go on holding, and there is no stopping, and there is no being done.

That was balance. Not a victory. A post. Hers, until the end of a life with almost no end.

She stood at the pedestal with her hand in the source and she felt the size of it, the whole length of it opening out ahead of her and not landing, and she did not pull her hand back, because she had come to learn the cost and the cost was learned and pulling her hand back would not unlearn it. She held still. The held quiet lay over her face in a room with no one to see it. And under it, the part that did the arithmetic so the rest of her could survive the choosing, ran the only sum it had left to run, which was not whether the holding was worth doing, that sum was already cast, three hundred breaths let go in a stone schoolhouse and a miller's two orphaned children had cast it, but whether she could bear the length of it, and the cold part, which did not lie to her, which had never once lied to her, returned no answer,

because there was no answer, because no one had ever been asked to bear a thing that long and the arithmetic had no column for forever.

* * *

And the source, while she held still and felt the length of the cost, gave her back the thread.

She had known it would. That was the second reason she had come, the reason she had not said at the table, the reason she had kept at arm's length since the night Amber asked her how long. The thread had been there at her hand the last time, the line that ran not outward into the world but down, warmer than the rest, with her name on it the way a letter has your name on it, and she had reached for it once with the whole of herself and found it had no bottom and let it go, because the world had been on the table and the table had been her. The world was on the table again. But she was not closing a wound now. She was learning a cost. And learning a cost was the one errand in all the world she might be able to finish before she had to set herself in a doorway forever, and there was a thing she had wanted to know her whole life long, under all the other wanting, and the thread quivered as it surfaced, the way it had quivered once before, as if it heard her.

Mother, she said into the pool, before the held quiet could decide whether to let her. *Bella*.

She reached for it.

It had no bottom. It had no bottom now any more than it had had a bottom the first time, and she felt the depth open under her the way the cost had opened, on and on, the warm stillness leading down into a place the source held somewhere she could not go, behind the thing she still could not name and would not look at straight. But she was the valve now. She had not been the valve the last two times. She

was tied to the source the way the source was tied to everything, and that tie ran her own self down the thread further than a girl reaching out of grief had ever been able to send it, and she went down the warm dark with the thread leading her, spending herself the way the source had shown her she would spend herself, a little, then more, then more than she had meant to, learning with every length she poured that the bottom was still not there, and just as she understood that she had made the same mistake she had made before and was about to make it worse, with more of herself to lose, the thread, for the first time in her life, gave her something back.

Not a bottom. Not an answer. Not her mother's face, or her voice, or a place, or a yes. It gave her, the way the source gave everything, a feel. A single feel, carried up the warm line from the depth that had no bottom, and the feel was this: that someone had come down this thread before her. That the thread did not lead to a place where her mother *was*. It led to a place her mother had *gone*. That the warm stillness at the unreachable end of it was not a person waiting to be reached but the shape a person leaves in deep water when she has poured the whole of herself down after a thing with no bottom and not come back up, the long smooth absence of a swimmer who set against the rope and then, at the last, let the rope go.

Bella had been the valve. Or something like it, in some older shape of the world, with some older overflow. Bella had stood in a doorway, and held a thing, and then she had reached down a warm line after a question of her own, and she had not come back, and the stillness Viridia had grieved beside for fourteen years and reached for twice was not her mother's presence kept safe in the source. It was her mother's cost. It was the exact shape of the thing now opening out ahead of Viridia herself. She had not been

reaching toward her mother. She had been reaching toward her own future, and it had her mother's name on it because her mother had got there first.

And below that, far below, at the very edge of where the feel could carry, past the place where her mother had gone, there was the nameless thing, the abstract cold edge of everything that was not absence-as-grief but absence-as-fact, and it was on the far side of the bottomless thread the way it was on the far side of the rim, and for one half-second, reaching, she felt it the way she had felt it once before from the pedestal, felt it notice the warmth of her pouring down toward it, and she understood, with a cold that had nothing to do with the cavern, that the thread did not only lead down to where her mother had gone. It led on. Past her. Into the place a fuller world was pressing against. And she turned her seeing away from it. She had no name for it and she would not give it one, and the bodies were real and the cold edge was not, yet, and a person chooses for the real ones first, and so she did the worst thing she did in that room, harder than the cost, harder than the holding.

She let go of the thread.

She let the warm stillness with her mother's name on it sink back down into the source's keeping, unfollowed, and this time she let it go knowing what was at the bottom of it, which was not her mother, which was the same doorway she would have to stand in, which had her mother already standing in it, gone. She drew her hand up out of the pool, slow, shaking, the way she had drawn it out a year ago, except that this time the sight did not gutter, this time she came back from the well seeing, which was its own cruelty, because it meant she would see, for the whole long length of the holding, every face she stood the doorway in front of and could never turn around to.

She stood at the pedestal in the dim, and she made no sound, because the grief had been allowed out once, down a bond, in this same kind of dark, and it had gone back inward after and stayed there, and she would let no living soul in this cavern see it and there was nowhere further out for it to go. She filed it. She filed the cost and the duration and the thread and the long smooth absence of a swimmer who let the rope go, in the place she did not visit, beside the white square and the warm quiet shape she had laid a hand on at a battle's end, and she wiped her face on her sleeve, twice, carefully, in a chamber with no one in it to read the wiping, and the wiping was for no one.

Then she opened the seam, and the cold from outside it came in over her, the wet of the hill and the bracken, and on the far side of it, in the changed feel where the deep stone ended, were the four of them, exactly where she had left them, Raizen braced at the far end of a bond gone tight enough to ache, Alice with her hand still flat on the stone, Amber with her arms crossed and her face white and the question already forming on it, Mrs. Zoran with her lips finally stilled.

* * *

She came through, and the seam sealed behind her, and Raizen had her before she was fully out of it, the bond and then his arms, and she let him, for a moment, in the dark, where the others' eyes could not make out more than that he held her up, which was a thing he could do without it being seen as a thing she needed.

"You found it," Amber said. Not the cost. She would not ask the cost in front of the others until Viridia gave it leave, that was the old deal too. "The how. You found the how."

"I found the how," Viridia said.

"And it works. Balance. The world stays whole and the rim goes quiet."

"It works."

Amber's arms came uncrossed, slowly, the white going off her face, the relief starting up the way relief had started up in a man named Coyle on a railway platform, and Viridia watched it start and could not stop it and did not want to, because there was a true thing in it, the world could be held, no one else had to be drained, the channel could be built. That part was real. Amber should have it. Alice should have it. They had earned a minute of it.

"So what does it take," Amber said, and the relief was still on her, and the question was the practical one, the next-step one, *what do we gather, who do we call, when do we go*, and not yet the other one, and Viridia understood that she had perhaps a breath, two breaths, before the practical question and the other question became the same question in Amber's quick mind, before Amber heard the answer she was about to give and ran it forward the way Amber ran everything forward and arrived, white again, at the floor under it.

She could have softened it. She had softened things before, for kindness, for a minute's grace. She looked at Raizen's dark ordinary eyes close to hers, the human eyes the change had dimmed down out of lightning, the eyes she would watch grow old over a length of years and then watch close, from a doorway, holding, and she did not soften it, because the not-pretending was the only thing she had ever had to offer the people who stood close, and they had not earned a lie for standing close, they had earned the truth.

"Me," she said. "It takes me. Standing at the fount holding the overflow. Not for a season. Not until it's fixed. There's no until." Her voice came out level, the flat careful surface holding over the duration that would not land. "It isn't a

thing you do. It's a thing you are, and I'd be it for the whole length of what I've got, and what I've got is longer than anyone's, because of the bond, because of what I am. The world stays whole because I stand in a doorway I don't come out of, and I watch all of you live your lives in the rooms behind me, and I file you, one at a time, when it's your turn, and I keep holding. That's the cost. That's balance." She forced out the last of it, the worst of it, the thing the thread had given her, because they were going to live the rest of the question with her and they should live it with the whole of it. "My mother did it. Some older shape of it. That's where the thread goes. She stood in a doorway and held a thing and then she reached for something past it and she didn't come back, and the stillness I've grieved my whole life isn't her keeping. It's the place she's gone. It's the doorway. It's already got my name carved next to hers, and it always did, and I just couldn't read it until today."

No one spoke.

The wind came down off the hill, cold, smelling of wet stone, and Raizen's arms had not loosened, and the bond between them was running so quiet now that it was almost the only sound, and Amber's face had gone white in the way Viridia had braced for, the white of someone who has watched the easy answer get refused and the hard answer get found and then seen, behind the hard answer, the thing it would cost, which was worse than the easy answer would ever have been, because the easy answers cost the world its soul and the hard one was only going to cost Viridia the whole of hers, slowly, forever, in a doorway, alone.

"There has to be another way to carry it," Amber said, and her voice did the thing it never did, it climbed, just slightly, at the end, the smallest crack in the flat seriousness, the question asked not as a question now but as a refusal. "You don't get to be the only pair of hands. You told me that

yourself. Alice told you that on a wall. You were never the only pair of hands."

"I know," Viridia said.

"So there's another way."

Viridia looked at her, and at Alice, and at Mrs. Zoran with her stilled lips, and at Raizen whose arms held her up in a dark where no one could quite see how much she was being held, and she gave them neither a *yes* nor a *no*, because she did not know, because the source had shown her the doorway and her mother in it and had not shown her any second pair of hands that could share it, and the truth of that was all she could set on the table between them, and a year of kitchens and walls and cold evenings outside burning towns had taught her that the not-pretending was worth more than the comfort, even now, even this.

"I don't know," she said. "But I know the shape of what it asks, now. And I know it has my mother's name on it. And I'm going to spend whatever's left before I have to stand in it finding out whether anybody's ever had to stand in it alone." She straightened, out of Raizen's hold, slowly, onto her own feet on the wet hill, into the grey morning, and she set her face west toward home, toward the bread and the lamp and the long table behind which the people she loved would grow old while she watched. "Because that's the only question left. Not whether I'll hold the balance. I'll hold it. There's nobody else who can. The question is whether holding it has to take the whole of me, the way it took the whole of her."

The thread had not given her that answer. It had no bottom, and neither, she was beginning to understand, did the cost.

She walked back down the hill in the rain to find out.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Brink

The bells started at Coldharbour before the sun was up, and by the time Viridia reached the high street the town was already running the wrong way.

That was what she understood first, standing in the mouth of the lane with Amber a stride behind her and the bond drawn tight at her back where Raizen had stopped to take in the sky. People did not run toward the river to fight a thing. They ran toward the river because there was nowhere else for the road to take them, and the thing was behind them, in the east, where the dark was not lifting the way dark lifts. She had felt it from the train. She had felt it the way she felt everything now, the sight come the rest of the way back over the year, a pressure on the lattice like a thumb pressed to the inside of her skull, and she had told the others it was a tear and she had been wrong. It was not a tear.

It was eleven of them. She counted before she could stop herself. Eleven thin places opened in a rough arc east of the town, all of them at once, all of them leaking, and through every one the same cold absence reaching in toward the warmth the way water reaches for a low place, and the low place was not the town. She knew that now, the way a pool in a cave had cost her to learn it. The low place was her. The town was only in the way.

"How many," Amber said.

"Eleven."

Amber did not say anything for a moment. The number sat between them in the grey. Then she said the practical thing, because she always said the practical thing first, before the fear got into her voice and made it useless. "We've closed one at a time. We've never closed two."

"No."

"How long does a town like this have."

Viridia looked at the bridge, where the press of bodies had jammed itself between the stone rails, where an ox had gone down in the traces and a cart had tipped and three men were trying to lift it and a child was screaming somewhere under the noise of everyone trying not to. She made the cold part do the arithmetic. Eleven mouths drawing on a place that was full of people, and the people the nearest warmth, and the drawing not stopping, not slowing, not interested in fighting because there was nothing in it that could fight, only the long even pull of a difference that wanted to be evened.

"Less than the morning," she said.

* * *

Raizen came up beside her, and the sky was the thing he was still looking at, his head tipped back, his dark eyes moving over the east. He had spent most of his long life reading weather from above and he read it still by habit, and what he read in it now made the line of his jaw go hard.

"They're not spread random," he said. "Look at the arc. It bends toward you." He brought his eyes down to her. "They opened where you'd feel them."

"I know."

"It's a hand closing." He said it plainly, the way he said the things that frightened him, the one manner he had ever learned for it, having been a creature that did not get

frightened across six centuries and was now a man who did. "Whatever's tearing them, it's tearing them in a shape. Toward the source. Toward you."

"I know, Raizen."

"Then we don't stand in the middle of the hand."

It was good sense. It was the sense she would have given anyone else. She looked at the bridge again, at the ox and the cart and the child under the noise, and she did not move toward the road out, and Raizen watched her not move, and the bond between them carried the thing she did not say, which was that the whole long year had gone into deciding she would not be the council, and the council's first move had always been to weigh a town against a plan and choose the plan, and call it the hard necessary thing, and go home to dinner with the matter closed.

"We close them," she said. "We start at the bridge and we work east and we close them as we go. Amber pulls people back behind each one as it shuts. Raizen takes the air and tells me which one's reaching hardest so I close the worst first." She was already moving. "Where's Alice."

"Behind us, with the Coldharbour wardens," Amber said. "Trying to teach forty terrified whole-mages to hold a dark half they got six months ago without burning the town down by accident. Same as always."

"Keep her there. That's the wall behind us. If that wall goes, the running starts and the running is what feeds them." She reached the first thin place, at the end of the bridge, where the air had gone wrong in a stretch the height of a door, the look of heat over a road except cold, except hungry, and on the far side of it the nothing she had no name for and would not give one. "Pull them back, Amber. Now."

* * *

The first one she closed the costly way, because that was the one way she had let herself keep.

She set her hand to the edge of the tear and she did not reach for the clean mark, the easy clean thing Drake had taught her on a boat in Book Two, the thing that asked nothing. She reached instead into her own self, into the warm running she had been since the rebirth, and she spent it, she poured a measure of the source's own warmth into the cold thin place until the difference at that one door was evened and the pull let go and the air closed over like water closing over a dropped stone. It cost. She felt it go out of her. She felt the small honest emptiness it left, the price the work was supposed to ask, the price that meant she had not done it the council's way.

It took the length of forty breaths. She did not have forty breaths apiece, eleven times over.

"One," Amber called, already three doors east, hauling an old man by the back of his coat, her face streaked with the river mud the crowd had churned up. "Vee. They're widening. The next two ran together while you were on that one."

She straightened. She looked east along the arc, and Raizen's voice came down the bond before his shout reached her, *the third, the third's the worst, it's pulling the wardens' line*, and she saw it, a thin place gone wide as a barn door, the cold coming through it in a slow visible wrongness like the air over a fire run backward, and behind it, fifty strides off, Alice's wall of frightened whole-mages already starting to bow.

She ran for the third one.

She closed it the costly way too, because she had said she would, because the easy way was a door she had nailed shut in herself a year ago. It took longer. It cost more. The warm running emptied out of her in a long pour and the honest

emptiness it left was not small this time, and when she stood up from it the lattice swam in her sight, the way a room swims when you stand too fast, and she understood with the cold part, dispassionately, the way it understood everything, that she had perhaps closed three and could close perhaps two more before she fell down in the mud and the town finished dying around her unconscious body.

Five. There were eleven.

* * *

It was somewhere in there, between the third door and the fourth, that the easy clean thing offered itself.

It did not come as a temptation the way a temptation comes in a story, a voice, a whisper, a hand on the shoulder. It came as a memory, which was worse, because a memory you trust. She was on her knees in the river mud with the warm running gone thin in her, and the fourth door yawning, and the cold part of her ran ahead the way it always ran ahead, and it laid the answer out flat and reasonable, the way Drake had laid it out flat and reasonable on the boat: the Death symbol does not spend you. The Death symbol closes a door and asks you for nothing. You could close all eleven before the next forty breaths were out. You could close every door in the world. You would never be on your knees in the mud again. You could go further than the doors. The doors are only the small mouths of the one big mouth. The source overflows and the void pulls and the pull tears the doors, and there is one clean mark that closes a door against a pull, and there is one source the whole pull comes up through, and a mark that closes a door against a pull would close —

She stopped the thought with her whole self, the way you stop a cart rolling back on you.

It would close the source. That was where the reasonable flat clean voice had been walking her, one door at a time, the same path it had walked the council six hundred years ago. Seal the small doors today, and tomorrow, kneeling in some other town's mud, too tired to spend yourself, you reason that the doors keep tearing because the pull keeps pulling, and the pull keeps pulling because the source keeps overflowing, and there is a clean mark, and it asks nothing, and you are so tired, and you put the clean mark on the fount itself and you close it, a little, then more, the way she had felt it in the cavern, the slow strangling of the world's wholeness one sealed measure at a time, until magic ran thin again and children were born half a thing again and she was the old council wearing a kinder coat, having killed the world a second time to be done with the holding of it.

The easy thing asked nothing because it took everything. She had come to know it on her knees in front of a pool. She learned it again on her knees in the mud, which was the only place she ever seemed to learn anything.

"No," she said, out loud, to no one, to the clean mark, to Drake on a boat a year gone, to the part of herself that did the arithmetic and wanted, more than anything, simply to be done. "I'm not closing the world to save the town."

She got up. Her legs did the thing legs do when they have decided not to hold you and you make them anyway. She went to the fourth door and she closed it the costly way, and the warm running in her was so thin now that she closed her eyes to do it and was not sure, for a moment afterward, whether she had opened them again.

* * *

The wall went at the fifth door.

She felt it before she heard it, the warmth of forty frightened cores breaking from a line into a scatter, the

worst thing, the thing she had told Amber was the thing that fed them. The whole-mages had held as long as people hold who got the dark half of their gift six months ago and have never once used it for anything but practice in a barn, and then a sixth door had torn open behind them, where no door had been, inside the wall, between the wall and the bridge, and the cold had come up through the middle of them, and they had run.

The running was what fed them. Viridia had said it twice. She had not said the other half of it, the half she had kept from her own mouth on purpose, which was that a scattering crowd is a field of separate warmths and a thing pulled toward warmth will go to the nearest separate one and take it, because a person alone is easier to even than a person in a wall.

Alice did not run.

Viridia saw it from the fifth door, across the churned ground, in the grey half-light: the wardens scattering and Alice not scattering, Alice with her changed long calm on her, standing in the gap the new door had torn, her arms out, doing the thing Alice had always done and the war had only deepened, which was to be the still point other people could find in the dark. She had her crooked-tooth almost-smile on, the one she used to settle frightened first-years, the one she had used on Viridia across a desk over Moravian a hundred years ago. She was turning the running back into a wall by being a thing too calm to run from.

And the cold came up through the new door three strides from her.

"Alice," Viridia said, and it was not a shout, it was the sound a person makes when the air is gone out of them, and she was already moving, and she was thirty strides off and empty of the warm running and there was nothing in her hands to throw.

* * *

Amber got there first.

Amber, who had been hauling the old man, who was nearest, who did what she had always done on a railway platform and a wall above Lest and a kitchen full of people deciding terrible things, which was to put her own body between the danger and the person, without weighing it, without the arithmetic, because Amber's arithmetic was done in advance and the answer was always the same and the answer was *not her*. She hit Alice at the shoulder and drove her sideways out of the cold's reach and into the churned mud, and the shove that saved Alice put Amber where Alice had been.

The cold took Amber instead.

Viridia felt it take her down the lattice, felt a warmth she had known for a year, the steady stubborn quick-running warmth that turned its teacup a quarter turn and let its tea go cold, felt it touched by the long even pull and felt it start, the way Sela had started, the way Harl had started, the way eleven souls in a spring hamlet had started, to spend itself into the evening of a pressure that did not care whose warmth it was.

Here is what the camera saw, and no more: Amber on her knees in the mud, her hands open, her face going the grey of the morning, her mouth shaping a word that did not have enough breath behind it to become one. The cold over her like heat run backward. And the small terrible quiet of a thing being drawn out that does not hurt the way a wound hurts, that only empties, the way a bath empties, the way a day empties at its end whether you are ready for the dark or not.

Viridia did not have forty breaths. She did not have four. She had Amber, going.

* * *

She broke the one promise she had sworn she would never break, and she broke it without deciding to, which was the only mercy in it, because if she had decided to she would have had to live with the deciding.

She reached for the easy clean thing.

Her hand was already coming up with the Death-symbol mark forming in it, the clean cold sure thing that asked nothing, the thing that would close the door over Amber in a single breath instead of forty, and she had it half-drawn on the air, and in the half-drawing she felt where it wanted to go after, felt the path open under it, the doors and the doors and the one big mouth at the bottom, and she understood that she was a single stroke from saving Amber and three strokes from the council and that on her knees with Amber going grey she did not, in that instant, care.

She cared about Amber.

And then the bond went taut.

Not a word. Raizen was a hundred feet up and a hundred strides off and there was no word he could have sent that would have reached her in time. It was not a word. It was the thing the bond was, the still rooted line he had set himself to be at the far end of, the hand resting on her shoulder from a great distance, and he did not pull her back from the mark and he did not argue the arithmetic, because he could not see the mark and did not know the arithmetic. He only did the one thing the bond could do, which was to be a steadying warmth she was tied to, rooted, not running, not scattering, a wall of one, and the feel of it down the lattice reminded her, in the half-second she needed reminding, that warmth held together is not warmth alone, that a person in a wall is harder to even than a person scattered, that the answer to a pull is never a wall against the world.

It was not the Death symbol. The Death symbol was a wall. She had a year of learning that a wall was the council's answer and the riverbed was hers.

She let the half-drawn mark fall apart in her hand. And she did the other thing, the costly thing, the only thing that was hers, except she did it the way she had never done it before, because she had never before had nothing left to spend.

She spent what she did not have.

* * *

She had told the source she would be the valve. She had not, until that moment, been the valve.

She knelt in the mud and she did not reach into her own thin warm running, because there was none left to reach into, and instead she reached down the tie, the deep tie, the one the cavern had shown her ran from her own self to the source the way the source ran to everything, the tie that did not need her hand in the pool. She opened it. She let the source run up through her, not a measure of stored warmth this time but the live overflow itself, the thing she was supposed to spend the whole length of her long life standing in a doorway to hold back, and she did not hold it back. She let it come. She let it run up the tie and up her arm and out into the cold over Amber, the whole pressing fullness of a remade world, and she did with it the thing she had felt herself become at the pedestal: she did not close the door and she did not dam it, she set herself in front of it and made the overflow break against her and spread thin and go out even, into the cold, until the cold over Amber had nothing left to pull because the difference at that one place was gone, evened, not by Amber's warmth and not by Viridia's but by the source's own, run through the valve the way it was always going to run through the valve, forever.

The door over Amber closed. Not with the clean mark's clean snap. With the slow soft closing of water finding its level, the cold gone because there was nothing for it to want.

And Viridia felt, for one half-second, with her hand in nothing and the source running up through her live and whole, exactly what the rest of her life was going to be. She felt the doorway. She stood in it. She held the world's fullness against the cold and let it through even, and the cold could not take Amber, could not take the town, could not take anyone, because she was the place the difference was measured and made level, and she understood in her body, not her arithmetic, what the cavern had only shown her as a duration: that this was not a thing she would do. It was a thing she was. It had her name on it. It had her mother's name carved next to hers.

It lasted one half-second, because she could not yet hold it, because she had not yet given herself to it, because the giving was the whole of a life and this was only one morning in the mud.

Then she fell over in the mud.

* * *

The other five doors were still open.

She knew it before she had her face out of the mud. She lay there a moment with the cold light coming up grey over the river and the bond taut and warm at her back and Amber's breath, alive, ragged, three feet away, the most welcome sound she had heard in a year, and she made herself find the lattice through the swimming, and the five remaining doors were there, east along the bending arc, still leaking, the cold still reaching, the town still in the way.

She could not close them the costly way. There was no costly warmth left in her and she had just learned, in the most expensive half-second of her life, that the live overflow

she could run through the valve was not a thing she could spend in a brawl, town to town, door to door, on her knees in the mud, because it would not stop. Once she opened the tie all the way it ran, and she could not yet shut it off cleanly, and a town saved by a valve held open by a girl too tired to close it was a town about to be drowned in the very fullness the doors were leaking. She had felt the edge of that too. She was not a tap. Not yet. She was a girl on the ground who had cracked open something that was meant to be held perfectly and forever and had held it for half a second, badly, and would pay for the half-second with three days of feeling like a wrung cloth.

So there was the brink, laid out flat by the cold part the way the cold part laid everything out. Five doors. No warmth to close them the right way. The valve she could not yet hold open without flooding what she meant to save. And the one clean mark in the whole of creation that would close all five before the next breath, and ask nothing, and walk her one stroke at a time to the fount, and close the world.

Amber's hand found her arm. "Vee." Her voice was gone thin and grey but it was her voice. "Get up. You're not done."

"I can't close them the right way. There's nothing left."

"Then close them the wrong way and we'll fight about it after."

"The wrong way doesn't stop at the doors." She got her knees under her. The lattice swam. "The wrong way ends with me doing to the world what they did to it. I've spent a year knowing that. I'm not going to forget it because I'm tired."

"Then what."

Viridia looked east at the five doors, and west at the broken wall and the scatter of frightened whole-mages that Alice was already, somehow, on her feet, with mud down one side of her, gathering back toward a still point, and she

looked up at Raizen coming down out of the grey, and she did the only thing left that was neither the costly way she had run dry nor the clean way that ended the world.

She did not close the doors.

She made the town stop being the low place.

* * *

"Alice," she called, and her voice came out wrecked, and she did not care. "Get them into a ring. All of them. Closest in, in a ring around the wardens, hand to hand, dark half banked, light half open. Don't fight the doors. Don't go near the doors. Just hold together and hold warm and don't anybody run."

Alice did not ask why. That was the thing about Alice, the thing the desk over Moravian had taught Viridia a hundred years ago: Alice trusted the working before she understood it, and that trust was its own kind of magic. She had the wardens turning, the scatter pulling back in, the ring beginning, her crooked-tooth calm doing the work no symbol could do.

"Raizen." He was down, beside her, his hands under her arm. She found his dark eyes, the ordinary human dark the change had left him, the eyes she had told a cavern she would watch grow old from a doorway. "Up. Carry me along the ring. I can't walk and I have to be inside it."

"Why," he said, because he was allowed to ask, because the bond meant he carried the cost with her and a person who carries the cost is allowed to ask the why.

"Because a thing pulled toward warmth goes to the nearest separate warmth," she said, as he lifted her, as the lattice swam and steadied against the rooted line of him, "and if there's no separate warmth, if it's all one warmth, all held together, all in a ring, then the nearest low place in this whole town isn't a frightened miller's wife on her own. It's me. I'm the lowest place there is. I'm tied to the source and

the source is the deepest well in the world." She got the words out against the swimming. "I can't close the doors. But I can stand in the middle of a warm ring and be a deeper low place than the doors, and let the pull come to me instead of the town, and just hold, just be the riverbed, not fight it, not close it, hold it, until the doors close themselves the way they opened, because a hand that closes opens again, Raizen, a hand can't stay closed forever, nothing can hold a pull forever except —"

She left the sentence where it was. He knew its end. He had heard it in a cavern. *Except me.*

* * *

It was the longest hour of her life, and almost nothing happened in it, which was the whole of the point.

Raizen carried her into the middle of the ring and set her down. The whole-mages held hands, dark banked, light open, the way she'd told them, forty frightened people doing the one thing terrified people can almost never do, which is nothing, which is stand still and hold on. Alice walked the inside of the ring with her crooked-tooth calm and her low voice and kept them holding. Amber sat in the mud with her grey face and her cold tea of a heart and watched the east. Raizen stood over Viridia at the dead center of the warm ring with his hand on her shoulder, the bond and the hand both. And Viridia opened the tie. Not all the way. Not the flood. A crack. Enough that the source's depth ran up through her into the lowest place she could make of herself, enough that she became, for one held hour, the deepest low place in the valley, deeper than the doors, deeper than the cold could find anywhere else, so that the long even pull of eleven thin places turned, slowly, the way water turns toward the deepest crack, away from the warm ring, away from the town, toward her.

She held it. That was all. She did not close it and she did not fight it and she would not give it leave to flood. She let the cold come to her and she let the source's depth take it and even it and send it back out level, and she held the crack open exactly as wide as it needed to be and not a hair wider, and it was the hardest thing she had ever done with magic and it looked, from the outside, like a girl lying still in the mud doing nothing at all.

The doors did not close because she closed them. They closed because the hand that opened them could not hold them open against a deeper low place than the town, and one by one, east along the arc, in no order, the cold let go and the thin places healed over the slow soft way water closes, the way the fifth door had closed over Amber, because the difference they were pulling toward had moved, and moved into a place that could swallow it and not be drained.

When the last one closed, the sun was fully up. The bells had stopped. The town was a town again, broken in the way a town is broken after a panic, the ox dead in the traces and the cart on its side and somebody crying somewhere that the worst was over, and the warm ring stood holding hands in the mud not quite believing it was allowed to let go.

Viridia closed the crack. It was, she found, harder to close than to open, and she filed that, in the cold place, beside everything else she was learning about the doorway she was going to live in.

* * *

She let Raizen help her sit up but not stand, because there is being brave and there is being a fool, and the line between them, her mother had apparently learned, was a thing you had to find before you went down a well you couldn't come back up.

Amber came over and sat down in the mud next to her, heavily, the way Amber never sat, and for a while neither of them said anything, and the not-saying was the whole conversation. Then Amber said, looking east at the healed doors, "You could have closed them. The clean way. I saw your hand."

"Yes."

"You had it half-made. When the cold had me." Amber's voice did the thing it almost never did, went careful. "You didn't."

"No."

"Why not. You'd have saved me four breaths sooner."

Viridia looked at her own hands, muddy, empty, the hands that had half-drawn a mark that would have closed the world one stroke at a time. "Because I'd have done it again the next town. And easier. And the town after that I'd have closed a door that didn't need closing because the clean way asks nothing and a thing that asks nothing you start using for everything. And six towns on I'd be too tired to spend myself, and the clean mark would still be free, and I'd put it on something it shouldn't go on, because I was tired and it was free, and it goes all the way down, Amber. The doors are the small mouths of the one big mouth. The clean way doesn't stop at the doors. It never stops. It's a slope and the council went all the way down it and called every step necessary." She turned her muddy hand over. "I'd rather kneel in the mud spending myself for the rest of my life than take one step onto that slope. Because I know where the slope ends. I've stood at the bottom of it. It's a pool in a cave with my whole world hanging off it."

Amber was quiet. Then she said, "You ran the source. Through you. To save me. I felt the air go strange."

"Yes."

"That's the thing. The doorway thing. The forever thing."

"A crack of it. For an hour. Badly." Viridia let out a breath. "It's going to be that, Amber. Not the slope. The other thing. Standing in the doorway being the deep place so the pull comes to me and not to towns. That's what today was, small and bad and only for an hour. The real one's the whole of my life and I don't get to lie down in the mud after." She heard her voice go flat and level and let it, because there were too many people near and the grief had been let out once already this book, to one person, in the dark, and it was not coming out again. "I learned it for certain today. There isn't another way to carry it. I looked for one the whole hour. The valve's only got room for one and it's me."

* * *

Raizen sat down on her other side, which put her between the two warmths she trusted most in the world, the deliberate human carefulness of him still learning how close was too close, and she let herself be between them a moment, in the mud, in the risen sun, the way she had let small warm true things hold her up under cold reaching ones her whole life.

"Then it's decided," Raizen said.

She did not pretend not to understand him. "It's decided."

Alice had come to stand over them, mud down one side of her, the crooked tooth catching the morning, her changed long calm on her, and behind the calm a thing Viridia had not seen on her since before the war, the look someone wears having just watched another soul choose the harder right thing at a cost and does not have words equal to it and is not going to insult it with the small ones. Alice put her hand flat on the top of Viridia's head, once, the way you would steady something precious you were afraid to pick up, and took it away.

"There's a thing nobody's saying," Amber said, because Amber said the true thing, that was the deal. "We held a town today by you being the deep place for one hour and it nearly killed you and there were eleven doors. There are going to be more than eleven. There are going to be more towns. We can't carry you to the middle of a ring in every town in the world and we can't close them the clean way and we can't close them the costly way fast enough and the only thing that worked today was you being the valve, for an hour, badly." She looked east, and then west, and then at Viridia, and her quick mind had run the whole thing forward the way it always ran everything forward and arrived, white-faced, at the floor under it, which was not whether but when. "It's not going to be enough to do it for an hour. Towns at a time. Is it."

"No," Viridia said.

"It has to be all of it. All at once. From the source. The whole world held at the deep place, so the pull comes to one doorway and not to a hundred towns."

"Yes."

"And the doorway's you. For good. Starting soon, because the next time it'll be twenty doors and a town we don't reach in time."

"Yes."

Amber looked at her for a long moment, mud-streaked, grey-faced, alive, the relief of being alive and the floor under the relief both on her at once, the way they had been on a man named Coyle, the way they were always both on people who had seen what the world cost up close.

"Then we'd best go and gather what it takes," Amber said, and got up, slowly, and held her muddy hand down, "because I am not letting you walk into a doorway forever without every single one of us standing where we can see

you do it. Not alone in the dark. We learned that one already. We paid full price for it."

Viridia took the hand. She got up, between her three, in the risen sun, in the broken town that was still a town, and she set her face not west toward home this time but east, toward the source, toward the cavern, toward the pool with her name and her mother's name carved side by side in it, toward the doorway a whole year had gone into refusing and one morning into learning she could not refuse.

"All right," she said. "Let's go and find out exactly what it takes."

She knew what it took. It took the whole of her, forever, the way it had taken the whole of Bella. She had known since the cavern. But there was a difference between knowing the size of a thing and walking toward it on your own feet with the people you loved beside you, and the difference was the only freedom she had left, and she meant to spend it.

The doors were closed. The town would stand the day. And somewhere east of all of it, the source ran full, and the void at the rim pulled, and the difference between them widened a shade further while she stood in the mud and decided, at last and for good, to be the thing that held them apart with her body for the rest of a life with almost no end.

She started walking before the others, because it was hers to start.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

What It Will Take

There is a thing that happens to a company on the morning it sets out to do the last large thing, and Viridia had read about it in the dry books and seen it once on a wall above Lest and never until now stood in the middle of it: nobody packs as though it matters.

They packed the way people pack for a week's walk. Amber rolled blankets and argued about the weight of the kettle. Alice counted out the dried things, the hard cheese and the twice-baked bread, and put back the soft apples because soft apples go to mush in a pack and she had found that out the hard way, she said, some other autumn, in some other life. Raizen stood in the doorway of the valley house turning a coil of rope in his hands and not knowing what it was for, because rope was one of the hundred small human things he had not yet met, and Viridia watched him work out its purpose by feel, the way he worked out everything now, and did not tell him, because he liked to arrive at things.

It was a Tuesday. Or it was the day after the one they'd called Tuesday on the train; the days had gone soft at their edges this past week the way they do when a person stops sleeping properly. The point was that it was an ordinary kind of day to be packing on, and that was the mercy of it, and Viridia understood that the ordinariness was not an accident. They were doing it on purpose. They were packing

soft apples and hard apples and arguing about a kettle because if they let themselves pack as though it were the last morning of the world they knew, somebody would have to say so out loud, and nobody wanted to be the one.

So she let the kettle argument run. She rolled her own blanket. And she did the sums in the cold place, quietly, the way she always did them, of everything the balance was going to need, and how little of it they had, and where the rest of it would have to come from.

* * *

The first piece came up the valley road on a borrowed motorcar two days before they left, and it was Drake's, and it was not Drake.

He could not come down off the mountain. He was too old and too large and too known, and a dragon on a valley road in a world this frightened was a thing that started a panic she did not have the warmth to spare for. So he sent the only part of himself that could travel, which was the knowing, folded into a man Viridia had not expected ever to be glad to see.

"He says," said the man from the mountain, who had carried messages for the resistance once and now carried them for a dragon, and seemed to find the second work easier on the conscience, "that you'll want the mark. The death-mark. He says you'll have been thinking it's the spine of the whole thing." He had clearly been made to memorize it word for word and was getting it out before he forgot. "And he says you're wrong, and he wanted to be the one to tell you while there was still time for you to be wrong somewhere cheap."

Amber snorted from across the kitchen. Viridia did not. "Go on."

"He says." The man frowned, finding the next of it. "He says the mark closes a door. He says he's spent six hundred years closing doors and never once made the breath even, and that's the whole lesson, if you've the wit to take it, which he says you have, and then he said a word I won't repeat with the healer in the room." He glanced at Alice, who was peeling something at the table and not pretending she wasn't listening. "He says there's no mark for a pressure. There's a mark for a door and a pressure isn't a door, a pressure is a leaning, and you don't close a leaning, you stand against it. He says you knew that on his rock and you've been hoping the road would let you off it and the road won't."

"I know," Viridia said, because she did, because she had known it on the rock with the wind going through three of them in the dark, and had carried it folded up the way she carried everything she did not want to be true.

"He says one more thing." The man went careful, the way people went careful when they'd been trusted with something heavy. "He says when you stand against it, you're going to want to close it anyway. At the end. When it costs more than you thought, and the mark is right there in your hand, asking nothing, the way it always asks nothing. And he says he's coming as far as a thing his size can come, not to teach you the mark, because you don't need teaching, but to be the one cold-handed thing in the room that knows exactly how it feels to want to close a door you must not close, so that when you want it, you can look at him wanting it too, and not be alone in the wanting."

Nobody said anything for a moment. Alice's knife had stopped.

"That's a long way to come," Viridia said, "to want something with me."

"He says that's the only company worth having, at the end." The man spread his hands, the message delivered, plainly relieved to be done carrying it. "His words, not mine. I'd not presume."

* * *

She understood the death-mark's true use then, sitting at the long table after the man had gone back up the valley, turning a cup she did not drink from.

She had been wrong the whole road. She had thought of the mark as the answer she was refusing, the easy clean monstrous answer, the slope down to the council's crime, and she had spent the better part of a year walking the other way from it. And it was that. But Drake, who did not lie, had sent a man two days down a mountain to tell her the thing under the thing, which was that the mark was not the wrong answer to her question. It was the wrong shape entirely. It answered a question she was not asking. The mark said *here is a door, let me end it*. And there was no door at the edge of the world. There was a leaning. There was a held breath getting harder to hold the fuller the lung. There was a pressure with her name on it, and you do not draw a symbol against a pressure any more than you draw a symbol against a Tuesday, against the tide, against the simple terrible arithmetic of a full thing leaning toward an empty one across a rim no one could see but her.

So she would not be closing anything at the cavern. She had been afraid, in some animal part of her, that the balance would turn out to be the slope after all, dressed up kind; that she would get to the pedestal and find that the only thing strong enough to hold the world was the one mark strong enough to end it, and that she would have refused the council's crime all year only to commit it gently at the last,

alone in the dark with no one to see the shape of what she'd become.

It was not going to be that. She let the cold part lay it out flat, and for once what it laid out was not worse than she'd feared. She was not going to close the rim. She was going to stand in front of it. She was going to be the wall Drake had named, the warmth held even against the cold, the breath that does not fill all the way and does not empty all the way, and the death-mark would have no part in the working except as a thing in Drake's old cold hand and her own young one, wanted and refused, side by side, so that the wanting did not have to be a secret.

The relief of it should have been larger than it was. But relief is a thing you feel when the worst is not coming, and this was only the second-worst, and the worst was still coming, just by its own true name now instead of a borrowed one.

* * *

The second piece she did not send for. It came because of the pendant.

She had worn it under her shirt for a year and barely thought of it, the Heart of the Spear, the small dense bit of watered grey metal the Dangris had given her with the four spears in a clearing a hundred years and one life ago, when she was a frightened first-year learning that the distance between blind and clumsy was the whole of the distance between dead and alive. Kor-toh, they had called themselves, striking their chests twice with closed fists. *We will come again*, Nargash had said, bowing the fractional bow, the one a creature gives a creature it has decided to respect. She had not thought he meant a hundred years. She had not thought he meant anything by it at all; people said *again* the

way they said *goodbye*, to fill the leaving with something warmer than silence.

But the pendant had begun to warm against her breastbone in the night, three nights running, the way a focus warms when a working reaches for it, except she was doing no working, and on the fourth morning they were up where the terraced gardens gave onto the boundary wall, six of them, where she had read the cold rim north all those weeks ago.

They came out of nothing the way they had come out of the pines, the small sounds of the world going quiet around them first, the birds stopping, and then the dry metallic smell of sun-baked stone and old iron on the morning air, and then six tall broad long-limbed shapes standing where no shapes had been, vertical slits for pupils, two slits where a nose should be flaring as they took the scent of her, mouths full of teeth each filed to its own point. Their cores burned the pure spinning white she remembered, light-side only, brilliant, no shadow anywhere in them. A people made whole of one half and never once grieving the other. The only people in the changed world the rebirth had not touched, because there had been nothing in them to mend.

The one at their head was not Nargash. He was younger, and his accent was thicker, and he struck his chest twice before he spoke, and the five behind him struck theirs, and the two low syllables came across the morning like a thing answered. "Kor-toh. The Heart called. We came."

"I didn't call," Viridia said, which was true, and the young Dangris looked at her with his blown-wide pupils and did the thing that on a Dangris was a smile and asked the viewer to be brave about it.

"You did not call with your mouth. The Heart called. There is a pact older than your war and older than the cutting, between the ones who walk and the ones who do

not, and the Heart of the Spear is the calling-stone of it, given to the true-bonded of a dragon, given to you. When the breath at the edge of the world goes hard enough that a stone a hundred miles from any of us warms in the dark, the pact answers. It has always answered. It answered before there were spears to put a heart in." He tilted his head, the cat-slits narrowing. "The dragons feel it from the high places. The deep beasts feel it from the under-places. We feel it through the Heart, because we are the ones who carry no shadow, and a thing with no shadow feels a coming-cold the way a man with no coat feels a coming-winter. We feel it first and worst." He struck his chest once more, slow this time, and it was not a war-sound. "You are walking east to stand against it. We came to stand where we can see you do it."

"It's not a fight," Viridia said. "There's nothing to fight. The cold isn't an enemy. You can't put a spear through a pressure." She heard how it sounded, telling a war-people there was no war in the thing they'd walked a hundred miles to. "I don't have a use for warriors. I'm sorry. I'd not waste what you came to give."

The young Dangris regarded her a long moment, and then he laughed, a short hard sound with all the points of his teeth in it, and the five behind him made the sound too, and it was not unkind, it was the laugh of a thing that has just been told the small wrong reason for a true thing.

"You think the pact is for fighting," he said. "Six hundred years your people have thought that, since the cutting taught you that a creature with a weapon is only for the killing of things. We did not come to fight your cold." He swept one long arm at the five behind him, at the high wall, at the valley and the cold edge of everything past it that only she could read. "We came because the pact is the oldest balance there is. The ones who walk and the ones who do not, the warm

and the warm, holding the line so the holder of the larger line is not holding it alone. That is the whole of it. That is what it was always for. Not the spear. The *standing-with*. The spear was only ever the smallest thing it could be made to do." He bowed, fractional, the bow a creature gives a creature. "Nargash is dead. He fell in your war, in the north, well, with his teeth in something. He sent the young of us before he fell, with the word, that when the Heart warmed we were to go to you and not to ask why and not to bring the spear's question, only the standing. So." He straightened. "We stand."

Amber, who had come up the garden at the sound of the laugh and stopped dead at the sight of them, said into the morning, in the flat practical voice she used when the fear was getting in, "We are going to need a great many more soft apples."

* * *

Here is a thing nobody told her, that she had to learn the way she learned everything, which was on her knees with no warning: that gathering a company to witness a cost is not a kindness you do them. It is a weight you hand them.

She caught it on Alice, the third night, after the Dangris had made their cold dry camp at the wall's foot and the valley house had gone quiet. Alice was at the table again with the lamp turned low, not peeling anything now, just sitting with the banked, settled stillness the year had left her, her palms pressed flat to the table, and Viridia came down for water and found her there and saw, under the calm, the thing the calm was holding down.

"You don't have to come," Viridia said.

"I know."

"You've been through enough. More than enough. You could stay with the wardens. Teach the new ones their dark

half. Be the still point here, where it's needed, instead of out there, where —" She stopped. *Where you'll have to watch.* She did not say it.

Alice turned her hands over on the table, palm up, the way you turn your hands when you've decided to tell the truth and want to see them while you do it. "Do you know what they did to me," she said, "in the place they kept me." It was not a question and Viridia did not answer it. "They made me watch. That was the whole of it, at the end. They knew I was a healer, they knew the one unbearable thing for a healer is a hurt you're held back from mending, so they hurt the others where I could see and they held me where I couldn't reach, and they made me watch, and the watching was the wound, the watching was the thing that changed me, the thing I'm still" — her hand moved, a small economical gesture that took in all of her, the bankedness, the crooked-tooth calm that had not used to be calm but had used to be quick — "still recovering, the word they keep using, recovering, as though I dropped something and have only to pick it back up."

"Alice —"

"Let me finish, I've been a year finding the words." She breathed. "Watching a thing you can't reach is the worst there is. I'll grant you that. I lived it. But watching a thing you *can* reach, that you chose to come and stand beside, that you packed soft apples for and walked a week to be near, that is not the same wound, Vee, it's the opposite of that wound, it's the cure for that wound, and I have been a year sick for the want of it." She put her hands flat again. "I will not be held back this time. I am coming because there is no worse thing than to love someone walking into the dark and be made to wave from the door. I have had the made-to-wave. I'd sooner walk."

Viridia sat down across from her. The lamp was low and the house was quiet and somewhere up the garden six creatures with no shadow in them were keeping a cold dry watch at a wall, and she found she did not have anything to say that was equal to it, so she did the thing you do when nothing is equal to it, which was nothing, which was to sit, which was to let the not-saying be the whole conversation, the way it had been with Amber in the mud. After a while Alice reached across and turned Viridia's water cup a quarter turn on the table, an idle thing, a settling thing, and it was so exactly the thing Amber did with her teacup that Viridia's eyes burned, once, briefly, and she looked down until they stopped, because the grief had been out once already and was not coming out again, and a burning that you look down until it passes is not the same as crying and she had decided a long time ago that it didn't count.

* * *

The cavern would be reached the way it was always reached, by seam, by meaning it. She did not need a map. The source knew where she was and she knew where the source was, the way two ends of a held rope know each other; she had only to open a seam and step through and she would be in the low rough older-than-old chamber with the unworked walls and the still dry air that tasted of nothing but stone, and the pedestal, and in its hollowed top the pool, which was no kind of water, which shone of its own accord, that was the deep well her own furnace had only ever borrowed from. She had been there twice. Once a clever tired first-year banking her core to an ember. Once a girl with her whole self loose and entire, no cold part walled off, leaning over the glow while the split symbol rose to the surface and the pool divided light from dark and both halves of her ached toward it at once.

She would go a third time as the only thing the room had ever truly waited for, and this time she would not take her hand out again. Not really. Not in the way that mattered. She understood that now in her body and not only in her arithmetic, the way she had understood it for one half-second in the mud over Amber: that the doorway was not a thing she would do, it was a thing she would *be*, with her name on it, with her mother's name carved beside hers in a place she had seen once and would see again and would not, she thought, ever leave in the way a person leaves a place.

She tried to say this to Raizen on the last night, and could not, and did not have to, because the bond said it for her, the way it had said the unsayable thing in the mud. He was at the far end of it the way he was always at the far end of it now, braced, rooted, the still line he had set himself to be, the warmth she was tied to that made a person in a wall harder to even than a person alone. He had been at the far braced end of it once before while she put her hand in the pool, lit like a struck wire all the way to wherever the bond reached, and he would be there again, and that was the whole of what he could do and it was everything.

"I'll feel it," he said, in the dark, not as a comfort, because he had learned from Drake not to comfort her with lies. "When you do it. Whatever it is. I'll feel it down the bond the way I felt the rebirth. It nearly took me apart, the rebirth, from a hundred strides off, and that was the small one." He was quiet. "This is the large one."

"Yes."

"Tell me the cost." He said it plainly, the one manner he had ever learned for the things that frightened him. "Out loud. Not down the bond where it's already half-said and you don't have to mean it. With your mouth. I want it in the room with us so it's not a thing you carried alone."

So she said it, in the dark, with her mouth, the way he asked, because he had carried the wanting-to-close-a-door with Drake and the standing-with from the Dangris and the made-to-wave from Alice, and he was owed the same plainness he gave.

"I become the throttle," she said. "Not for an hour. Not for a town. For good. I stand in the doorway between the full thing and the empty thing and I hold the breath even, the whole of it, all the world's warmth leaned against all the world's cold, and I let the source run up through me and out level forever, so the pull comes to one place instead of a hundred towns, and the one place is me." She found his hand in the dark, the human hand, the one that had not known what rope was for. "And I'll feel it. All of it. Every core that lights and every core that goes out. Every birth, Raizen. Every death. Not the way I feel them now, in flickers, with the sight coming back a piece at a time. All of them, all the time, for the whole of a life that hardly ends, because I'm tied to you and you hardly end either. I will never again be only myself. There won't be a morning of the rest of my life where I wake up and it's just me in the room. It'll be me and the whole world, every joy and every grief of it, leaning on me through a doorway, until the world's last day or mine, and the True-Bond means mine is a very long way off."

He did not say *you don't have to*. He had got past that, weeks ago, on the rock with Drake. He did not say *it isn't fair*, because fair was a child's word and they had both put it down. He held the hand she'd found, and after a while he said the one thing that was both true and bearable, which was the thing the bond was for.

"Then you won't be only yourself," he said. "But you won't be by yourself either. Those are different. I'll be at the far end of it for the whole of the very long way off. That's what the bond is. You felt the rebirth take me apart at a hundred

strides and you saw me put back together, and I'll come apart and go back together every day of the holding if I have to, because I am the second warmth, and a person in a wall is harder to even than a person alone, and you taught me that, in the mud, the day Amber nearly went." His thumb moved over her knuckles, learning them, the way he learned everything. "You will not stand in that doorway by yourself. I'll be the doorpost. For as long as it takes. Which is forever. Which I happen to have."

* * *

They left on the ordinary kind of day, with the soft apples left behind and the hard ones packed and the kettle, after all, brought, because Amber won that argument the way she won all the arguments that didn't matter, by simply putting the thing in the pack while everyone else was talking.

They went out the valley road at first light, the six of them and the six Dangris, twelve in all walking east where the dark was not lifting the way dark lifts. Drake would meet them where the road gave out at the foot of the cold country, as far as a thing his size could come, the one cold-handed witness who knew exactly how it felt to want to close a door he must not close. Alice walked with her changed long calm and would not be waving from any door. Amber walked with her kettle and her arithmetic done in advance, the answer always the same, the answer always *not them, not while she could help it*. The Dangris walked the way they did everything, almost soundlessly, six tall shadowless shapes who had come a hundred miles because a stone warmed in the dark and an old pact said *stand*, and did not ask why, and did not bring the spear's question.

And Raizen walked at Viridia's left hand with the bond drawn warm and rooted at her back, a man new to feet and cold and buttons and rope, who would be the far braced end

of a doorway for the whole of a life with almost no end, because that was the bargain he had signed when he hatched in her hands, and which he had read, because he was the one of them who could.

She walked at the front, because it was hers to walk at the front. The cold part did the last of its sums. They had Drake's witness and his cold-handed knowing-of-the-wanting; they had the Dangris and the standing-with of an old balance; they had Alice's still point and Amber's truth and Raizen's rooted line; they had the cavern, and the pedestal, and the pool with two names in it; they had everything the balance needed except the only thing it had ever truly needed, which was a girl willing to be a doorway for the rest of a span that hardly ended, and that they had too, walking at the front, in the risen sun, on her own two feet.

She had done the largest thing once before alone in the dark, with her hand in a pool and no one to see the shape of what she became, and it had taken her a year and two books to learn what that cost, learning that a thing done alone in the dark is a thing the people who love you can never quite forgive you for, not because they blame you but because you robbed them of the standing-with, the oldest balance there is. She would not rob them twice. She had learned that one. She had paid full price for it.

So when the road gave out and the cold country began and Drake's great banked shape came down out of the grey to meet them at the edge of it, Viridia stopped, and turned, and looked at the whole gathered company of them, the warm and the warm and the shadowless and the cold-handed and the rooted, every one of them having walked east on their own feet to stand where they could see, and she found that the thing in her chest was not dread, or not only dread, but its close companion, the warmth that had always held up the dark stretches of her life: that she

was, for once, exactly where she had decided to be, with exactly the people she had chosen, going to do the hardest right thing on purpose and in the open.

"All right," she said. "Not in the dark this time. Not alone. You all see this." She looked at each of them, the cold part counting them, the warm part loving them, both at once, the whole merged one core of her leaning east. "You see what it takes. That's the price of you coming, and I'm charging it, because I'm done paying the other price."

Amber set the kettle down in the road, deliberately, the way you set a thing down when you mean to be free-handed for what comes next. "We see it," she said.

"We see it," said Alice.

The Dangris struck their chests, twice, the standing-sound, not the war-sound. Drake's banked eye held her, cold-handed, knowing the wanting. And at her left hand Raizen took her right one, the human grip, sure now, no wobble in it, and said it down the bond and out loud at the same time, the only way it counted with him: "We see it. Go on, then. We're the doorpost. Walk."

She turned east, toward the cold edge of everything, toward the seam that would open onto the low rough chamber and the pedestal and the pool with her name and her mother's name carved side by side in it, and she opened the seam, and the still dry stone-smelling air of the oldest place in the world breathed out of it into the morning, and she stepped toward it on her own two feet, with the whole of them behind her where she could feel them, where she could be seen.

It was the most expensive thing she would ever do. She walked toward it the way you walk toward a thing you have chosen, which is slowly, and without flinching, and not alone.

The doorway was waiting. It had always been waiting. This time the dark would have witnesses, and that, she had learned, was the whole of the difference between a sacrifice and a crime, and the only freedom she had left, and she meant to spend it in front of everyone she loved.

She stepped through.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Approach

The seam did not open onto the cavern. She had half expected it would, the way the last large door in a story is the door you mean, but the source did not let you in by the front. It let you in by the country above it, and the country above it was the worst place she had ever stood, and she had stood in a burning school.

She came through onto a slope of black stone that no weather had ever softened, and the cold met her the way a hand meets you in the dark, not a wind, there was no wind, only the fact of the cold sitting on the land the way water sits in a bowl. Above her the sky was the colour of a bruise gone old. Below her, a long stone tumble down, the slope ran into a fold in the rock where two faces of the mountain leaned almost together, and in the seam of that fold there was a darkness that was not shadow, a mouth in the world, low and rough, and she knew it the way you know your own name said in a strange room. The cavern. The source's one door into the world. She had reached it twice before, both times from inside, both times by meaning it. She had never seen the outside of it, and now that she had, she understood why the source kept its back to the world: a thing the world is borrowed from should not have a front anyone can walk up to.

They came through behind her one at a time, and the slope took them, and nobody spoke for a moment, because there was nothing in any of them that had a word for the cold.

Then Amber said, "Right," in the flat voice, and shrugged the pack higher on her shoulder, and that was the company finding its feet.

* * *

The cold leaned. She read it the moment she stood still enough to, the way you feel a floor tilt under you a degree at a time once you stop walking and pay attention to your own weight: the whole even patient steepening pull of the world's warmth drawing toward the warmth she had become, and here, this near the source, the lean was not a faint thing felt across a country. Here it was a current you could nearly lose your footing in. The rim was close. The cold edge of everything was close. And the source at the bottom of the fold was the full thing the empty thing leaned toward, and she was the door between them whether she had drawn it or not, and she felt, standing on the black slope, the dreadful rightness of having walked all this way, because there was no other place in the world the working could be done. You cannot hold a breath even from across the room. You have to stand in the throat.

"How far," Raizen said. He was at her left, where he always was now, and the bond ran warm and rooted off the back of her like a line paid out to a post. His ordinary dark eyes were narrowed against a glare that was not light, the glare a too-empty place puts on a person who can feel it.

"Down the slope. Into the fold. The mouth's lower than it looks." She did not say the other thing she read, which was that they were not alone on the slope.

She had felt the wrong warmth before she saw it. Down and to the right, where a shoulder of black rock made a kind of yard before the cavern mouth, there was a smudge of human warmth that did not belong to her company, a single core, banked low and clever and frightened, and around it, drawn to it the way the cold drew to her but smaller, meaner, faster, three thin places in the world's cloth where the cold was getting through.

She knew the core. She had stood three feet from it in a low stone room at the bottom of a bald valley and watched a question light at the back of its tired eyes.

"Marick's here," she said.

Amber's head came round. "The chalk man. He's *here*?"

"He worked it out." She was already moving, down the slope, careful on the loose black stone, the cold part laying it flat as she went, the way it laid everything. "What I was listening to. He worked out there was a large thing and that the large thing was at the source, and he's a man who has spent forty years wanting to stand next to the one large thing, and now he can feel where it is the same as I can, because he holds both halves too." She heard her own breath in the cold. "He came to see it. He came to *help*. God help us. He came to help."

* * *

He had drawn on the rock.

She saw it as the slope let her down into the yard, the made marks pale on the black stone in a hand she knew now, careful, clever, a lifetime of wanting in the steadiness of the lines. Marick was on his knees over the largest of them with a stub of chalk worn nearly to nothing in his fingers, and he had aged a fortnight into a year since the valley, his coat grey with stone dust, his spectacles gone or broken, his eyes red-rimmed and bright and entirely sure. And around

him, at the three corners of his working, the cold was coming through. Not big. Each tear no longer than a hand. But fast, the lamp-coloured nothing of the slope going thin at the edges of them, the rock losing its substance the way a word loses its meaning the more you say it, and Viridia felt each small drinking mouth and felt how new they were and how they were widening, and understood that Marick had not come to help her hold the breath even.

He had come to do his own working over the source. The fourteenth, or worse than the fourteenth. He had come to the one place where both halves could be held against the largest thing, and he had begun to open it, because a man who has spent his whole small life made small does not, when he finally reaches the great door, knock.

"Marick." She kept her voice plain. "Stop. Take your hand off it."

He looked up, and his face went to the thing she had dreaded in the valley and dreaded worse now: it was glad to see her. "You came," he said. "I knew you'd come. I worked it out, you see, I worked out what you're listening to, and I followed it, I followed the lean, the way you must have, it points like a needle once you know it's there, and it points *here*, and I thought —" His chalk hand trembled, not with fear. "I thought, if she's the one who can feel it, then between us, both of us holding both halves, we could —"

"There is no working that helps," she said. "Marick. Listen to me with the clever part. There is no door to draw at the source. The source isn't a problem you open. The thing that's wrong is a pressure, and you do not draw a symbol against a pressure, you stand against it, and every line you put on this rock is another place for the cold to come through, and you can feel that, I know you can, you can feel them widening under your own hands right now."

And the terrible thing, the thing she would carry, was that he could. She watched him feel them. She watched the clever part of him register the three small drinking mouths at the corners of his working and do the sum and arrive at the same answer she had arrived at in his valley, that the door does not close, that the warning written in the worn-away hand had been true, that he had been right about the men who buried things and wrong about the one thing it mattered to be right about. She watched a forty-year wanting meet the bottom of itself in a single breath, the way it had met the bottom of itself once before when she unmade his door without trying. And she watched him decide, with the cold already coming up through his own marks and the recognition plain on his ruined clever face, not to take his hand away.

"No," he said. Quietly. Not aggrieved now. Almost gentle. "No, I don't think I'll stop. You'll do your large thing, and it will be right, and you'll be the one who held the world, and I'll be the man in the valley who picked up the chalk. I have been the man in the valley my whole life." His hand pressed flatter to the rock. "Let me be the one who reached the door, just once. Just the once. You can't know what it is to be a candle your whole life and feel the fire come into you at forty and be told to put it down."

"It isn't fire," she said. "It's a leak. Marick —"

The corner of his working tore.

* * *

It did not tear like the small ones. It tore the way the made cut at the valley had been a made thing, a clean line where a hand had been, except this hand had drawn it at the throat of the world where the lean was a current, and the cold came through it not as a draught but as a tide, and the black rock at the working's edge stopped being rock and became the

absence of rock, the lamp-light and the bruise-dark sky and the very substance of the slope drawing in along the new margin and not coming back.

Drake came down the slope behind her like a wall falling the right way.

He had stayed up at the seam, too large and too known, the cold-handed witness; but a dragon does not need to be small to close a door, and Viridia heard him before she felt the heat of him, the deep stone-grinding intake of a thing the size of a barn drawing breath, and then the death-mark was on the air. Not chalk. Drake did not need chalk. Six hundred years of closing doors, and he wrote the mark the way an old man signs his name, with the death-flame itself, the cold black-edged fire that asked nothing and closed anything, and he laid it across the largest tear, Marick's tear, the one drinking the slope, and the tear shut. It shut clean. It shut the way the death-mark always shut, easy, total, asking nothing, and Viridia felt the eerie ease of it go through her own teeth even from here, the ease Drake had crossed a continent to stand beside her in the wanting of, because that ease was the whole danger, because a thing that closes that cleanly makes you want to close everything.

But the death-mark closes a door. It does not close a pressure. And it does not, it cannot, unmake a man who has already set his hand inside the door he opened.

She would not, afterward, be able to say exactly what she saw, and she came to understand that this was a mercy the eye does for you, the way it had done it for her once in a burning corridor. She saw Marick's working tear at its last corner. She saw the cold take the chalk and then the chalk hand and then the steadiness in his ruined clever face turn, at the very end, not to terror but to something nearer wonder, the wonder of a man who reached the door after all. She saw him lean toward the cold the way the whole world

leaned toward her, the small leaning toward the empty, and she heard him say something that was not quite a word.

And then Drake's death-flame closed the last door, because a door has to be closed whatever is still in it, and the slope was black rock again, whole, asking nothing, and there was no working on it, and there was no man.

The chalk stub lay on the stone where it had fallen, worn to nothing.

Viridia did not look away from it. She had settled it in herself years back that you owed the dead the not-looking-away, even the culpable ones, even the ones who would have torn the world to stand next to its largest thing. The cold part counted it: one core gone out, a wrong death, drained, not natural, the kind she had felt across a country a year ago and not been able to read. She had read this one whole, three feet away, with her sight returned. There was no comfort in the reading. There was only the smaller mercy that he had, at the very last, reached the thing he wanted, and the larger truth that it had taken him into itself, and that those were the same fact.

"That," said Amber, very low, beside her, not flat now, "is the worst thing I have ever seen, and I was at the school."

* * *

Fen was alive.

He was pressed flat against the black rock at the edge of the yard where Marick's working had not reached, a slight ink-stained boy with his arms over his head and his whole body gone to the shape of a creature waiting to be hit, and he was alive, and Viridia got to him before she had decided to, on her knees on the cold stone, her hand on his shoulder, hard, the way you grip a thing to tell it that it is still here.

"You're all right. Fen. Look at me. You're all right."

He came up out of his arms by degrees. His face was grey. He looked at the place on the slope where Marick had been and where now there was only black rock and a worn chalk stub, and he looked at it the way Alice had once described being made to watch, the look of someone who had seen a thing they could not put back, and his mouth worked and nothing came out so he just knelt there. Then he said, in a voice scraped down to almost nothing, "I told him not to. The whole way west. I told him at every fire. I said the warning was true, I said you'd unmade his door in a breath, I said whatever you were doing here you didn't need a second person drawing on the rock. He said." Fen swallowed. "He said I didn't understand what it was to want a thing your whole life. And he was right. I don't. I'm seventeen. I don't want anything that much yet. I was just." His ink-stained hand opened and closed on nothing. "I was just the one who carried the bag."

"You followed a dangerous man to the worst place in the world," Viridia said, "and you told him the truth at every fire, and you carried the bag. That's not nothing, Fen. That's the opposite of nothing." She thought of him in the doorway at the valley, the boy who had weighed the man inside against the strangers and come down, fractionally, on the side of the strangers. She had filed that then. She was glad past saying now, exactly as the filing had promised she would be, that she had seen it. "You're going to live through today. Do you hear me? Whatever happens down in that fold, you stay up here on the whole rock, with the kettle, and you live through it, because somebody has to carry out of here the true account of what was done, and I am electing you, because you're the one who tells it true."

It was not, she knew, a thing a person should say to a boy on a cold slope over a hole in the world. But it was true, and she had learned from Drake to give people the true thing

plainly, and she watched it reach Fen and give him something to be, which was all anyone could be given on a slope like this one.

* * *

The mouth of the cavern was lower than it had looked, and the closer she came to it the more the company changed shape around her, without anyone deciding it, the way iron filings take an order from a magnet they cannot see.

The Dangris went to the seam of the fold first. There were six of them, tall and shadowless and almost soundless on the black stone, their cores burning the pure spinning white of a people with no dark half to grieve, and where the cold came thinnest into the world, at the lipped margin of the fold where the rock leaned almost together, they took up a standing the way she had seen them take a clearing once a hundred years and one life ago. Not a fighting line. There was nothing to fight. The young one who had come for Nargash struck his chest, twice, the standing-sound, and the five struck theirs, and Viridia understood what they were for at last, not in her arithmetic but in her chest: a thing with no shadow in it stood at the place where the shadow leaned through, and by standing there, whole and brilliant and unafraid of a cold that could find no purchase in a thing that had never been cut, they made the margin a place the cold had to come past witnesses. They could not close the rim. They could stand in front of it shadowless, so the one who held the breath did not hold it among strangers. The standing-with. The oldest balance there is.

Drake settled across the slope above the fold, banked and enormous, the cold-handed one, and she felt rather than saw him take up the work he had named down a mountain: not to teach her the mark, but to be the one cold-handed thing in the room that knew exactly how it felt to want to

close a door you must not close. The small tears the cold kept opening on the slope, the worn places, the leaks, he closed as they came, one death-mark and then another, easy, total, asking nothing. Each time he closed one she felt the ease of it pull at her like a tide pulling at a swimmer. *Close it, close it all, the mark is right there and it asks nothing.* And each time she looked up the slope at the great banked shape closing doors and wanting, exactly as she wanted, not to have to stand against the larger thing, and was not alone in the wanting, and so did not slip. That was the whole of what he had come to do, and it was everything.

Amber stopped at the cavern mouth and would not go further, and that too was right. "I'm no use in there," she said, and her jaw was set the way it set when she was making herself say the true small thing instead of the brave large one. "I'm no use anywhere magic happens, never have been. So I'll be use here." She set the pack down. She got the kettle out of it, the kettle she had won the argument over, and she set it on the black rock at the cavern mouth in the cold with no fire under it and no water in it, the most useless object in the worst place in the world, and Viridia understood that Amber was doing the only thing Amber knew how to do against a horror, which was to put an ordinary object down in the middle of it and dare it to mean nothing. "Somebody comes up that slope that shouldn't," Amber said, "human or otherwise, I'll make such a noise. That's my working. I make a noise and you all come running." She looked at Viridia, and the fear was right there in her face, undisguised, the way it had been in the mud, and she let it show. "Go and do the thing. I'll mind the door. I'm good at minding doors. It's the only kind of standing-with I've got."

"It's the best kind," Viridia said, and meant it, and kept the rest behind her teeth, which was that Amber had been minding her door for two books and that there was nobody

alive she would rather have at her back doing the useless brave thing with a cold kettle.

* * *

That left Alice, and Raizen, and the mouth of the cavern, and the long rough dark of it going down into the place the world was borrowed from.

"You said you'd not be held back," Viridia said to Alice, at the threshold, in the still dry stone-smelling air that breathed out of the dark, the air she knew, the air that tasted of nothing but the deep places that had never had weather. "And I'm not going to hold you. But I'll tell you what's down there, because you're a healer, and a healer should choose with her eyes open. It's the source. The pool. And I'm going to put my hand in it and not take it out again, not in the way that matters, and there'll be nothing for your hands to do, Alice. Nothing to mend. That's the cruelty of it for you, of all people. You'll have walked a week and stood at the worst door in the world to watch a thing you can't reach."

Alice looked at her with the changed long calm, the banked warmth, the one crooked tooth showing for half a second as her mouth moved. "You've got it the wrong way round," she said. "I told you in the valley house and you weren't listening. The wound is watching a thing you *can't* reach. This," and her hand took in the dark, the cold, the whole of what was coming, "this is watching a thing I *chose* to come and stand beside. I packed for it. I walked to it. There's no hand for me down there, you're right, and I don't care, because the standing isn't for my hands. It's for yours. So that when you've got the whole world leaning on you through that doorway and you can feel every grief there is, you'll know, down whatever's left of the bottom of you, that one of the griefs in the world is a healer who loves you, standing as close as she's allowed, having chosen it." She put her steady

healer's hand flat on Viridia's breastbone, over the place the Heart of the Spear hung, over the dark-blue stone, over the merged one core leaning toward the dark below. "I am not waving from any door. I'll be the closest grief you can feel. That's my use. Now go."

And the burning came up behind Viridia's eyes, once, the way it did, and she looked down into the dark until it passed, because the dark was a good place to look when your eyes burned and you had settled it with yourself, years since, that a burning you looked down until it stopped did not count, and no one saw, because they were all, every one of them, looking at the same dark she was.

* * *

She went down into the cavern the last little way alone, with Raizen at the far braced end of the bond behind her on the threshold where the stone began, because the bond did not need him beside her, it only needed him rooted, and rooted he was, braced there, the line set to be a line. She felt him take up the bracing the way he had braced for the rebirth, the way he had told her in the dark he would come apart and go back together every day of the holding if he had to, and she carried that down with her into the dark, the knowing that she would not stand in the doorway by herself even if she stood in it alone.

The cavern took her the way it had taken her twice before.

It was low and rough and older than old, the walls unworked stone, the air still and dry and tasting of nothing but stone, of the deep places of the world that had never had weather and never would. There was no sound. Not the drip of water, not the stir of air, not the cold leaning above on the slope, not Amber's cold kettle, not the Dangris's standing, not Drake closing his easy doors. The silence had a weight to

it, the silence of a room that had been waiting, and it had waited for her once as a clever tired first-year banking her core to an ember, and once as a girl with her whole self loose and entire and her cold part broken on a stone two days behind her, and it had her now a third time, and the room did not care which girl she was. It only held its pool of pale even light and waited with all the patience of a thing the world is borrowed from.

Ahead, the stone pedestal, and the light coming from its hollowed top, the only light in the place.

She crossed the unworked floor.

In the pedestal's hollowed top lay the pool, and the light came from the pool itself, a clean pale glow with no source above it or below it, only the liquid shining of its own accord, and it was not water; she had learned that in the first instant of touching it once and would never need telling twice. This was magic itself. The source. The deep well her own furnace had only ever been a borrowing from, the thing every focus and glyph and core in the world was only a borrowing of, and the whole even tide of the world's cold drew toward it through her, because she was the door it had to come past now, and the lean of it was a current, and she was the throat.

She leaned over the pool, and the light side of her stirred and the dark side of her stirred, both at once, the whole merged one core of her leaning toward the glow, and the pool felt her, and as it felt her the split symbol rose to its pale surface, the mark of the two halves of the gift that her lost focus had worn and her mother's burned book had worn, and where it touched the surface the pool divided, light to one side and dark to the other, and both sides of her ached toward it at once.

And there, where the dark half deepened toward the place the warmth thinned toward and did not reach, where the source ran down into its own deep memory, two names

lay just under the surface side by side, cut into nothing, warm in the way a letter is warm that has your name on it: her own, and her mother's, the warm familiar stillness at the far end of the line that ran not outward into the world but down. The Bella thread. It brushed her the way it had brushed her at the rebirth, warmer than the rest, pointed, hers, and it said, the way it always said, *follow me down, there is an answer down here*, and she did not follow it, because that lesson was hers too now, that the answer down there cost more than the world could spare of her, and that a doorway has to be held by someone who keeps her edges, and she meant to keep hers, this time, for the whole of the very long way off.

Above her, far up the dark, the company held the line: a boy on the whole rock with a chalk stub he would carry out and a true account he would tell; a woman with a cold useless kettle minding the worst door in the world; a dragon closing easy doors and wanting, exactly as she wanted, not to have to do the hard thing; six shadowless people standing where the shadow leaned through; a healer who would be the closest grief she could feel, having chosen it; and at the threshold where the stone began, a man new to feet and cold and rope and buttons, braced at the far end of the line, who had read the bargain because he was the one who could and signed it anyway and was at the far braced end of it now, rooted, the steady warmth, so that she would not be only herself and would not be by herself either, because those were different, and he had taught her the difference back to her in the dark.

She was witnessed. That was the whole of the difference between a sacrifice and a crime, and the only freedom she had left, and she had spent it, all of it, in front of everyone she loved, on purpose and in the open, on her own two feet.

There was nothing left to do but the thing itself.

Viridia stood over the pool with her two names in it and the whole leaning weight of the world drawing toward the warmth she had become, and she did the last of the cold part's sums, and the sum came back the same as it had come back for a year and a country and two books: there was no hand at the rim to stop, there had only ever been hers, and a hand that makes the weight is the only hand that can hold it even.

She set her hand to the source.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Weight, Taken Up

She set her hand to the source, and the source, which had no front and no manners and no notion of being ready, took it.

Not the way it had taken her at the rebirth. That she had been braced for, the dissolving, the world coming up her arm in a flood, and she had braced for it again on the long way down through the dark, setting her feet against a wave that had already knocked her down once. But the source did not pour into her this time and it did not let her pour into it. It leaned. The whole even patient weight she had felt on the black slope, the lean of the world's cold toward the warmth she had become, came down the channel of her arm and through her hand into the pool and met the pool leaning back, the source full and rising toward the empty place it had been rising toward for a year, and she was the throat between them, and the lean was not a wave. It was a pressure. It was the whole of two large things pushing against each other through the narrow door of her, and the door was her, and she had perhaps half a breath to understand that there was no flood to ride and no wound to close and nothing to do but hold the doorway open at exactly the width it should be while two oceans tried to come through it at once.

* * *

Far up the dark, on the whole rock, a boy held a chalk stub and did not breathe.

* * *

The overflow was the first thing, and it nearly took her before she had her feet.

She had thought, doing the cold part's sums on the slope, that she understood it: the rebirth had run the world's lung full, and a full lung leans harder on the empty place beside it, and the source had been rising ever since, and what was wrong was a pressure. The measuring of it had taken her a country west and back. She had named it a differential, a word that sat in the mouth like a coin, and used the word to teach Drake what she could feel and could not say. The word had been true and the word had been nothing. The thing itself came up her arm now not as a measurement but as a tide with no shore, the source's risen fullness pushing up through her hand toward the rim because she was the only open place left for it to go, more of it than a hand could hold, more of it than a girl could hold, the whole borrowed deep of the world wanting up and out and through her into the empty place that leaned, and if she did nothing it would pour. It would pour the way Marick's tear had poured, except that this was not a hand-sized cut in a slope. This was the door itself, opened wide, and through a door opened wide the whole risen source would empty itself into the cold the way a struck artery empties, and the world would not be unmade by the cold coming in. The world would be unmade by the warmth going out. By her own gift. By the very fullness she had made.

She felt it start. She felt the source surge up her arm to spend itself through the open door of her, glad, the way water is glad of a low place, and she felt how easy it would be to let it, how the easiness was the danger here too, the same

easiness Drake's mark had, the same easiness as letting her own edges go in the flood a year ago: just open. Just let the full thing find the empty thing. Let the lean resolve itself the way leans want to, all at once, and be done.

She did not open the door wider. She narrowed it.

* * *

This is the thing she did, and it was hers, and her hand did it, and she would never be able to tell anyone the half of it but she could always tell them this much: she did not let go and she did not pour. She took the surge of the risen source coming up through her, the whole leaning weight of the world's full warmth wanting out, and instead of opening to it she set herself across it, palm flat to the pool, her own merged core thrown across the doorway like a body across a sill, and she held the door to the width it should be. Not shut. A shut door was the council's crime, the throttling, the choosing-who-gets-to-be-in-the-world, and she had crossed a continent swearing she would not commit it again in a new coat. Not open, either, because open was the artery, the world bleeding warmth into the cold. She held it at the width a door should be, the width that let the source be full without spending itself empty, the width that let the world lean toward the cold the way a thing leans toward its own counterpart and not the way a thing falls into its own grave.

It was like holding a door in a gale with your whole body when the gale wants it open and your own hands are tired, except the gale was the size of the world and the door was the only door there was and her body was her self, the merged one core of her, light and dark both, thrown flat against the leaning weight. The source pushed. She held. The source pushed harder, finding the give in her the way water finds the give in a bank, every place she was tired, every place she was afraid, every place a year of half-sight

and a drained miller's wife and a man going gladly into the cold had worn her thin, and at each of those places the door tried to gape and the warmth tried to pour and she set herself across it again, and again, narrowing where it widened, by main force, by the cold part's flat refusal and the warm part's whole ache, both of her thrown across the one sill, holding the world to the width it could survive.

* * *

She felt her edges start to go.

Not the way they had gone at the rebirth, washed out gently into the grief of strangers. This was rougher and faster and it came from holding, not from drowning: the pressure she set herself across was so much larger than a self that the self began to spread under it, to thin, to lose the line where Viridia stopped and the door began, until she could no longer be sure whether she was the girl holding the door or the door itself, whether there was a girl at all or only a narrowed place in the world where the warmth was kept from pouring, and the terror of it was the same terror, exactly the same, how simple it would be to stop being a girl and become only the throttle, to thin all the way out into the function and let the function hold the door because the function could not be tired or afraid, and she felt herself going that way, spreading, thinning, the door holding and the girl dissolving into the holding of it.

One line did not push.

The bond. She found it the way she had found it once before in a worse flood, the single line in all the leaning weight that wanted nothing from her, that did not surge or thin or gape, that only held, rooted, fixed, set to be a line. Raizen at the far braced end of it, up the dark on the threshold where the stone began, coming apart and going back together as he had warned her in the dark he would,

every breath of the holding, paying out the line and never the man. She could feel him doing it. She could feel the cost of it on his end, the new-to-feet, new-to-cold, new-to-rope-and-buttons man bracing his whole strange human self against a weight that was meant for a girl with her hand in the world, taking the recoil of it up the line so that some part of it never reached her, coming apart at the seams of his own newly ordinary body and going back together and coming apart again, and not once, not for the length of a breath, letting the line go slack.

She set herself against it.

Hand over hand, the way you climb a rope out of deep water, the way she had climbed this same rope a year ago in a sealed dark. She found the place where the line ran into her and she gripped it, not with a hand, there was no hand to spare, with the part of her that was still a girl and not yet only a function, and she pulled herself back along it toward the rooted end, back toward the edges of herself, back from the thinning-out into the throttle. The door did not get easier to hold because she had something to hold it with. The pressure pushed exactly as hard. But she stopped spreading. She found the line where Viridia stopped and the world began, and she held it on the bond the way she held the door on her palm, two holdings at once, the world on one side of her and the man on the other, and between them the narrowed place that was her and was a door and was, now, going to stay both.

* * *

At the cavern mouth, in the cold, a woman set her hand flat on a kettle that had no fire under it and no water in it, and held it there, as if the most useless object in the world could be made to mean something by a palm that would not lift off it.

* * *

She held the door. The door held. And in the holding, somewhere past the narrowed place, at the far leaning edge of everything, she came up against the empty thing itself, and she understood for the first time what it was, and what it was not, and what she had been about to do wrong.

She had come down meaning, in the bottom of her, to seal it. She knew that now, holding the door with her whole self spread thin across the sill. Under the careful words about balance and the lessons about the council's crime, under all of it, there had been a girl who wanted, the way Drake wanted, the way Marick had wanted, to find the empty place and close it, to make the cold stop leaning, to mark a door across the whole vast absence and be done with the holding forever. The Death-mark was in her if she reached for it. Drake had crossed a continent to stand in the room of her wanting it. And the want was right there, the eerie easy want, *close it, close the empty place, make the lean stop, you'll never have to hold the door again.*

But the empty place was not a door. She knew it in the body the way she had known at the rebirth that the wound was one cut and not a million. The empty place at the leaning edge of everything was not a thing that had been opened, the way Marick's tear had been opened, a made cut with a hand behind it that you could close by unmaking the hand. There was no hand behind it. There was no edge to mark. It simply was, the way the source was, an absence as old and as large and as patient as the deep it leaned toward, and it was not waiting to ruin anything and it was not hungry, whatever it had felt like across a country, whatever it had felt like to a drained miller's wife. It was the empty that a fullness needs in order to be a fullness at all. It was the cold that a warmth is the warmth of. It was the other half of

the one breath, the out to the source's in. And standing there with her hand in the full thing and her self spread across the door between the full thing and the empty thing, she understood it, all at once and out of the holding the way the hardest knowing always came: that you cannot seal one half of a breath without killing the breath, that an absence you close is just a presence with nowhere to lean. The council had not only throttled the dark half of the gift six hundred years ago. They had been afraid of exactly this, the necessary empty, the counterpart, and had spent six centuries trying to make a world with only the in-breath in it. The rebirth had run the in-breath full at last, and now the out-breath leaned toward it because that is what an out-breath does, and the answer was not to stop the leaning.

The answer was to let it lean, and hold the door at the width that let it.

She stopped reaching for the mark.

* * *

She did the hardest thing, then, which was nothing.

She did not seal the empty place. She held the door and she let the void lean against it and she left it unclosed, and that was harder than closing it would have been, because closing it was a single eerie easy stroke and not-closing it was forever. She let the cold be the cold. She let it lean toward the warmth she had become the way it had leaned all year, the way it would lean for the whole very long span of her, and instead of trying to make the lean stop she set the door to the width that let the lean be only a lean and never a pour. She acknowledged it. There is no better word for the thing her self did, spread across the sill with the source full on one side and the absence patient on the other; she turned the part of her that was still a girl toward the empty place and did not flinch from it and did not name it and did not

seal it, and she let it be what it was, the necessary counterpart, neither the thing that ate the world nor the thing that saved it, only the other half of the one breath she was now the throat of, and she held the door open the exact right amount so that the world could go on breathing in and out across her for as long as she could hold it.

And the lean, met that way, held by a door at the right width instead of a body trying to slam it, eased. Not gone. It would never be gone. But it stopped being the thing that knocks a girl down. It became the thing she carried, the steady even patient weight of two oceans leaning against each other through the door of her, and she stood in it, narrowed and spread and held on a line at the far end of which a man came apart and went back together, and she felt the world, for the first time in a year, stop tearing.

* * *

The Dangris felt it first, at the seam of the fold, the six of them shadowless and brilliant at the place where the cold leaned thinnest into the world, and the young one who had come for Nargash struck his chest, once, and the five struck theirs, the standing-sound, because a thing with no shadow in it can feel when the shadow has stopped leaning the wrong way and started leaning the right way, and it stood and it sounded and it was witnessing the oldest balance there is come back into a world that had spent six hundred years afraid of it.

* * *

She held it, and it held.

That was the thing she had refused herself the hoping of, on the slope, doing her sums, because hope was a thing you spent and she had not had any to spare: that the working

could not only be begun but held, that the door once narrowed to the right width would stay narrowed, that the world once set leaning the right way would go on leaning the right way without her standing across the sill of it with her whole spread-thin self forever. She held the door at the width it should be, and the source ran full without pouring, and the void leaned without tearing, and the world breathed in and out across the throat of her, and slowly, the way a fevered thing comes off the worst of its fever, the way a current that has been dragging at a swimmer slackens by a degree and then by another degree, the holding asked less of her. Not nothing. Never nothing. But less. The door, once she had taught it the width, began to know the width. The lean, once she had let it be a lean, began to be a lean and not a fall. She felt the working settle the way the rebirth had settled in her once, not in a single stroke but in a vast slow motion altogether, the whole leaning weight of two oceans easing into a balance that had not existed in the world since a council of frightened people put their hands into the source and made the choice that started all of it, and she knelt at the pedestal with her hand in the pool and her self spread across the door and felt the world become, after a year of her own mercy eating it, a thing that could go on.

It would hold. She knew it the way she had known the cut would close. It would hold, and it would go on holding, and she had done it with her own two feet on the unworked floor and her own hand in the source and her own spread-thin self thrown across the sill in front of everyone she loved, witnessed, the whole of the difference between a sacrifice and a crime, and the balance started, under her hand, to take its own weight.

And then she understood why it would always need a throat.

* * *

She had thought, in the part of her that hoped, that holding the door to the width once might be enough. That she could teach the door its width and the lean its limit and then draw her hand up out of the pool the way she had drawn it up a year ago, changed and shaking and free, and let the balance go on without her the way a wound, once closed, goes on closed.

The door was not a wound. A wound, closed, stays closed; the edges knit; the thing is over. But a door held to a width is held to a width only as long as something holds it, and the source would go on rising forever because the world's lung was full forever, and the void would go on leaning forever because that is what an empty place does beside a full one, and the lean would find the door and try it forever, every breath, every birth that filled the lung a little fuller and every death that emptied it a little, the whole even endless traffic of the world's warmth coming and going across the one narrowed place, and the one narrowed place was her. She felt it as she felt the balance begin to take its own weight: that it took its own weight only because she was the weight under it. That the door knew its width because she was the width. That she could not draw her hand up out of the pool the way she had a year ago and walk away changed and free, because the changed-and-free girl had left a closed wound behind her, and the girl with her hand in the pool now would leave, if she drew it up, a door swinging open in a gale, and the world bleeding warmth into the cold the moment she stepped back.

She would have to hold the door.

Not for an afternoon. Not for the length of a working. The understanding came up her arm the way the hardest knowings always came, whole and sudden and out of the

holding, the full shape of it arriving before she could brace for any one part: that the weight she had taken up was not a thing she had lifted and could set down. It was a thing she had taken up, the way you take up a watch, and there is no end to a watch but the end of the watcher. She had made the world's lung full and now the world would lean toward its empty counterpart forever and the lean would need a door at the right width forever and she was the door. She had reached for the source meaning to do a great thing once and pay for it once, the way she had paid for the rebirth once, with her sight, and walked out blind and ordinary into an aftermath. There would be no walking out of this one. The cost of this one was not a thing spent in a stroke. The cost of this one was the holding. It was every breath of it, for as long as she breathed, and the True-Bond meant she would breathe a very long time.

She felt the cost begin to land the way you feel cold water reach the skin under your clothes, not all at once, a creeping line of it, the understanding moving through her one degree at a time: that she was sixteen years old and she had just learned that she would stand at this door, or near enough to it, holding the world to the width it could survive, feeling the full traffic of every warmth that came and went across her, for the rest of a life the bond had made very long, and that there was no one at the rim to take a turn, there had only ever been her, and a hand that makes the weight is the only hand that can hold it even, and she had said that to herself on the slope as a thing she understood and she had not understood it at all until now, with the balance taking its weight under her hand and the weight turning out to be the whole of the rest of her.

The burning came up behind her eyes, once. She held her hand in the pool and looked down into the pale even glow until it passed, because the glow was a good place to look

when your eyes burned, and because no one down here in the dark could see, and because she had settled it with herself years since that a burning you looked down until it stopped did not count.

* * *

Up the dark, at the threshold where the stone began, Raizen came apart one more time and went back together, and held the line, and did not know yet what his end of it had paid for, only that the pull on the bond had changed, from the wild dragging of a thing being torn to the steady even draw of a thing being carried, and that the difference, whatever it had cost her to make, was the difference his bracing at the far rooted end had been for, and he held it, rooted, so that she would not be only herself and would not be by herself either.

* * *

She lifted her face from the pool, not her hand. Her hand stayed in the source. Her hand, she understood now, would stay in the source, in the way that mattered, for the whole of the very long way off, the way she had told Alice at the threshold without quite knowing she meant it so wholly. But she lifted her face, and she found that her ordinary eyes still worked, the dark cave and the pale pool and the unworked stone there for her the way they were there for anyone, and that the other seeing, the lattice-sight, the cores and the threads and the deep place under everything, was still with her too, full, here at the fount where it always came whole, and that the source had not taken it this time. The source had not taken anything from her in a stroke this time. The source had not been asked for a stroke this time. It had been asked for a watch, and a watch is not a thing taken from you all at once and carried out of the room; a watch is a thing you

keep, awake, in your own body, for as long as the watch runs, and the source, neither cruel nor kind, had given her exactly the thing she had asked it for, which was the holding, forever, in her own two hands.

She knelt at the pedestal with her hand in the world and the balance taking its slow weight under her palm and the bond running rooted off the back of her up the dark to a man at the door, and she knew that she had done the thing she came to do, that it was working, that the world had stopped tearing and started breathing, and that the doing of it had not ended and was never going to end, and that the difference between this and the rebirth was the difference between a debt paid and a debt come due every single day for the rest of a borrowed life.

Two names lay just under the surface, side by side, warm in the way a letter is warm that has your name on it. She did not follow the second one down. She had learned that lesson too, and she meant to keep her edges, this time, for as long as the watch ran, because a door has to be held by someone who keeps hers. But she let it brush her, once, the warm familiar stillness, and she thought, not as a question she would chase but as a thing she finally understood about the woman at the far end of it: *Is this what you knew. Is this why you told me to be careful who saw me do it. Did you stand at a door once, and was it this. Did you carry this and never say, the way I am never going to say.* And the thread quivered, the way it always quivered, as if it heard her, and gave her no answer, the way it always gave her no answer, and she let it be, and turned the whole of herself back to the holding.

* * *

It held.

She felt it take, under her hand, the way you feel a fevered child's brow turn from burning to merely warm, the great

even leaning weight of two oceans settling into a balance across the narrowed door of her, the source full and not pouring, the void patient and not tearing, the world breathing in and out, and the working that had begun as two large things trying to come through her at once became, slowly, the steady carried weight of a watch being kept. It held. It was going to go on holding, because she was going to go on holding it, and she felt the truth of that arrive in her not as a triumph but as a settling, the way a great load settles onto the back of the one who is going to carry it the whole rest of the road, the moment the straps stop biting in new places and start biting in the one place they are going to bite forever.

The balance held. And the cost, the real cost, the one the cold part had failed to put a number to on the slope because it was not a number, began, slow and cold and entire, to come home to her: that she had not paid for the world and walked out free. She had taken it up. The weight of the source was hers now, taken up in her own two hands in front of everyone she loved, and she was going to carry it, breathing, down the whole of the very long way off, and the carrying had only, this moment, with the balance settling onto her back, begun.

She knelt in the pale even light with her hand in the world, and held the door, and felt the weight take its place across her shoulders, and did not yet let herself feel the whole of what it would mean, because the door was open at exactly the right width and the world was breathing and there was no part of her to spare, yet, for the rest of it.

There would be time. That was the worst of it, and the truest. There would be all the time there was.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Cost

It came to her the way weather comes to a country, not as a thing she chose to look at but as a thing that was simply happening now across the whole reach of her, and she had no eyelid for it, and that was the first true shape the cost took: that there was no looking away.

She had her hand in the source and her face lifted from the pool and the door held to its width under her palm, and she had thought, in the half-breath after the balance took its weight, that the worst was behind her, that holding a door was a single hard thing she would do forever and would at least know the size of. She did not yet know the size of it. The size of it began to arrive while she knelt there, the way the cold had arrived on the slope, by degrees and then in a rush, because the door she held was not a door onto a wall. It was a door onto everything, and everything was the whole even traffic of the world's warmth coming and going, and now that she was the throat of it, the traffic came through her.

A child was born.

Not a child she would ever see. Somewhere east of the fold, a long way off, past the army and the broken capital and a river she did not know the name of, in a room she would never stand in, a core that had not been in the world a moment before was suddenly in it, small and new and blazing the particular outrageous blaze of a life that has only

just begun, and she felt it the way you feel a coal put against the back of your hand, sudden and entire and not asking, the lung of the world filling by one breath more. She had no choice about the feeling of it. It was not a thing she reached for. It came up the channel of her hand into the part of her that was the door, and for the length of it she was that room, that small fierce new warmth, that filling, whether she would or no, and then the moment passed and the child went on being born without her and she was a girl at a pedestal again with a coal-mark on the inside of her that would not cool.

She had time to think, *Oh*. That was all. *Oh*.

Then an old man went out.

* * *

He went out gently, wherever he was. There was no wound in it. She felt that too, the cleanness of it, the way you can feel from across a room whether a thing was torn or only laid down: this was laid down. An old core somewhere south, banked low for a long time, the way a fire is banked at the end of a long evening, and it did not so much stop as let go, the warmth in it sliding out of the world the way water slides off a tilted plate, unhurried, finished, and the lung of the world emptied by one breath, and the door under her hand felt the lean change by exactly that much, the void leaning one breath harder because there was one breath less to lean against, and she set herself across the sill by exactly that much to meet it, without deciding to, her hold tightening as a hand tightens on a rope when the weight on the far end shifts.

He had been somebody's. She did not know whose. That was the part she had not reckoned, doing her sums on the slope, naming it a differential, a clean coin of a word: that each breath in the great traffic had been a person, and the door did not let her keep them at the width of a word. The old

man going gently out had been held, somewhere, by a hand she would never know, and the going-out came up her arm with the held-ness still on it, the room of it, the lamp and the long evening and whoever sat by, and she carried it across the sill the way she carried the rest, and let the void lean its one breath harder, and did not seal it, and did not look away, since there was nowhere away to look.

She knelt very still. Above her, far up the dark on the whole rock, the company held the line they could see, against the cold they could see, and could not see this at all.

* * *

This is the thing she understood, kneeling there, and it was the cost, and no one would ever be able to take a turn at it for her, and she would never be able to say the half of it to anyone she loved: that the rebirth had run the world's lung full, and a full lung breathes, and now she was the breathing of it. Every warmth that came into the world filled the lung and leaned the door one way. Every warmth that left it emptied the lung and leaned the door the other. And she was the door, held to its width by a girl, and the only way to hold a door to its width through a changing weight is to feel the weight change, every time, and answer it, every time, and she was going to feel it change every time for the whole of a life the bond had made very long.

She tried, for one cold flat moment, to do the cold part's arithmetic on it, because the arithmetic was the thing she ran to when the rest of her could not stand the size of a thing. How many. How many in a day. She got as far as a number that was not a number, a thing the mind slides off the way a hand slides off wet glass, and the cold part, which had carried her through a burning school and a year of half-sight and a man going gladly into the cold, set down its chalk and would not do the sum, because there was no use

in a sum whose answer was *all of them, always, for the rest of a borrowed life*, and she let the arithmetic go, which she had almost never done, and felt the loss of it like a rail taken away on a high place.

A woman, far west, lost a child before it was born.

She felt that one differently. It was a warmth that had begun to be and then stopped being, a coal lit and gone out in the same breath, the lung filling and emptying so close together that the two were one motion, and the door barely moved, and the smallness of it on the lattice was the unbearable part, that a thing so large to the woman who carried it was, on the great even reach of the world's warmth, the faintest flicker, here and gone, a candle guttering in a country of furnaces. She felt the woman's not yet knowing. She felt the small warmth wink out under a heart that would go on beating for hours before the body told it. And she had no eyelid for that either, and she carried it across the sill with the rest, and her own heart, the ordinary one in her own chest, did a thing in the dark that her face did not.

* * *

The bond held.

She found it the way she had found it in the worse flood, the one line in all the changing weight that wanted nothing of her, that did not fill or empty or lean, that only held, rooted, a warmth set to be a warmth and not a door. Raizen, up the dark at the threshold where the stone began. She could feel him on the far end of the line, braced, ordinary, still half-amazed by feet and cold and the whole strange business of standing on two legs in a body the source had given back, and she could feel that the wild dragging on the line had stopped, that what ran between them now was the steady even draw of a thing being carried and not the tearing

of a thing being torn, and she could feel that he did not know yet what his bracing had bought, only that the pull had changed under him, from a storm to a weight.

She reached for the line, with the part of her that was still a girl and not yet only the door.

She did not need to climb it this time. She was not spreading out into the function the way she had on the slope; the working had settled, the door knew its width, she was not in danger of thinning out entirely into the throttle. But she reached for the line anyway, the way you put a hand on a doorpost in a dark house not because you are falling but because you want to know the house is still around you, and she found his warmth at the far rooted end of it, and she held on, and the holding-on did not make the door easier and did not stop the births and the deaths coming through her and did not give her an eyelid for any of it. It gave her only this: that she was not feeling the whole traffic of the world alone in the dark. There was a line off the back of her to a man who would brace the rooted end of it for the whole of the very long way off, who had said so in the dark before she ever set her hand to the source, and who would go on saying so, and the door was a thing she would hold forever, but she would not hold it by herself.

She thought, very plainly, in the middle of the great changing weight: *I could not do this without you on the end of the line.* And she sent no word of it down the bond, because the bond did not need the saying, and because she had no part of her to spare for words, but she let the thought be true, and held the line, and held the door, and let the world breathe in and out across her.

* * *

Up the dark, where the stone began, he felt the thought come down the line without words, and did not understand the

half of what she was carrying, and braced anyway, and that was the whole of his part, and he kept it.

* * *

A man died with a wound.

It was the other kind, and she had been waiting for it, in the part of her that had been at a wall and a burning school and knew that not every warmth goes gently out. It came up her arm torn. Somewhere east of the fold, in the long grey unwinding of the war she could not see, a man's core went out the wrong way, fast and against itself, the warmth not laid down but struck out, and she felt the strike of it, the affront of it, a thing that should have had years in it ending in a breath, and the door under her palm jerked the way a held thing jerks at a sudden load, and she set herself across it, fast, and held the width, and the void leaned and she let it lean and did not seal it, and the man finished dying without her, and she carried the torn shape of it across the sill, and it was worse than the old man and worse than the child and worse than the small flicker in the west, because there had been a hand behind it. There was always going to be a hand behind some of them. She was going to feel those too. Every one.

She held very still in the pale even light and looked down into the glow until the burning behind her eyes went down again, because the glow was a good place to look when your eyes burned, and because no one down here in the dark could see, and because she had settled it with herself years since that a burning you looked down until it passed did not count, and she was not going to start counting it now, here, at the door, where the whole reckoning of the world was already counting itself through her hand. She would keep that one ledger to herself. It was the one ledger that was hers.

* * *

There were small ones too, and the small ones taught her the rest of the shape.

A core flickered, far north, and did not go out. She felt it dip the way a candle dips when a door is opened somewhere down a hall, and steady again, and she understood she had just felt someone, in a cold room she would never see, come very near to dying and then not. A child with a fever, maybe, that broke before dawn. A man who had gone under the ice and been got out. She would never know which. She felt the dip and the steadying and not the story between them, and the not-knowing was a thing she was going to have to make her peace with, because the door gave her the bare fact of every warmth and none of the meaning, and a person is more than a flicker, and she was going to feel the flicker of every person in the world and the meaning of almost none of them, and that was its own loneliness, to be that near to everyone and let in on nothing.

Two cores, somewhere west, found each other. She felt that as a kind of warmth doubling, two ordinary lives leaning toward one another the way the source leaned toward the void, not a birth and not a death but a thing the door registered anyway, because the door felt every change in the world's warmth and this was a change, and she let it pass through her with the rest, glad of it the way she was glad of the births, undefended, sixteen, and thought, in the part of her that was still a girl, that she had not known the door would let her feel a thing as small and good as that, and that if it was going to make her carry every wound it could at least let her carry the odd kindness too, and that this, perhaps, was the only mercy built into the watch: that it was not only the dying she would feel.

She held the door. The world came and went. She kept her hand in the source and her face turned toward the dark and let the whole even traffic of it move across the throat of her, the dippings and the steadyings and the doublings and the lightings and the going-outs, and turned away from none of it, having nowhere to turn.

* * *

It was the births that nearly broke her, in the end, and not the deaths, and she had not seen that coming.

She had braced for the deaths. She had been bracing for deaths since she was fourteen years old. A girl who has filed the dead since a school burned down has a place she puts a death, a cold flat place, the cold part's ledger, and even here, even feeling them come through her in the body, she had a place to put them. There was nowhere in her to put the births. They came up her arm blazing, outrageous, glad, a thing she had no defence against, because there is no defending yourself against gladness. Each one was a whole new person beginning the whole long business of being alive. She felt the world full of them, a country of new coals all lit at once across a single grey morning, more being born in any breath than she could have counted in a day, the lung of the world filling and filling. And the unbearable thing was not the weight of them but the wonder of them. That she should be the one who felt every single beginning the world made. That she had no eyelid for the wonder any more than for the grief, and that the wonder was its own kind of too-much, a sweetness so large it had a grief folded inside it, because she was going to feel every one of these begin and she was going to be there, in the years without number ahead of her, to feel every one of them end.

That was the shape the bond put on it, finally, the thing the True-Bond meant that she had said to herself as a fact

and not understood. She was going to live a very long time. The child born east of the fold this morning would grow and have its years and grow old and one evening let its warmth slide gently out of the world the way the old man had, laid down, finished, and she would feel that too, the same child, the whole arc of it, the beginning she had felt this morning and the going-out she would feel in seventy years, and there would be no part of her that had forgotten the coal-mark of the beginning when the ending came. She was going to carry the whole length of strangers' lives. Not the middle. The door did not give her the middle, the days, the names, the suppers and the quarrels and the small ordinary years; it gave her only the two ends, the lighting and the going-out, the filling and the emptying, the lean one way and the lean the other, and she was going to hold the door true through both ends of every life the world made for the whole of a life that was barely going to begin to end.

She was sixteen years old.

She let that be a fact, the way she had set the arithmetic down, put it where she could see it and held her gaze on it: that she was sixteen, and what she had learned this morning was that this was the watch, and there was no end to a watch but the end of the watcher, and the watcher was bonded to a thing that did not end the way watchers usually do. She held her face still. She held the door. She looked down into the glow until the eyes stopped, and held the line off the back of her, and held the door, and let the world come and go across the throat of her, and was sixteen, and did the only thing a person can do with a weight that does not lift, which is the carrying of it, one breath at a time, beginning now.

* * *

Far up the dark, at the cavern mouth, a woman she could not see kept her hand flat on a cold kettle, because a hand has to

be somewhere, and a man with a cold mark on him stood in a doorway and closed nothing, because there was nothing left to close, and a healer with a crooked tooth waited at the threshold with her warmth turned all the way up toward a girl she could not reach, and the Dangris stood shadowless at the seam where the cold leaned thinnest, and all of them held the line they could see, and none of them could feel what came and went through her hand, and that was the mercy in it, the one mercy: that the door was hers alone to feel, and so it was theirs not to. She would not have wished it on any of them. That was a thing she found out about herself in the dark, kneeling there with the whole world's coming and going in her open hand: that of all the people she could have wished beside her in it, the truth was she would not have one of them feel a single birth or a single death of it, that she would rather carry the whole reach of it alone than have Alice feel even one going-out, and that the wanting-to-spare-them was not the weight lifting but the weight finding the exact shape of her, settling onto her back in the one place it was going to sit for good.

Alice had a crooked tooth and warm hands and a laugh that had come back to her slowly across the year, the way her own sight had come back, a piece at a time. Viridia thought of the laugh, kneeling there with the world coming and going through her hand. She thought of it on purpose, the way you press a thumb to a bruise to be sure the rest of you still works. The laugh was up the dark, a long climb of black stone away, on the far side of a cold the others could feel and a traffic of births and deaths they could not, and the thought of it did not lighten the door by the weight of a feather. It only reminded her what the door was held open for. She had not done this so that the world would be safe. She had done it so that there would go on being laughs in it, crooked teeth in it, hands that came back warm. That was a

different thing from safe, and a smaller thing, and the only thing worth the watch.

* * *

And then, while she held the door at its width and the world came and went across her, she felt the cold begin, very slightly, to draw back.

She almost did not believe it. For a year she had felt the lean steepen, the cold drawing harder and harder toward the warmth she had become, the pull that bent portals open and dragged the Horrors through them toward the source the way absence is drawn to presence. She had felt it on the black slope so strong she could nearly lose her footing in it. And now, with the door held true to its width, with the source full and not pouring and the void leaning and not tearing, the great steepening pull began, the smallest degree at a time, to slacken. Not to vanish. It would never vanish; the void leaned because that is what an empty place does beside a full one, and it was going to lean for as long as there was a fullness to lean toward, which was forever. But the lean stopped getting steeper. The door, held to the right width, gave the cold a thing to lean against that was not a wound and was not an artery, and the cold, met that way, eased off the wild dragging it had been doing all year, and settled into the long even patient lean of a thing resting against its own counterpart.

She felt it on the lattice: a tide turning. Out across the world, at the torn places, at the rims where the cold had bent the world thin and pulled its Horrors through, the pull slackened, and the things that had been dragged toward the source by it stopped being dragged. They did not die. She felt that clearly, and held to it, because it mattered, because she had come a continent swearing she would not commit the council's crime in a new coat, would not seal and throttle

and choose who got to be in the world: the Horrors did not die. They simply stopped being pulled. The pressure that had drawn them through the torn places and across the world toward her eased off them, and at the rims, one by one, slow, the way a thing that has been straining toward something lets go when the strain comes off it, they began to draw back. Back toward the cold edge they had come from. Back toward the leaning absence that was, she understood now and would never unname, the necessary other half of the breath she was the throat of. Not driven back. Released back. The world stopped pulling at them, and so they stopped coming, and at the far torn places the cold began to recede the way a flood recedes when the rain stops, off the fields, off the low places, off the world it had been leaning into all year.

She held the door, and felt the world breathe, and felt, very far off, the cold begin to go back to its edge.

* * *

It would take a long time. She could feel that too. The lean had been steepening for a year, and a year's lean does not come off a world in a morning; the recession would be slow, the rims would be days and weeks closing, the cold would be a long while drawing all the way back to its proper edge, and there would be torn places, here and there, that held warmth a while longer in the way a soaked field holds water after the river has dropped. But the direction had changed. That was the thing she held to, kneeling in the pale even light with a child's beginning and an old man's going-out and a struck man's wound all carried across the sill of her and the whole great traffic still coming and coming: the direction had changed. The world had spent a year leaning into the cold. Now the cold was beginning, the smallest degree at a time, to lean back off the world.

She had done that. Her hand had done that, in the source, in front of everyone she loved and where they could not feel it, and she would go on doing it, holding the door true through every birth and every death, and the doing of it had not ended and was never going to end, and the cost of it was that there was no away and no eyelid and no taking of turns and no end but the end of the watcher.

She lifted her face a little more from the pool. Her ordinary eyes still found the dark cave and the pale glow, there for her the way they were there for anyone. Down the line off the back of her, Raizen held, rooted. Far up the dark, the company held the line they could see, and the cold leaning thinnest at the seam where the Dangris stood began, by the smallest degree, to lean less thin.

She knelt at the door with her hand in the world and held it, and felt the great pull go quiet, out across the torn places, the way a fever goes quiet, and did not yet know how she was going to carry the whole rest of it, only that she was going to, and that the world, for the first time in a year, had stopped tearing and begun, somewhere far off and out of her sight, to mend the long slow way a thing mends when at last it has been let alone.

The cold was going back to its edge. She held the door at the width that let it.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

What the World Keeps

She lifted her hand out of the pool.

She did it fast, before the part of her that was afraid could lodge an objection, because she had knelt at the pedestal a long time with the certainty growing in her that she could not lift it, that the door would gape the instant her palm came off the water, that the world had been spared for the length of a kneeling and would be unmade the moment she stood, and the only way to find out the certainty was wrong was to find out, and so she lifted her hand.

Nothing tore.

The water ran off her fingers and fell back into the pool with a sound so small it was almost no sound, and the pale even glow of the source went on glowing, and the door held. She felt it hold. She felt it hold all through her, the great even leaning weight of the world balanced across the narrowed width of her, and the width did not change when her wet hand came up dripping into the cold air of the cave, because the width was not in her hand. It had never been in her hand. Her hand had been the way in, a key turned once in a lock, but the door she had become was the whole of her, the merged one core, and that rose with her out of the pool and would go wherever she went and hold the world to the width it could survive from anywhere a girl could stand.

She understood it, kneeling there with her dripping hand held up in front of her like something that had stopped belonging to her. She had told Alice, at the threshold, without quite knowing she meant it so wholly, that her hand would stay in the source. It would. In the way that mattered, it would stay there for as long as there was a world to hold. But the part of her that mattered was not the wet part she could lift, and she could lift the wet part, and stand, and walk out into the world, and carry the door with her, held at its width, wherever she went, because she was the width of it now, and a person carries herself out of a room when the kneeling is done.

She was still kneeling. The kneeling was done. She had simply not yet stood.

* * *

She stood.

Her legs did the things legs do that have knelt too long on cold stone, the pins-and-needles, the not-quite-holding, and she put one hand on the pedestal to steady the standing and the other still dripping at her side, and the world kept breathing across her the whole while, a child born somewhere far west that she felt come up into the lung of the world bright and outrageous and glad, and an old core somewhere going gently out, the lung emptying by that much, the door leaning to meet the change and her self leaning across it without her deciding to, the way her hand had tightened on the rope when the weight on the far end shifted, except now there was no rope and no pedestal-water and the leaning happened in the standing the same as it had happened in the kneeling. It made no difference to the door whether she knelt or stood. That was the thing she had needed her body to teach her, since her mind had said it on

the slope and not believed it. The watch was not a posture. It was her.

So she could stand. She could turn. She could put her back to the source for the first time since she had come down through the dark to it, and the door did not gape, and a man whose name she would never know finished being born somewhere in the grey morning above, and she felt it, full and entire, and held the width true, standing, with her back to the pool, looking up the dark at the long climb of black stone she had come down.

She started up it.

* * *

The climb back was longer than the climb down had been, because going down she had been all one purpose, a thing falling toward the thing it had come for, and going up she was a tired girl with the whole reach of the world coming and going across her at every step, and she had to climb the black stone with that traffic moving through her. A birth on the third step. A quiet going-out on the seventh. On the twelfth, a man dying with a wound, struck out, fast, against himself, and the door jerked under the load of it the way a held thing jerks, and she stopped on the twelfth step and set herself across it and held the width and let the void lean its one breath harder and did not seal it. Then she went on climbing, because the climbing and the holding were the same thing now and were going to be the same thing forever, walking and holding, eating and holding, sleeping, if she ever slept again, and holding, and she might as well learn it on a flight of cold stairs in the unwatched dark as anywhere else.

It was a Tuesday, she thought, climbing. Or it was not. She had genuinely lost the count of the days somewhere on the slope, and which day it was had stopped mattering to

her, only that it was the first day of the watch, and that all the other days, however they were numbered, were going to be days of the watch too.

She climbed up out of the dark into the grey.

* * *

They were where she had left them, at the cavern mouth, holding the line they could see.

She saw them before any of them saw her, because she rose out of the deeper dark into the lesser dark of the cave's throat and they were turned outward toward the cold, watching the seam where the cold leaned thinnest, and so for a moment she had them all in front of her unguarded, the whole company, the way you see the people you love when they do not know they are being seen and are only being themselves, tired, and braced, and hers.

Amber stood nearest the mouth with her arms not folded, the black-nailed hand loose at her side, her weight set the way a person sets their weight who has decided to stand exactly here and be moved only by force. The Dangris were shadowless at the seam, three of them, standing-with in the way they did that was not quite standing and not quite a thing a body did at all, and the cold leaned thinnest where they stood and they let it lean and gave no ground before it. And there in the cavern mouth, in the doorway, half-turned between the dark she was climbing out of and the grey morning behind him, was a man with dark ordinary eyes and a cold mark on him, standing in the door and closing nothing because nothing remained to close, and the bond ran off the back of her up the stone to him, rooted, and she felt him before she let any of them know she was there, felt the steady even rooted draw of him on the far end of the line, and the feeling of it was the first thing since she had lifted her hand from the pool that did not ask her to hold anything.

She stopped where she was, in the throat of the cave, and let herself feel it for the length of one breath. Then a child was born somewhere far off and she felt that too, glad and outrageous, and she carried it across the sill of her with the rest, and took the last steps up into the grey.

Raizen turned. He turned because he felt her come up the bond toward him, not because he heard her, and his dark ordinary eyes found her in the half-dark, and he did not say *you did it* and he did not ask her what it had cost, because he had been on the far end of the line the whole while and he had felt the pull change under him from a storm to a weight and he knew, in the only way he could know it, which was not the half of it, that the weight was on now and was not coming off. He came two steps and put a hand out, not to catch her, because she was walking and did not need catching, but the way you put a hand on a doorpost in a dark house to be sure the house is still around you, and she took it, his ordinary warm hand in her cold one, and held it, and that was the whole of what they said.

Amber said the rest. Amber crossed the stone fast and stood square in front of her and looked at her the way she looked at a thing she meant to get the true measure of, up and down, the wrung-out swaying tiredness of her, the wet hand, the eyes that landed on Amber and held instead of sliding off, and she said, "Well." And then she said it again, lower, "Well," and her voice did the rough thing it did, and she did not ask whether Viridia had had the right, because she had asked that on the long march and Viridia had paid the asking in full now, in a dark room where Amber could not follow her to watch, and Amber, of all of them, would not hand her the forgiveness she had not earned, and so what she handed her instead was the thing she could honestly give, which was: "I don't know what you did down there. I know what it took. I can see what it took." She put her loose

black-nailed hand flat on Viridia's shoulder, hard, bracing a thing that might go over. "Let's get you off this rock."

* * *

Alice was waiting at the lip of the mouth, where the cave gave onto the grey slope, with her warmth turned all the way up.

She had not come into the dark. Viridia understood, seeing her there, that Alice had stood at the lip the whole while with her healer's warmth turned up toward a girl she could not reach, the way you keep a lamp in a window for someone out in weather, and that the keeping of it had been Alice's whole part and she had kept it, and that the warmth was the first warmth Viridia came into out of the cold of the cave, and it reached her, it actually reached her, the way the source-warmth never would because the source-warmth came up her arm as traffic and Alice's came across the grey air as a person.

Alice had a crooked tooth and warm hands and a laugh that had come back to her slowly across the year, a piece at a time, the way Viridia's own sight had once come back, and the laugh was not there now, because there was nothing yet to laugh at, but the warmth was, the whole of it, turned up and steady. She did not say anything clever. She had not been clever for a long time, not since the cold place she had been kept, and the cleverness was one of the pieces that had not all come back yet, and Viridia found she did not want it back, not the cleverness, only the warmth, and the warmth was here.

"You're cold," Alice said. It was the only thing she said. She took Viridia's free hand, the wet one, the one that had been in the source, and folded both her warm ones around it, and held it, and Viridia felt the warmth go into the cold hand and not be enough to warm it, because the cold in that

hand was not the cold of weather and would never altogether warm again, and Alice felt the not-being-enough and did not let go, and held on harder, which was the right thing, which was the only thing, because the holding-on was not for the warming. It was for the holding-on.

And Viridia, standing in the cavern mouth with her wet cold hand in Alice's two warm ones and her other hand in Raizen's and Amber's hard palm on her shoulder and the Dangris standing-with at the seam and a child being born far off across the breathing world, felt the burning come up behind her eyes, once, and looked down at the folded hands until it passed, because the folded hands were a good place to look when your eyes burned, and because they were all of them watching her face and none of them watching the inside of her where the watch ran, and because she had settled it with herself years since that a burning you looked down until it stopped did not count, and she was not going to start counting it now, here, in the one good moment, with the people she had held the door open for standing around her in the grey holding the parts of her they could reach.

It was the warmth that nearly did it, in the end, and not the cold, and she had not seen that coming, the same way the births had been the thing that nearly broke her down in the dark and not the deaths. She had braced for the cold. She had no brace ready for being held by four people in a cave mouth on the first morning of a watch that would not end. And the moment held, and was the best thing in it.

* * *

They came down off the rock slowly, because no reason to hurry was left in the world, and that itself was a strange new thing to learn, the not-hurrying.

For a year there had been a reason to hurry. The cold had been steepening, the lean drawing harder and harder

toward the warmth she had become, the Horrors dragged through the torn places toward the source the way absence is drawn to presence, and every day had been a day spent against a clock that was speeding up. The clock had stopped speeding up. She could feel it on the lattice as they came down the slope, the great steepening pull gone over, the lean stopped getting steeper, the cold settled into the long even patient lean of a thing resting against its own counterpart instead of the wild dragging of a thing tearing toward what it lacked. And out across the world, at the torn places, at the rims where the cold had bent the world thin, the things that had been dragged toward her were not being dragged anymore. They had stopped being pulled. They were drawing back, slow, the way anything that has been straining toward something lets go once the strain comes off, back toward the cold edge they had come from, and they were not being driven and they were not dying, they were simply being let alone, and a thing let alone goes back, in its own time, to where it was before the pulling started.

It would take a long time. The cold did not come off a world in a morning. The rims would be days and weeks closing, and there would be torn places, here and there, that held the cold a while longer the way a soaked field holds water after the river has dropped, and people in those places would have a hard while of it yet. But the direction had changed. She held to that, coming down the slope with her people around her and the world breathing across her. The world had spent a year leaning into the cold. Now the cold was beginning, the smallest degree at a time, to lean back off the world.

* * *

The army was still on the plain below, and it had begun, while she was in the dark, to come apart.

Not into rout and not into surrender. Into people. She saw it as they came down, the great stopped mass of the host that had marched a week to put her in the ground, and it was not a host anymore. It was men. They had set their workings down because a working is heavy to hold lit and no reason remained to hold one, and they sat on the churned ground in their enemy's plain sight, and some of them had got up and begun the long business of walking, west or east as their homes lay, and no one stopped them, because there was no longer any one whose business it was to stop a man from walking home.

She could not read a single core of them. The lattice-sight was full in her, fuller than it had ever been, but it was full of the deep traffic now, the births and the going-outs of the whole reach of the world, and it did not stoop to tell her which man on the plain below had a furnace in him and which a candle, which had meant her harm and which had only been frightened into the line. She found she did not need it to. A man whose whole life has changed inside his chest in a grey morning he cannot account for looks the same from the front of the eyes as from the deep seeing. He looks like a man who has been handed something and does not know whose hand it came from. The whole plain below was full of men who had been handed something. Every one of them carried both halves of the gift now, the light and the dark together, the way she did, the way everyone alive did since the rebirth, and the war they had marched to fight had been a war about a difference between people that no longer existed, and you cannot keep fighting a war whose reason has gone out of the world in the night.

There was a knot of them down at the foot of the slope, a dozen or so, who had not walked home and had not sat down with their faces in their hands, and were instead standing in a loose ring arguing, and she watched them as she came

down, because there was something in the shape of the arguing that was new.

They were not arguing about whether to fight. The fighting was over and they all knew it. They were arguing, she understood as she came near enough to catch the shapes of it, about who was to say what happened next, and the strange new thing, the thing six hundred years of a world with someone always at the top of it had never once shown her, was that no one in the ring was claiming the saying. It was the opposite. A big man with a sergeant's bearing was insisting, loud, that it was not his to decide where the supply carts went now that there was no quartermaster and no Chancellor and no order coming down the line, and a thin man was insisting back, just as loud, that it was not his either, and a third was saying that someone had to decide or the carts would sit there and the food in them spoil, and the argument was not a fight over a crown. It was a dozen frightened tired men standing in a ring in the mud discovering, out loud, in real time, that the thing at the top of the world, the thing that had told them all their lives what to do, was gone, and was not coming back, and that the deciding was going to have to be done by the people standing in the mud, and none of them knew how, and all of them were afraid of it, and they were going to have to learn it anyway, because the carts were really there and the food in them would really spoil.

She stood at the foot of the slope and watched the ring of them argue about the carts, and it was the most hopeful thing she had seen in a year, and she could not have said exactly why, except that it was the sound of a world that no longer had a head learning that it was going to have to grow its deciding out of its own middle, the way a thing grows toward the light from wherever it has been cut, and that no one was designing the new shape and no one was in charge

of the new shape and the new shape was going to come anyway, slow and quarrelsome and from below, out of a dozen men in the mud worrying about who would say where the carts went.

She did not go and tell them. She had a thing she could have told them, that the difference they had fought about was gone, that they all carried both halves now, that nothing was left to be a side about. But she had crossed a continent learning the cost of being the one who steps in and decides things for people, and she was the last person on the plain who should walk into a ring of men learning to decide for themselves and hand them an answer from on high, because she of all of them could see how badly that ended, having spent the year cleaning up after the last people who had done it. So she let the ring of them argue, and did not go down, and the arguing was the new shape beginning, and the not-going-down was hers.

"They'll work it out," Amber said, beside her, watching the same ring. "Or they won't, and the food spoils, and they're hungry, and then they work it out. That's how it goes when there's nobody to make them." She was quiet a moment. "I've lived in a place with nobody to make them. It's not tidy. It's better than the other thing."

"It's not fixed," Viridia said.

"No," Amber said. "It's not fixed." She looked at Viridia sidelong, the black-nailed hand loose. "You didn't go up that rock to fix it. You went up to keep there being a world for them to make a mess of. There's a world. They're making a mess of it. Down there." She nodded at the ring of arguing men. "That's the win. That's what winning looks like, when you do it your way. A bunch of tired men in the mud, free to argue about carts." Her mouth did something that on another face would have been a smile. "Ugly little win. I'll take it."

* * *

Drake came over the plain in the early afternoon, low, his shadow running ahead of him across the churned ground, and the men who had marched to fight a war scattered out from under the shadow not in terror now but in the stunned slow wonder of people who have stopped being able to be afraid of one more impossible thing, and he came down on the slope above the army with the wind of his wings flattening the grass and folded the great breadth of himself and was, for a moment, only a dragon at rest on a hill in the afternoon, the colors running slow along his spine.

She climbed up to him. He had a thing to tell her, and she had felt it coming, in the set of him, before he said it.

"The range is going quiet," Drake said. His voice was the deep slow grind of it, the voice that had named her a friend and a fool across the year in roughly equal measure. "I can feel it the way you can, I'd wager, only smaller. The cold's leaning off the high passes. The pull that bent the portals open up there, that dragged my kind half-mad toward the source all year, it's slackening. They're settling. The young ones that fled south are turning back north." He turned one great eye on her. "I have to go and be among them while they settle. A range full of dragons coming back to their right minds all at once is not a thing to leave to settle itself. Somebody has to be the old one on the high rock while they remember how to be themselves."

"I know," she said. And she did. She had felt the range going quiet on the lattice, the same as the rims, the same as the plain.

"I'll be a long way off," he said. "But you'll feel me. You feel everything now, don't you. The whole sorry breathing lot of us." He did not quite make it a question. He had worked out, in his slow enormous way, more of what she carried

than she had told him, because he was old and he had watched her measure the differential across a continent and he was not a fool. "You'll feel me born and you'll feel me go out, one day, the long way off. Same as all of them."

"Yes," she said, and gave it to him plain, because he would not have wanted it any other way.

"Good," Drake said, which was not what she had expected, and he saw the not-expecting and rumbled the deep grinding thing that was as near as he came to a laugh. "It's a comfort, girl, to an old creature, to know that when he goes out there'll be one warmth in the world that feels it land and knows what it weighed. Most of us go out unfelt. You'll feel mine. That's not nothing. That's the opposite of nothing." He put the great brow down toward her, the way Raizen's dragon-self had used to, and she put her cold hand on it, and held it there, and neither of them said the word for what it was, because the word was too small and they were both too old for it now, one of them in years and one of them in a single year that had been longer than years.

Then he stood, and the wind of him flattened the grass, and he went up off the hill into the grey afternoon and turned north toward the high passes and the dragons coming back to their right minds, and she stood on the hill and watched him go with her ordinary eyes for as long as her ordinary eyes could hold him, and felt him on the bond-that-was-not-a-bond, the kinship that was only friendship and was enough, going north and small and away, and did not look away until he was a dark mark on the grey and then not even that.

The burning came up behind her eyes. She looked down at the flattened grass until it passed. No one was on the hill with her, but she looked down anyway, out of the habit of a year, because it was the one ledger that was hers and she

meant to keep it hers even alone on a hill with the only witness gone north.

* * *

They camped that night below the slope, the company, in the lee of a broken cart, because the company had to be somewhere and a body has to lie down even when the part of it that matters does not stop, and Viridia lay down with them and did not sleep, and found that not-sleeping was not the trial she had feared, because the world came and went across her whether her eyes were open or shut and there was a kind of company in it she had not expected.

She lay in the dark with Raizen's warmth rooted on the far end of the bond, ordinary and asleep, half-amazed even in his sleep by the strange new business of having feet, and Amber's slower warmth a few yards off, and Alice's nearer, the healer's warmth banked low for the night the way a fire is banked, and beyond them, out across the breathing world, the whole even traffic of it, the births and the going-outs and the dippings and the steadyings and, once, far west, two cores finding each other, leaning toward one another the way the source leaned toward the void, and she felt that one and was glad of it, undefended, sixteen, the way she had been glad of the small good thing in the dark. The world was full of beginnings. She was going to feel every one of them begin, and she was going to feel every one of them end, in the fullness of the very long way off, and the wonder of the beginnings had a grief folded inside it and the grief of the endings would have, she was learning, a wonder folded inside that, because each going-out she carried across the sill had been a whole life held by hands she would never know, and the not-knowing was its own loneliness and the feeling-it-anyway was its own strange grace.

Fen was alive, somewhere. She did not know the name, lying there, did not know the boy or the low stone room far off where a man's last working had gone wrong, did not know there was anything yet to know. She only felt, in the great even traffic, the ordinary fact of warmths going on being warmths, more of them than she could ever count, the whole country of the living breathing in and out across the throat of her, and she held the door at the width that let them, and lay in the dark among the four she loved, and did not sleep, and kept the watch.

* * *

This is the thing she understood, lying there in the lee of the broken cart on the first night of it, and it was the shape of the rest of her life and she said none of it aloud to any of them.

She had not paid for the world and walked out free. She had not, this time, the way she had after the rebirth, spent a great thing in a stroke and woken blind and ordinary in an aftermath with the worst behind her. There was no behind her now. The cost of this one was not spent. It was carried, and it was hers, and it was permanent, and no one would ever be able to take a turn at it, and she would never be able to say the half of it to anyone she loved, not to Raizen rooted on the far end of the line, not to Alice with her warm hands, not to Amber who had named the cost out loud before she paid it, not to Drake gone north into the quiet. The door was hers to hold. The world was hers to feel come and go. The watch was hers, and there was no end to a watch but the end of the watcher, and the watcher was bonded to a thing with no ending in it the way watchers usually have, and she was sixteen years old.

She let it be a fact. She put it where she could see it, the way she had set the arithmetic down, the way she had set her age down in the dark. She was sixteen, and the world

had stopped tearing and begun, far off and out of her sight, the long slow way back toward its right shape, and the price of that was that she would stand at the door of it, or near enough, holding it true through every birth and every death, and the price was not coming off, and she was the only one who would ever feel its full weight, and the only one who could.

She turned her face up toward the dark where the stars were, the ordinary stars, there for her the way they were there for anyone. Down the line off the back of her, Raizen held, sleeping. Out across the breathing world, the cold leaned the smallest degree less hard than it had the night before, going back, little by little, to its edge. A child was born somewhere far west and she felt it come up bright into the lung of the world, and she carried it across the sill of her, and held the door at the width that let the world keep it.

That was the work now. That was the whole of the work, for the whole of the very long way off: to hold the door at the width that let the world keep what it made. She did not weep. She looked up at the ordinary stars until the burning behind her eyes went down, and held the line, and held the door, and let the world come and go across her, and was sixteen, and carried it, one breath at a time, because there was no one else who could, and because she had found out about herself, in the dark, that she would not have wished it on a single one of them, and because the carrying was hers now, the one weight that did not lift, taken up in her own two hands, and going on.

CHAPTER TWENTY

A Place Where a Core Should Be

The first weeks of a world with no one at the top of it went, in Wend, like this.

Spring came up the valley unhurried, the way it had always come, not knowing the world had changed, and the almond tree at the bottom of the garden flowered the way it flowered every year, and Viridia felt the flowers register in the source-sense as she had felt them the spring before, a small green outrageous insistence down under the breastbone, the world making more of itself because making more of itself was the only thing the world had ever known how to do. The terraces went in. The mill turned. The bridge at Hallow stayed broken because the man whose business it had been to mend a bridge was gone with the order that had employed him, and so a man named Corliss who had been a mason before the war took it into his own head one morning to go and look at it, and came back and said it could be done with the village's own backs and a fortnight, and there had followed a long argument behind the mill about whether the village owed Hallow a bridge, and who would feed the men who built it, and the argument had been ugly and slow and gone on for three evenings, and at the end of it the bridge was going to be built. That was how things got decided now. Slowly, and from below, and badly, and they got decided.

She watched it from the high wall that closed the gardens at their top, where she still went most evenings to read the cold edge of the world, and the reading was easier now, the rim leaning back off the warmth the smallest degree at a time, easing to its edge, and she stood up there with the whole even traffic of the world coming and going across her and watched a village three evenings deep in a fight about a bridge, and did not go down to settle it, and the not-going-down was hers.

* * *

The men came up from the city in the third week, and that was the morning she could have ruled the world and did not.

There were five of them, and they had come by the long road, riding the line to its broken end and walking the remainder, and they had the look of men who had argued the whole journey about who would speak and had not settled it. They were not soldiers and they were not the worst kind, the kind who wanted a stronger hand. They were the middling kind, the frightened reasonable kind, men who had run things under the old order in small careful ways and now stood in a world with the top gone out of it and the food in the carts spoiling and no one to say where the carts went, and they had heard, the way a thing like that is always heard, that the girl who remade the world was alive in a valley a day and a half down the slow southern line, and they had found her at the long table behind the mill on a spring morning with flour on her sleeve from helping the miller, which was not how any of them had pictured her.

She knew what they had come for before the eldest of them got through the throat-clearing of it. She had felt it walking toward her down the road for the length of an hour, five frightened cores climbing the valley with a thing they wanted on them like a smell.

The eldest got it out at last. They wanted her to come to the city. Not to rule it, he said quickly, seeing something in her face, though he did not know what he was seeing, because she had put nothing in her face. Only to settle it. To say how it should be. The factions would not stop fighting because no one among them had the standing to make the others stop, and she had the standing, she had the only standing left in the world, she had made the world with her own hand, and a world that one hand had made would hold still to be ordered by that same hand, and would they not all be saved a great deal of blood if the hand that made them would only, please, say how things should go. He was not a wicked man. He was a tired man asking the most natural thing in the world. He was asking her to be the top of it, because there had always been a top of it, in all of their lives there had always been someone at the top of it, and the absence of a top was a thing none of them knew how to stand inside, and here, ready-made, blessed past argument, was a girl who could be one.

And she could have. That was the thing she stood inside, that morning, with the flour on her sleeve, that none of the five men in front of her could see. She could feel every living core there is. The whole even traffic of the world came and went across her, and she was the door it all leaned on, and if she had wished to she could have leaned the world the way the world leaned on her. She had not a single doubt that it would work. She could go to the city and the factions would stop fighting, because she would say stop, and they would stop, the way a thing made holds still to be ordered by the hand that made it, and the carts would go where she said the carts went, and there would be no more killings that left no wound, and she would do all of it, she knew, for good reasons, out of the part of her that did the arithmetic, because the arithmetic would come out that more lived if

she ruled than if she did not, and the arithmetic would be right.

It was the most monstrous thing anyone had ever offered her, and it was offered by a kind tired man with his hat in his hands, and that was exactly the danger, the whole of the danger, because no rule of her mother's had ever warned her about the monstrous thing that arrives kind, asking please, dressed up as the obvious good. She had crossed a continent learning that the free good thing is how you lose yourself, and here it was, the freest and the most good and the most certainly herself-ending of all of them, and she could feel the cold working part of her reaching for it, *more would live*, and she stood at the long table and did not let her hand close on it.

"No," she said.

The eldest blinked. He had been braced for a great many answers and that flat small one was not among them.

"You don't understand," he said. "We're not asking you to take a crown. Only to —"

"I understand exactly what you're asking," she said, and heard her own voice do the careful flat thing, the certainty laid over the part of her that wanted, very much, the easy good. "You're asking me to decide for everyone, because I'm the hand that made it. And I could. That's the part you should be more afraid of than you are. I could go to your city and stop your war by saying stop, and I'd be right, and more people would live, and in a year there would be a top of the world again and it would be me, and I'd have stopped fighting being one before I was finished being one, because no one ever does. The last people who held a hand over everyone's chest and decided what was good for them, I spent a year cleaning up after. I will not be the next ones. Not even to do good. Especially not to do good." She put the flour-dusted hand flat on the long table, where Alice taught,

hand over hand, the way that was theirs at the end of it. "You'll have to decide it yourselves. All of you, in the mud, frightened, badly, the way this valley decided about a bridge. It's slower than a hand from on high and it's uglier and people will die in the deciding who wouldn't die under me. I know that. I did the arithmetic. And the answer is still no, because a world that gets its deciding handed down from the one who made it is not a world, it's a thing that one hand owns, and I did not spend everything I spent to own you. I made a world so there'd be a world. What you do with it is yours."

She left the rest unsaid, the true bottom of it, which was that the day she said yes to that was the day she stopped being herself and became the thing she fought, and that the one thing keeping her from being it was that she kept saying no, every time, especially when it would be good. She kept that part because it was hers, and because saying it aloud would have made it sound like a virtue, and it was not a virtue, it was a daily refusal of a thing she wanted, and a thing you have to refuse daily is not a virtue, it is a discipline, and a discipline is not for saying out loud to frightened men with their hats in their hands.

They went away down the valley in the afternoon, the five of them, with nothing she had given them except the one thing they had not come for, which was the news that no one was coming to save them and they were going to have to save themselves, and she watched them go from the high wall, and felt the cold in her go on quietly insisting, for an hour after they were out of sight, that *more would have lived*, and did not act on it, and the not-acting was the thing, the whole thing, the only thing, that kept the hand on the wall hers.

Amber came up beside her at the wall while the men were still a dark knot going down the road. She had heard the whole of it from the mill doorway.

"You wanted to," Amber said. It was not a question and it was not an accusation. It was Amber doing the thing Amber did, which was naming the true thing at the start and not at noon.

"Yes," Viridia said.

"For good reasons."

"The best ones."

Amber watched the men go a while, the black-nailed hand loose on the wall. "That's how I tell," she said finally, which made no sense until she said the rest of it. "You asked me once how you tell the difference, from the inside, between you and them. The ones who hold a hand over everyone for their own good. I never had a good answer. I've got one now." She nodded down at the road. "Them, they'd have said yes. They came up here hoping you'd say yes. And the difference between you and the thing you're scared of being isn't that you don't want it. You want it. You wanted it just now, on those reasons, I watched you want it. The difference is you said no anyway. That's the whole difference. It's not in the wanting. It's in the no." She pushed off the wall. "You keep saying the no. I'll keep watching to make sure you do. That's the arrangement. That was always the arrangement."

* * *

This is who stayed, when the spring had got its feet under it, and who went.

Drake had gone north in the first days, to the high passes, to be the old one on the rock while a range full of dragons remembered how to be themselves, and she felt him up there, small and far on the kinship that was only friendship

and was enough, and once, on a clear evening, she felt him do the thing dragons do that is half flight and half grief and entirely loud, off a high rock, alone, and knew he was all right in the way Drake was ever all right, which was loudly and at a height and on his own terms.

The Dangris had come to her on a grey morning at the top of the gardens before they went, shadowless at the seam where the cold leaned thinnest, and the one in the middle had said, in the voice that was not a voice so much as a meaning arriving where a voice would have, *The standing is done. The thing we came to stand against has gone back to its edge. The thing that called us has become a thing with no need of calling.* She had reached to the Heart of the Spear at her collarbone and not taken it off, because it was not hers to give back, it was theirs to release, and they had released it, the warmth of the pact in the stone going quiet under her fingers the way Lor-ar's bond had gone quiet, not broken, only open now onto something with no further use for it. *We will come again,* the meaning had said, which was what it had said to her at Hazel when she was fourteen and had not understood that a thing that says *we will come again* is not promising a season or a year, *when there is a standing worth the standing.* And then the cold did not lean thinnest anywhere on the wall, and they were gone the way the Dangris went, which was the way a thing goes that was never quite there in the first place. Lor-ar was a quiet open place in the forest of the world, released a year since, not called, not needed, *little one* still hanging in him the way it hung in her.

And Amber stayed, who had survived the east road on purpose and appointed herself the keeper of the one thing she trusted no one else to keep, and took it as her standing work to watch a girl with enough power to own the world keep saying no to owning it, which was, Viridia thought, the truest pact anyone had made with her, truer than the spear,

because no one had given Amber a pendant for it, she had simply decided.

And Alice stayed, warm all the way down now. The laugh had come back to her in the second week, over nothing, at the long table behind the mill, when the miller's elder girl had got her bowl to do the thing it was supposed to do and been so startled at herself that she had knocked it into the lap of the man beside her, and the man had come up off the bench with a yell out of all proportion to a lapful of water, and Alice had looked at him dripping and outraged and the girl horrified behind her hands, and laughed. It came up out of her the way the crooked tooth came up, a coal banked so low for so long that Viridia had stopped expecting the coal under it to catch, and it caught, the whole warm wide laugh of it, the laugh that had come back across the year only in pieces until that afternoon, and the wet man could not hold his anger against it, and the long table laughed. Viridia had stood at the edge of it with the spring coming and going across her and watched her oldest friend laugh warm all the way down at last, and the burning had come up behind her eyes, except this one was not grief, and she had looked down at the wet table until it passed and then laughed out loud with the rest of them, which was a thing she was allowed, which no rule of her mother's had ever forbidden. Alice did not know, and would not be told, that her core had been remade by the hand of the girl across the table from her; Viridia carried that unaskedness the way she carried everything, in the low place. But Alice knew the thing that was enough, which was that the warmth was back and she was a healer again and not only a survivor, and that much passed between them across a wet table, and it was, Viridia thought, more than she had ever let herself hope to be standing in the middle of.

And Raizen stayed, close and rooted, learning to be a person one ordinary infuriating thing at a time. He had got the hang of his feet. He had not got the hang of buttons, the small ones, and swore at them in a language that had no business being used on a shirt. He had got the hang of an apple, finally, eating it the whole way down past the middle he had studied for a year and not understood, the unripe place between the flower and the rot, the human part. It was not as complicated as he had made it, he said around a mouthful of it; you simply ate the middle along with the rest and let it be part of the thing. He looked at her when he said it in a way that meant he was not talking about an apple, and she let him have that, because he was right, and because he was learning. The prismatic thing he could not stop being still ran faint off his fingers when he forgot to bank it, in the evenings, when he was tired, a thread of every colour there is, the only place left in him the dragon showed.

* * *

Spring came up the valley a second time on her watch, and this one she let herself feel the whole way.

She had not, the first one. The first spring after the cavern she had stood on the wall and counted it the way she counted everything that year, a grief and a wonder folded so close together she could not get a knife between them. She had been new to the weight then, and a person new to a weight holds it stiff-armed, all the way out from the body, and counts the cost of every minute she holds it, because she does not yet trust that her arms will go on holding it without her watching them do it. This spring she trusted her arms. That was the only difference, and it was the whole difference. She let the lambs be lambs and the bloom be bloom and did not do the column on any of it, because she had learned the trick at last, the human trick, the one she

had told Raizen on this wall a year back and not been able to do herself: you do not look down the whole drop. You look at the stair you are on.

He had taught her, that first spring, by asking her the question no one else alive could ask her. He had sat on the garden wall with the apple core going brown in his hand and asked her how long, and she had told him long, longer than the tree, longer than Corliss, longer than the miller's girl with the bowl, and he had built it one post at a time the way he built everything, *she'll get old, and we won't*, until he reached the sum at the bottom of the column and asked the real thing under it. *How many of them. Will we watch go.* He had not been counting years. He had been counting people, the way you only learn to count them when you have just got hands and a face and a span you can feel the end of, and have begun, for the first time, to love things that end nearer than you do. And she had given it to him plain, because the bond would not let her gentle a true thing into a smaller one without his feeling her do it and trusting her the less. *All of them*, she had said. *Everyone we love who isn't on the far end of this. We'll outlast the whole of it. We'll bury them. We'll bury the people who bury them. And then we'll go on.*

How do you carry a thing with no bottom, he had asked, and she had told him the only answer she had, which was that you do not carry it all at once. You carry the nearest one. You love Amber while Amber's here to be loved, the whole of it, like there's no column under her, and when the door takes her you carry that one, just that one, all the way across, and you don't carry the next one until the next one comes. The column is only unbearable if you stand at the top of it and look down the whole drop. You look at the stair you're on. She had heard it as she said it and almost laughed at herself, because she had spent two years learning to do exactly the opposite, to look down the whole drop of the world and read

the cold at the bottom of it, and here she was telling a year-old man to do the human thing instead.

And he had done the thing for her that no one else had ever had it in them to do. *You don't have to do the dry face with me*, he had said, setting it down between them like a thing he had worked out and wanted to give her. *With everyone else, yes. It's the same as me banking the colours so I don't frighten the miller. It's a thing you do so the world can stand to be near you. But I'm the far end. The colours don't frighten me and the wet face doesn't either. You can put it down, with me.* And she had let her eyes burn and not looked away to the gardens, had looked at him instead, and had not wept, because she never did, because that door had been opened the one sanctioned time and would not open the whole way again, not even here, not even against the kindness of it; the guardrail held. But she had let the burning stand in her eyes where he could see it and not turned the dry wall onto him, and that, between the two of them, with the very long way off in front of them and only each other at the far end of it, was the whole of what weeping was for, and was enough. *All right*, she had said, when she could. *With you. Just with you.* And he had said, *that's the arrangement*, which was Amber's word, taken off Amber the way he took words off everyone he loved, magpie, building his human speech out of the scraps of the people he loved, and he would have it on his tongue in a hundred years, a borrowed word kept warm in the mouth of a creature the years would not touch, and they both knew it, and let it be true.

* * *

Down by the mill the light was lit, and that was Alice, working late over the bowls of still water with someone who could not yet hold both halves of the gift, teaching the slow way that was theirs at the end of it. Forty years of that, the

column said, give or take, that and Alice's own stubborn heart, and forty years was a long time and was nothing, both, at once, and Viridia had stopped trying to make those two facts lie down quiet together, because they would not, ever, and had decided that the not-lying-down was simply the texture of loving a thing that ends when you do not.

Amber came out into the lit square of the mill doorway and stood with the black-nailed hand up against the frame, looking up the dark slope toward the wall. She did it every evening, the keeper checking the one thing she would let no other hand mind, and Viridia raised a hand off the cold stone so Amber would see her there and not have to climb to know it.

Tonight she did not go in. Tonight she came up the slope.

She came the way Amber came at anything that needed saying, head a little down, working out the words on the way up so they would come out in the flat plain register she trusted and not the warm one she did not, and she got to the top of the steps and put both forearms on the wall beside Viridia's and looked out at the valley with her, and for a while the two of them said nothing at all, which was a thing they were good at, the wordless company that did the work of talk between people who had long since run out of need for it.

"There's grey," Amber said, at last. "At the temple. Found it this morning in the glass." She put it the way she put any fact, the way she would have noted the carts were late or the river was up. "I'm not telling you for you to do anything about it. There's nothing to do about it. I'm telling you because." She stopped. Worked it. Amber, who had questions that grew teeth, had never once had an easy time with the ones that grew them on the inside. "Because you're going to watch it, the whole of it, the grey and the rest of what comes after the grey, and I'd rather you watched it with

me telling you it's happening than have you reading it off me from up here on the wall like I'm one of your births and going-outs. I'd rather hand it to you. While I've still got the hand to hand it with."

Viridia looked at her. The grey was there, now that Amber had named it, a thread or two of it at the temple in the last of the light, and she had read it off Amber a week ago and filed it and said nothing, because saying it was Amber's to do and not hers, and here Amber was doing it, on purpose, the way Amber did everything, by walking up the hard slope and putting the true small thing down on the wall between them.

"All right," Viridia said.

"That's all. That's the whole of it. I'm going grey and you're not, and one of us is going to walk out of this and the other one's going to stand on the wall and feel it happen, and we both know which, and I'm not going to pretend we don't, because pretending's a thing you do for people you don't trust to take the truth, and I trust you to take it." She turned her head. The fierce ordinary fear was right there in her face, undisguised, the way she let it be undisguised only with the people she had decided were hers. "Don't carry it early. You hear me? I can feel you wanting to. You've got that look you get, the looking-down-the-drop look. I've got years. I've got a lot of years, the way ordinary people count years. Don't go spending them grieving while I'm still here to be a nuisance in. Carry me when I'm gone. Not before."

"I know the rule," Viridia said. "You taught it to me. The stair you're on."

"I taught it to you." Amber almost smiled, which on Amber was a great loud thing held down to almost nothing. "God help the world. I'm out here teaching the door of everything how to be a person." She put her hand, the black-nailed one, over Viridia's on the cold stone, briefly, hard, the arrangement, and took it back before either of

them could make it into more than it was. "Right," she said, which was the word she ended things with, and pushed off the wall, and went back down the slope to the lit doorway and the warm, and did not look back, because looking back was a thing you did at endings and this was not one, this was only a Tuesday, or near enough, and Amber had stopped looking back at Tuesdays a long time ago.

Viridia watched her go. Her eyes did the thing, once, on the slope, with only the dark for a witness, and she let them, and looked at the lit doorway until they stopped, and gave it no tally, because a burning you looked at the dark until it passed had never once counted and never would.

* * *

Raizen came up after, careful with his feet on the steps, the way he was still careful two springs on, because feet had been the last thing he learned to trust and a thing learned last is a thing held carefully forever. He stood at the far end of the wall, near, not on her, the way she wanted him, and held his peace, and the bond carried the rest of it without a word spent, Amber's grey and the slope and the looking-at-the-dark, all of it running warm down the lit line between them, sparing her the lifting of any of it into speech.

"You did the count again," he said. Not a question. "And you got off it. At the stair."

"I got off it."

"You're getting better at the getting-off." He said it the way he reported any small true mechanical fact, a button done up right, a knot held. "You used to need me to do it. You don't need me to anymore."

"I always need you to," she said. "I just don't always have to use you to."

He turned the dark ordinary eyes on her, the eyes that still surprised her every evening for not being lightning, and

was quiet a moment, working the difference between needing a post and having to lean on it, and she watched him get hold of it and set it down on the wall with the rest of what he had got hold of about being alive among people who ended.

Below them the valley went on. A child was born somewhere far west and she carried it across the sill, glad. An old core somewhere east went gently out and she carried that too, and held the door at the width that let the world keep what it had and lose what it must, neither leaning to close the going-out nor leaning to force the coming-in, because the world was borrowed and not owned and the not-leaning was the whole of the lease. She had made the world with her own hand, and a thing you make is the most owned thing there is, and the whole danger lived in that; so she made herself think of it the other way, the true way, the way that kept the hand on the wall hers, that she had not made the world to own it but so that there would be a world, and a thing you make so that it can be itself is a thing you lend your hand to and then take your hand off. There was a tear in the rim that night, west of the let-go country, and she could have leaned the door and closed it and saved, the arithmetic said, eleven lives across the coming month, and she let it lean back its own slow degree instead, and let the eleven take their chance, and would carry across the sill the ones who did not make it, because a world whose tears she closed by leaning was a world she owned, and she had not spent everything she spent to own it. The almond tree that Edrick's hand had set in a spring before the war stirred its new leaves in the warm dark, fifty years gone and the tree going on. To the west, in the let-go country, a tired clever sort of trouble went on being trouble in its own low way, and she felt it faintly, as she had every evening for two springs,

and she left it alone, as she left the bridge alone and the city alone, because she was the door and not the world's hand.

It felt, this time, like an ending. Not very nearly. The whole of it. The war was two springs gone and the world was borrowed and held and the cold leaned back off it a degree a year, to its own edge, with no help wanted from her. The men in the broken city were learning, slowly, badly, from below, to grow their deciding out of their own middle, and made a worse job of it than she could have made and a truer one, because a thing a people decides for itself is a thing that holds, and a thing decided for them from a wall is only a thing that waits to be undecided. The people she loved were lit and warm below her and one of them was going grey, and that was the right order of things, the natural one, the column running the way a column should, and the one who could carry the span with her was at the far end of the wall, near, not on her, rooted, the warmth she was tied to. There was nothing left undone that her hand was the only hand for. She had refused, and would go on refusing every evening for the whole of the very long way off, to be the one who owned the world, and the refusing had a shape now, a worn comfortable daily shape a person can live inside, and she lived inside it, and it had not made her smaller and she had not become the other one, the kind reasonable one with a hand over every chest, and she knew it the way she knew the births from the deaths, by the plain fact that she was, this evening, still saying the no.

She stood in it and let it be over. She let the long thing be done. There is a kind of evening, after the long thing is done, that has the still gold weight of a last page to it, and she stood in the gold weight of it and let it ask nothing further of her than to be stood in, and the stars came out over the long view, mile on mile of it, year on year, more than either of them could see the end of, which was the point, which was

exactly the point, and for one whole held breath of an evening on the wall the world was finished with her, and she with it, and it was enough, was more than enough, was very nearly everything.

* * *

Far to the west, past the wall that had stopped a war, past the capital that had learned to lose its head and live, in the let-go country where the maps gave up and the names ran out, there was a low stone room with the shutters drawn against an evening it had no use for.

A man had worked in this room once and did not work in it anymore. His chalk was still here, a stub of it worn to nothing on the bench, and his volumes, the bound old ones with the deep severed-half mathematics in them, stacked the way a careful clever man stacks the things he loves, and the slate he had drawn his last working on, scrubbed and drawn again and scrubbed, the ghosts of a hundred attempts grey under the newest one. The room had been waiting the way the cavern waited, patient, indifferent to which person walked into it.

A young man was in it now. Ink-stained, narrow, near nineteen and looking older than that the way a person looks who has carried a true account out of a bad place and could not put it down once he had it. He had come back west because the account was not finished, because a thing half told is a thing that festers, and the festering of it had walked him back across a continent to the one room where the rest of it might be found, the room of the man he had told not to, at every fire, the whole way west, a lifetime ago, and been right, and hated being right.

He had come to read the slate, not to work it, the way you read a dead man's hand to know him better than you managed to while he lived. But the volumes lay open and the

lamp was lit and the old severed-half mathematics waited there the way water waits in front of a thirst, and he had carried both halves of the gift since the morning the world's chest changed, the same as everyone, and he was nineteen, near enough, and a thing he had told a clever desperate man to leave well alone had a way of getting into the one who told it, the way a warning you give is a road you have learned the shape of.

He drew the symbol.

He felt it take, the way Marick must have felt it take at the cavern mouth, a clean line where a hand had been, and the slate went cold under his fingers, cold the way no slate is cold, and the air at the heart of the working thinned and stopped being air and became a margin, a low door no bigger than a hearth opening onto a dark that was not the dark of the room, a dark the lamp would not reach into, a dark that was the absence of the room rather than the shadow of it.

And out of the dark, before he could lift his hand, before he could so much as decide to be afraid, something came.

He did not see the whole of it and was glad afterward, the way the eye is merciful, for not having seen the whole of it. He saw a length of it, dark and wet and too smooth, reaching out of the low cold door across his bench toward the lamp and the warmth and the man, the way a thing reaches that has felt a warmth from the far side of a wall and means to have it; and Fen did the only thing a person does, which is the thing the body does before the person decides anything at all. He let go of the working.

The door did not close gently. It snapped. The margin slammed shut on itself the way a breath held too long goes out in a rush when the holding fails, and the length of the thing that had come through it was on the wrong side of the slam when it shut, and the door took it, clean, the way the

cavern had taken Marick, asking nothing; and the severed end of it dropped onto the bench among the chalk and the open volumes, dark and wet and ended, and lay there not moving, a thing cut off from whatever owned it, and on the far side of the shut door, in the dark the lamp would not reach, something that was not in the room any longer made a sound that was not a sound, and was gone.

Fen did not stay to look at it.

He went out of the low stone room into the let-go country at a dead run, the lamp left burning, the account unfinished and a worse account begun, west to east, the wrong way, the way home, running the way a person runs from a thing he cannot tell anyone about because there are no words yet made for it; and the running was the whole of him, a narrow ink-stained shape going flat out across a darkening country under the first stars, alive, and meaning to stay alive, and carrying out of that room the one true thing he had: that a door he had opened had let something reach for him, and that the door had shut on it, and that the door had not been the only side of itself, that there had been a far side, and that on the far side there had been something, and that the something was still there.

He ran. The stars came out over him the way they came out over everyone.

* * *

On the wall, a quarter of a country east, Viridia felt it.

Not the door. Not the running boy. She could not feel a door any more than she could feel a window; doors were a thing of the world, and she was the door of the world, and the world's small doors were beneath the grain of her sight. And she could feel the boy no more than she felt any of the millions, one warmth among the even traffic, too far and too

small to lift out of the whole breathing tide of the living that crossed her sill without ceasing.

What she felt was something else. The thing on the far side.

It came up under her the way a wrongness comes up under a tongue, a place in the even breathing tide where the tide was not. She had felt every kind of warmth there is. She had felt them come up bright and outrageous and glad, and felt them go gently out, and felt them lean toward one another far west in the dark, and felt the dippings and the steadyings and the whole even traffic of the world coming and going across her for two springs without a single gap in it that she had not understood; the world was full, full all the way to its borrowed edges, full of cores the way the dark is full of stars, and she had thought, in the worn comfortable way a person thinks a thing she has stopped examining, that fullness was the shape of everything she could feel, that there was warmth and there was the cold past the rim, presence and the clean abstract negative of it, and nothing between.

This was neither.

It was not a warmth, and it was not the cold edge of everything, the patient empty counterpart she had learned to feel leaning back off the world the slow way. It was a small particular place, a there, near enough that it had a direction even if she could not have named the direction, west, low, faint, gone almost before it came; and in that small particular place the even tide of the living did not lean and did not lean back and did not run full. In that small particular place there was a shape exactly the size and silence of a core, with all the room in the world made ready around it for a warmth to sit, and no warmth sitting in it. A held place. An emptiness with edges. A socket. A place where a core should be, where the grain of everything said a

core should be, and where there was not one, and never had been, and the not-one was not the cold past the rim and was not a death she had carried across the sill and was not anything the two whole halves of everything she could feel had a name for.

She came off the gold stillness of the evening in one lurch, the way your foot comes down on a stair that is not there in the dark.

Raizen felt her go. She felt him feel it, the doorpost snapping taut at the far end of the bond, his head coming round, the dark ordinary eyes finding her. "What," he said. "What is it. You went —" He had no word for where she had gone. He had felt the floor tilt in her and had nothing to put it on.

She stood very still on the wall and reached for it again, carefully, the way you reach a tongue back toward the place a tooth was, and it was already fading, already going under the even tide the way a stone goes under a closing water, the fullness of the world flowing back in over the small held empty place until she could no longer be sure she had felt it, could no longer find the there it had had, only the memory of the wrongness of it, the socket, the room made ready and nothing in it. She turned her face west, toward the let-go country, where a tired clever sort of trouble went on in its low way and she left it alone, and she searched the dark with the sight that read the rim of the world, and the dark gave her nothing back, because what she had felt was not anything the sight could read; the sight read cores and the cold the cores were measured against, and this had been neither, this had been a place where a core should be and was not, and you cannot see an absence by looking at it. You can only feel the shape of where it should have been.

"I don't know," she said.

It was the truth, and she heard herself say it in the flat hard certainty she used for the things she was sure of, and felt the wrongness of using that voice on a thing she was not sure of at all, and could not help it, because the voice was the only one she had for the rim of the world and the rim of the world had just shown her a thing it had never shown her in two springs of holding it, something belonging neither to the warmth nor to the cold, a thing with edges, somewhere out past the borrowed world she had given her whole self to hold whole; and she did not know what it was, and she did not know where, and she did not know whose, and she only knew, standing on the wall in the gold ruin of an evening that had so very nearly been an ending, the one plain fact the sight had handed her and then taken back before she could hold it: that somewhere, far off, in no direction she could keep, there was a place where a core should be and was not, and that the world was not, after all, finished with her yet.

About the Author



Post Peleos writes character-driven fantasy about quiet people in loud worlds — stories that love to tease as much as they wound, and never quite stop wondering what waits out beyond the stars. *The Saeren Chronicles* is his debut series.

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